

Identity in Journalism

Evidence from News Reporting of Violence Against Women

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Abstract

Does it matter who writes the news? I study this question by looking at gender differences in reporting on violence against women in Italy. Matching the universe of murders with female victims in 2006–2022 to newspaper articles, I construct indexes for two reporting narratives: victim-centered narratives, which focus on the victim and the violence she experienced and point to support resources, and perpetrator-centered narratives, which focus on motives such as jealousy or a fit of rage. I show that female journalists use more victim-centered and fewer perpetrator-centered narratives, exploiting the conditionally random assignment of reporters to crimes within newsrooms to account for selection in the stories covered. Combining reporter assignment with province-level readership in a staggered difference-in-differences design, I show that greater exposure to female reporters after a murder raises calls to the national helpline for violence against women. An online experiment identifies the mechanism: victim-centered narratives shift norms around help-seeking. It also reveals potential engagement costs, as these narratives decrease engagement among men but help retain female readers. The characteristics of those who report the news are thus a relevant supply-side determinant of both news content and reader behavior.

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“You are the interpreters to the women of the country as to what goes on politically in the legislative national life, and also what the social and personal life is at the White House”

— Eleanor Roosevelt at her first women-only press conference (March 6, 1933)

1 Introduction

During her tenure as First Lady, Eleanor Roosevelt held 348 press conferences exclusively for female journalists, on the premise that women were better intermediaries for delivering news to audiences. Nearly a century later, many newsrooms have been changing their composition along similar lines, with outlets like the *New York Times* markedly increasing their shares of women and minority reporters over the past decade.¹ At the same time, the rise of news influencers, a model in which a consumer subscribes directly to a person rather than to an outlet (Forman-Katz et al., 2025), has moved the individual reporter to the center of how information reaches the public. But does it matter who writes the news?

So far, the drivers of news content have been studied mainly on the demand side and at the ownership-level supply side, by looking at differences in political ideology across outlets that cater to readers’ or owners’ preferences (Puglisi and Snyder, 2015). This work rests on the implicit assumption that reporters’ incentives are aligned with those of their employers. In reality, journalists retain substantial discretion over how they frame a story and may face different incentives. Their characteristics and preferences could therefore be a supply-side determinant of news content and a novel channel through which identity persuades readers at scale.

This paper shows that journalists’ gender shapes news content, with female and male journalists using different narratives to report on otherwise similar crimes, and that this, in turn, shapes readers’ behavior. I study this in the context of violence against women (VAW) in Italy. Here, gender identity is especially salient: these crimes are overwhelmingly perpetrated by men against women, creating the clear in-group/out-group structure under which theory predicts reporters’ gender to shape coverage (Tajfel et al., 1971; Akerlof and Kranton, 2000). Italy is also a particularly suitable setting, as VAW is highly salient in public and media discourse.² At the same time, resources meant to counter it, like anti-violence centers or helplines, remain underused, with only a small fraction of women who experience violence ever turning to them.³ Because help-seeking has proven hard to shift through policy alone, I ask what role the media can play. Exploiting

¹The *New York Times* increased the share of female and minority journalists by 10 percentage points (2024 DEI report). Similarly, *The Atlantic* and the *Washington Post* increased the share of minority reporters by 10 and 5 percentage points, respectively (The Atlantic 2025 DEI report, The Washington Post’s Workforce Demographics).

²In 2024 alone, approximately 50,000 women were killed worldwide by intimate partners or family members (UN, 2024). In Italy, the share of women murdered by a current or former intimate partner has increased by 10 percentage points over the past decade, and despite having one of the lowest overall homicide rates in the European Union, Italy records the highest number of murders of women (Statista, 2022a; Statista, 2022b).

³A survey conducted in 2025 (ISTAT, 2025) showed that 13.3% of the interviewed women who experience any type of violence reported it to any institution or specialized service, and only 8.7% contacted an anti-violence center or helpline.

quasi-random variation in exposure to female reporters and a pre-registered experiment, I study whether these identity-driven differences in reporting affect victims' help-seeking behavior.

First, I show that female and male journalists covering the same crimes report them using different narratives. A central challenge in doing so is measuring reporting style meaningfully. Existing outlet-level measures of slant or topic selection are too coarse to capture the narrative choices that reporter identity is most likely to influence. Instead, drawing on guidelines for VAW reporting and theoretical work in psychology and communication studies (Henley et al., 1995; Carlyle et al., 2008), I construct two narrative indexes in a novel dataset of news articles covering murders with female victims in Italy between 2006 and 2022. These narratives capture the gendered nature of the crime: victim-centered (VC) narratives focus on the victim and contextualize the crime within the broader phenomenon of VAW (*"after twenty years of violence and threat"*). Perpetrator-centered (PC) narratives, in contrast, foreground perpetrators' motives, such as jealousy or fits of rage (*"intense disputes fueled by jealousy and accusation regarding her relationship with another man"*).

To isolate gender differences in reporting, I compare articles by female and male reporters within the same newsroom. In Italian newsrooms, the assignment of journalists to crime stories is orthogonal to crime characteristics, addressing the potential selection of reporters into crime stories. Driven by the urgency of quickly covering a crime, newsrooms assign reporters based on work schedules and geographic proximity, generating quasi-random variation in the gender of the reporter covering a given crime. I confirm this by showing that crime characteristics are not predicted by reporters' gender, age, and experience. Finally, to address potential correlations between reporters' schedules and crime characteristics, I also compare female and male reporters who cover the same crime.

The results reveal significant gender differences in reporting among journalists, with female journalists using more victim-centered narratives and fewer perpetrator-centered ones. On average, they score 0.12 standard deviations higher on the VC index and 0.05 standard deviations lower on the PC index than their male counterparts. Breaking these differences down, women are 20% more likely to call a murder a femicide and 80% more likely to mention help resources, while men are 15% and 10% more likely to attribute the crime to a fit of rage or jealousy, respectively. These differences remain stable even when I include crime-event fixed effects and when I restrict the sample to the first articles about each crime.

I rationalize these findings through a model of identity-motivated journalists. If reporters cared only about the monetary returns from readership, they would converge on the same profit-maximizing narrative, and no systematic gender differences would arise. Differences emerge when reporters also value the utility of their in-group: they may then favor narratives that benefit or are preferred by their own group, even at a monetary cost, or if it reduces out-group engagement. Therefore, in the model, monetary and identity-driven incentives reinforce each other when in-group narratives also maximize readers' engagement, but conflict when they do not.

However, many other mechanisms could explain the gender differences. I start by ruling out the possibility that reporters' gender proxies for other characteristics, like age, outlets' political lean-

ing, and regional gender norms. I also exclude the possibility of women being better journalists or more empathetic toward victims in general by finding no gender differences in reporting on male homicides and in general reporting and writing skills. The differences also do not reflect greater VAW expertise, differential access to sources, or the preferences of female crime desk editors, leaving reporters' identity-driven preferences for in-group narratives and monetary incentives as the main candidate explanations. Separating these two requires evidence on the readers themselves, which motivates the second part of the paper.

Do readers respond to these reporting differences? In the second part of the paper, I ask whether they change readers' behavior, studying the effect of exposure to female versus male journalists on help-seeking, measured as weekly calls to the national gender-based violence helpline. Identification exploits the quasi-random assignment of first reporters to crimes and the timing and location of murders as sources of exogeneity. To ensure the former, I construct the treatment variable using only the first five articles for each newspaper and crime, focusing on reporting in the two weeks after a crime, before editorial preferences can influence reporter selection. I then estimate the effect of early exposure to articles by female reporters, weighted by provincial newspaper circulation, using a generalized difference-in-differences design with continuous treatment.

The results show that helpline calls increase more after a larger share of articles comes from female reporters, suggesting that gender identity not only shapes news content but also meaningfully changes readers' behavior. Specifically, one additional article written by a woman for each crime and newspaper leads to a 17% increase in helpline calls, roughly one additional call per province and week. These estimates are robust to alternative estimators (Chaisemartin and D'Haultfoeuille, 2024) and are not driven by general crime trends or by female reporters generating more coverage of the crime. The effect of female coverage is null in placebo exercises using randomly timed murders and actual male-victim murders, and it survives a triple-difference design that adds victim gender as a third source of variation, showing that it is specific to female victims.

I provide suggestive evidence that the effect operates through narratives rather than through readers responding to the female byline. Replacing the female-exposure measure with narrative-specific ones shows that VC narratives drive the rise in calls, while PC ones do not. Similarly, the effect is concentrated among female reporters who use VC narratives and is absent among those who do not. Victim-centered narratives could, however, raise help-seeking through two distinct mechanisms: by making readers aware of available resources (Daponte et al., 1999; Bettinger et al., 2012), or by shifting their perception of help-seeking as a common and accepted behavior (Bursztyn et al., 2020b). These channels cannot be reliably separated in the observational data, so I use a pre-registered online experiment to help distinguish them.

I recruit 1,508 Italian respondents and assign them to read the same newspaper article about a murder, randomizing the narrative: perpetrator-centered or one of two victim-centered alternatives (providing information on resources or pre-existing violence). I find that VC narratives increase respondents' perceived prevalence of help-seeking among VAW victims, but only when describing the victim's prior experience of violence and help-seeking attempts, with a stronger effect for

women. By contrast, providing information on help resources does not raise perceived help-seeking and even lowers perceptions of VAW prevalence. I read this as consistent with a social norms channel: learning that other women undergo violence and seek help increases help-seeking stakes and lowers its perceived cost (Bursztyn et al., 2020b). Turning to attitudes, both narratives increase empathy for the victim, while only VC ones reduce empathy for the perpetrator.

Finally, I use the experiment to investigate readers' preferences over narratives, providing evidence on the monetary returns a reporter faces from each. I measure two forms of engagement: retention—the probability of using the same newspaper again—and click-through—the probability of clicking on a linked article. I find that victim-centered narratives reduce click-through engagement among male readers and that perpetrator-centered narratives reduce declared retention for female readers. These results suggest that reporters might be better at targeting in-group readers and that monetary and identity motives are likely to reinforce each other.

This paper contributes to the literature on the determinants of news content and media narratives. On the one hand, existing papers have highlighted the role of demand-side factors in influencing media slant, like readers' political preferences (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2010; Puglisi and Snyder, 2011), and how these can lead to different degrees of slant depending on the characteristics of the media market (Mullainathan and Shleifer, 2005; Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2006).⁴ On the other hand, works focusing on supply-side factors have mainly provided evidence on the influence of media ownership (Durante and Knight, 2012; Martin and McCrain, 2019; Mastroiocco and Ornaghi, 2025) or media guidelines (Djourelouva, 2023).

I shift the focus to another component of news production: journalists. The few empirical studies focusing on journalists' contribution to media slant have provided evidence of a small effect of journalists' ideology on news slant compared to the role of outlets (Hassell et al., 2020; Boxell and Conway, 2022; Cagé et al., 2025).⁵ In this paper, I move away from political ideology and instead focus on gender identity. Contrary to the findings of these studies, this paper provides novel evidence showing that journalists' gender is the main driver of crime narratives about VAW and that these differences also persist within outlets with different political alignments.⁶

This paper also contributes to the literature on the effects of media on readers' behaviors and attitudes by providing, to the best of my knowledge, the first evidence of the effects of reporter-specific narratives. A central finding of this literature is that politically slanted media affects individuals' political preferences, whether through exposure to different outlets (DellaVigna and Kaplan, 2007; Ladd and Lenz, 2009; Foos and Bischof, 2022) or to different topics (Chiang and Knight, 2011; Grossman et al., 2022). My findings are more closely related to works on the effect of

⁴See Puglisi and Snyder (2015) and Gentzkow et al. (2015) for reviews of the empirical and theoretical literature on the drivers of media slant.

⁵On the theoretical side, Baron (2006) is the first to propose a framework in which journalists have discretion when producing news, leading to media bias arising from their private information about news.

⁶These results are in line with the evidence on the drivers of the representation of women and minorities in the media (Ash et al., 2021). Further, they relate to studies investigating whether external elements influence media content through their effects on journalists, such as connections (Xu, 2024; DellaVigna and Hermle, 2017) and to the descriptive evidence in communication studies on gender differences in sourcing and coverage (Rodgers and Thorson, 2003; Armstrong, 2004; Correa and Harp, 2011).

media exposure on crime-related outcomes (Mastrorocco and Minale, 2018; Banerjee et al., 2019; Keita et al., 2024; Moreno-Medina et al., 2025).⁷ In line with these findings, I show that exposure to different narratives leads to changes in attitudes and behavior, providing the first evidence of identity-driven persuasion in the media.

In other contexts, many papers have investigated the role of identity in shaping individual preferences and behavior in politics (Chattopadhyay and Duflo, 2004; Beaman et al., 2009), firms (Matsa and Miller, 2013; Bertrand et al., 2019), and the judiciary (Harris and Sen, 2019; Miller and Segal, 2019).⁸ At the same time, the evidence on whether this descriptive representation translates into substantive representation for in-group members is mixed.⁹ This paper provides novel evidence on this in the context of journalism showing that the identity of workers can have a direct effect on consumers by affecting the product.¹⁰

This paper further contributes to the literature on information framing and persuasion, which documents effects on perceptions (Andre et al., 2024), attitudes (Iyengar, 1991; Chong and Druckman, 2007), and policy preferences (Alesina et al., 2023). Most closely related are papers on media narratives and rhetorical devices (Schwarz et al., 2022; Moreno-Medina et al., 2025). I contribute to this literature by providing evidence that victim-centered narratives shape perceived norms around help-seeking behavior, and that narratives move readers' empathy.¹¹

Finally, I contribute to the literature on gender-based violence. A substantial body of work has studied the economic determinants of intimate partner violence (Aizer, 2010), the role of legislation and enforcement ([sviatschi_gender_2021](#); Ferraz and Schiavon, 2022; Bochenkova et al., 2023), and the role of gender norms, including evidence that entertainment media can shift norms and reduce VAW prevalence (Banerjee et al., 2019; González and Rodríguez-Planas, 2020; Green et al., 2020). Closest to my setting, recent work shows that the coverage of femicides can spur community mobilization (Belguise and Monterosa, 2025) and raise calls to anti-violence helplines (Colagrossi et al., 2023). I complement this literature by providing the first evidence that help-seeking responds to the framing of coverage, rather than its volume alone, and that this framing is shaped by the identity of individual reporters rather than by media campaigns or top-down editorial decisions.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes journalism and violence against women in Italy, and Section 3 the data and narrative measures. Sections 4, 5 and 6 present the three parts of the analysis. Section 7 discusses the results and Section 8 concludes.

⁷See also Enikolopov et al. (2011), Martin and Yurukoglu (2017), and Durante et al. (2019) and, for reviews of media effects, DellaVigna and Gentzkow (2010), Prior (2013), and DellaVigna and La Ferrara (2015). On media and women-related outcomes, see Jensen and Oster (2009), La Ferrara et al. (2012), and Baum et al. (2018).

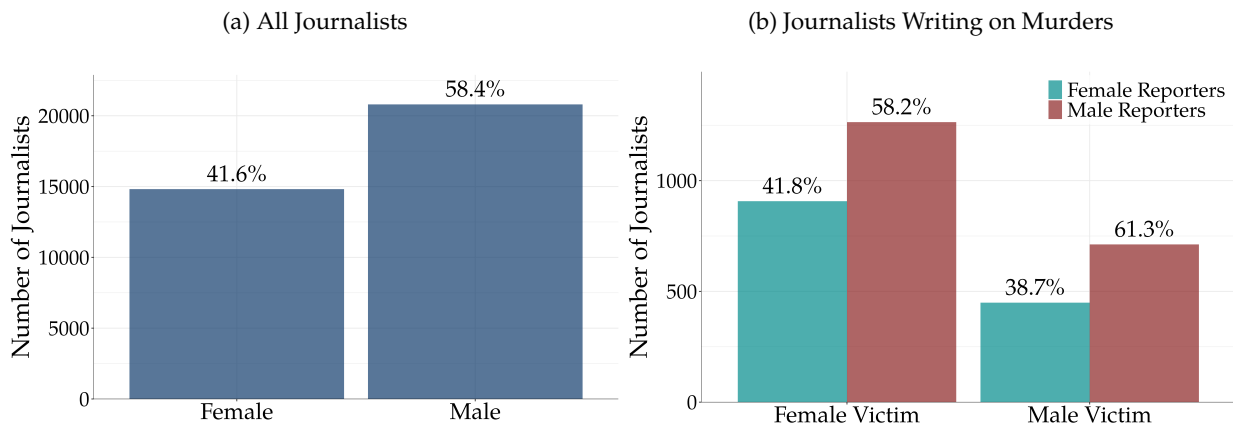
⁸These works build on social identity theory (Tajfel et al., 1971; Turner et al., 1979) and its introduction into economics by Akerlof and Kranton (2000).

⁹See Mansbridge (1999) and Wängnerud (2009) for reviews of the debate on descriptive and substantive representation, and Grossman et al. (2016) and Lowande et al. (2019) for evidence on whether the two coincide.

¹⁰This is different from similar papers on substantive representation, that mainly provide evidence on this through a role model channel (Dee, 2007; Flabbi et al., 2019; Porter and Serra, 2020).

¹¹See Bursztyn et al. (2020a) and Bursztyn et al. (2020b). At the same time, I do not find any evidence of this leading to an increased demand for government intervention, as the growing literature on the role of perspective-taking and empathy in shaping policy preferences would predict (Adida et al., 2018; Kalla and Broockman, 2023; Adida et al., 2025).

Figure 1: Gender Composition of Journalists



Notes. Gender composition of journalists in Italy. Panel (a) reports the number of journalists separately by gender in the full population of Italian journalists. Panel (b) reports the number of journalists writing about murders separately by gender of the victim and of the journalist. The top of each bar reports the share of journalists within each sample or set of articles.

2 Institutional Context

Italy's media landscape is characterized by a few influential national newspapers and several more local ones. The leading national newspapers are more popular in the North, while in Southern Italy, regional and local newspapers dominate the media scene. These newspapers are generally smaller and focus more on local news while still covering the main national ones.¹²

The Italian journalism job market has been rigid over the last 20 years, as newspaper readership and revenues declined, limiting the hiring of young journalists and leaving newsrooms homogeneous. Male journalists are the majority both overall and in crime sections (Figure 1), and editors-in-chief and news-desk heads tend to be older men,¹³ who favor a traditional style in which *storytelling* plays a larger role than accurate reporting (Post, 2023).

Italian newsrooms, like those of many other countries, are organized hierarchically. Larger newspapers are typically led by an editor-in-chief who oversees several section editors, each responsible for a specific topic or theme like politics, economy, or crime. The crime section, for example, consists of a specialized team of journalists responsible for investigating and writing articles on crimes. Each level of this hierarchy faces different incentives that shape a newspaper's editorial output. The editor-in-chief sets the overall editorial line, weighing the newspaper's ideological positioning, often correlated with that of the owner, against its financial needs. Specifically, they need to consider what is newsworthy and what is likely to maximize readers' engagement, such as click-through rate or retention. Next, section editors act as intermediaries between the main editor and reporting journalists. In practice, they decide on article titles, monitor journal-

¹²See Appendix Table A.36 for information on newspapers and their readership.

¹³Only two of Italy's daily newspapers are led by a woman.

ists' output, and, jointly with the editor-in-chief, determine which stories to run, with incentives broadly aligned with those at the top.

Finally, reporters are tasked with gathering the necessary information and writing the article. In doing so, they face a broader set of incentives. They still aim to maximize readers' engagement and adhere to the newspaper's positioning. But they also have personal preferences over how to frame events that, in the extreme, could even lead them to switch media outlets and move to more ideologically aligned ones (Cagé et al., 2025). Because reporters retain meaningful discretion over content and style, writing choices can differ significantly across reporters with different characteristics or preferences.

When news outlets receive news from a wire agency, they must respond quickly, especially if it qualifies as breaking news and needs prompt reporting, as is the case with crime news. Section editors, therefore, assign the story to the reporter in the crime unit who is both on duty and geographically closest to the event.¹⁴ The assigned reporter then writes an article drawing on information from the wire agency and, in some cases, any newspaper informants. Finally, section editors review the piece, assign a title, and publish it with the authorization of the editor-in-chief. The same happens with crime developments in the following days, as long as the crime is covered by the crime unit.

Turning to crime, Italy is among the safest countries in Europe in terms of murders. As of 2022, it had one of the lowest murder rates per 100,000 inhabitants in the European Union, less than half that of France and equal to 75% of Germany's (Statista, 2022b). At the same time, it was estimated to be the country with the highest number of femicides in the European Union, with 120 murders, followed by France and Germany, with 118 and 113 femicides, respectively. The trend of these murders in Italy, as in Europe, is also striking. Appendix Figure A.11a plots the number of murders per year and shows that while the number of murders with male victims has decreased sharply in the past 20 years, the number of murders with female victims has decreased by a smaller margin and remained stable in the past 10 years. Moreover, the prevalence of murders by the current or ex-intimate partner has been increasing since 2017, reaching 60% of murders with female victims.

Finally, the setting of murders with female victims in Italy is particularly suited to investigating the role of journalists' identities. As mentioned above, violence against women is a very salient issue in Italy. On top of this, media representation of these crimes has increasingly been central to public debate. Feminist activists argue that the media tend to sympathize with the perpetrators and rely on episodic framing. They point, for instance, to reporting that focuses on triggers of the crime, like a fit of rage, mental or economic problems, or some action of the woman.¹⁵ Moreover, these crimes involve mostly Italians and vary little across age, region, or socioeconomic status. Coverage is therefore framed around gender rather than class or nationality, which lets me isolate

¹⁴The assignment process is different when the crime becomes front-page news or a story of *national interest*. At this point, journalists outside the crime unit are assigned to cover the story depending on their expertise.

¹⁵In a recent article by *The Guardian* the president of a feminist association argued for a change in how media portray perpetrators, and to "put an end to journalism that still emphasizes the point of view of the murderer, explaining what motivated him to kill a woman" (Kassam, 2023).

gender identity while holding these other dimensions roughly fixed.

For these reasons, this is an ideal setting to study this question, but not a unique one. Similar conditions could arise in other contexts where an in-group/out-group divide, other than political ideology, is salient, and where the journalist identifies with one of the groups. Such a scenario emerged in American newsrooms after the murder of George Floyd in 2020. The event highlighted an ideological struggle within American journalism: Black journalists advocated for a more explicit commitment to social justice in reporting by, e.g., framing events as manifestations of systemic racism, while others defended traditional norms of neutrality. This suggests that the tension between identity and professional norms documented in this paper for gender and crime reporting is not unique to this context, but could extend to many domains of public life.

3 Data and Measurement

This section describes the data (Section 3.1) and the method I use to measure victim- and perpetrator-centered narratives (Section 3.2).

3.1 Data

This paper leverages several data sources. First, I collect data on murders of women, then I match this data with newspaper articles and available metadata. Finally, I combine this corpus with additional province-level data, e.g., help-seeking and crime rates.

Murders. Official individual-level data on murders are unavailable, so I compile a list of murders of women in Italy from two sources. The first is *Casa Donne*,¹⁶ an association that publishes annual reports on press-reported murders of women classifiable as VAW; from it I take each event’s date, place, the victim’s and perpetrator’s names and nationalities, and their relationship. I validate and complete the list with *Femminicidio Italia*,¹⁷ a website dedicated to these events, from 2018 on.

The final sample comprises 1,989 murders of women from 2006 to 2022. Appendix Table A.37 reports the summary statistics for the murders in my data. It shows that most victims and perpetrators are Italian—77% and 83%, respectively—and that around 87% of these murders are either committed by the partner of the victim or by a relative. To check the completeness of this newly constructed data, I compare the yearly average with the yearly national average of murders with female victims from the Italian National Statistical Office (Appendix Figure A.12). The gap is largest in 2006, when the national count is nearly twice mine, but shrinks over time, as murders unrelated to the victim’s gender (e.g., robberies) fall from about 50 to fewer than 15 per year.

Second, I build a set of male-victim murders to use as placebo crimes throughout the paper. I extract these with a large language model (gpt-4.1-mini) from news articles on these crimes. The model reads each article and classifies whether it describes a real murder in Italy, the victim’s

¹⁶<https://www.casadonne.it/>

¹⁷<https://femminicidioitalia.info>

gender, and the victim's and perpetrator's names, relationship, location, and date.¹⁸ I then manually clean names, relationships, and locations and map them to municipalities, identifying 5,393 murders (about 7% by a relative and 8% by the partner).

Corpus of Newspaper Articles. As a next step, I collect articles from Italian newspapers about these murders from *Factiva*. I include in my sample the most-read national newspapers, excluding from the count local news outlets, as well as the two most popular newspapers for each province (See Appendix Table A.36). To retrieve the articles of interest, I query *Factiva* separately for each year by searching the name of the victim or the perpetrator combined with the root of words like "murdered", "killed", or "dead". I achieve a matching rate of 98.31% between the murders in my sample and those for which I find newspaper articles. Similarly, for the articles about murders with male victims, I query words like "killed", "murder", "homicide", and "dead". By leveraging the tags available in *Factiva*, I collect a total of 18,127 articles with byline after removing articles that are not about murders that occurred in Italy, as described in Appendix Section E.

Appendix Figure A.14a shows the number of articles on murders with female victims rising over time, with a jump in 2015 that reflects newspaper availability. Until 2014, only five newspapers are in the sample (Appendix Figure A.16), with the pool of newspapers increasing after 2015.¹⁹ Appendix Figure A.17a shows that coverage is also concentrated. Most events receive fewer than 10 articles per newspaper, but the distribution has a long tail for events that become salient due to victims' characteristics or to the uncertainty surrounding the crime (Appendix Figure A.17a).

A sub-sample of articles has information about the reporter who authored it, for a total of 2,613 reporters. For these reporters, I draw on the National Journalist Order, the professional body journalists must register with.²⁰ I retrieve each reporter's date of birth, region of residence (where they also work), registration date, and license class (*Professionista* or *Pubblicista*), and I infer gender from the first name. Appendix Table A.38 reports the summary statistics for journalists' characteristics separately for female and male reporters. The Table shows that the majority of reporters are men (58%) and live in Northern Italy (47%). Moreover, even within newspapers, female reporters are, on average, 4 years younger than male reporters and consequently have less experience. Appendix Figure A.14b plots the yearly number of these articles by reporter gender, showing that while there are consistently more male reporters, the difference between male and female reporters has been narrowing over the years.²¹ Additionally, the majority of articles in the sample are authored by journalists who write articles on both crimes with female and male victims.²² Finally, I match newspapers with yearly data about their readership in each Italian province, using data from *Accertamenti Diffusione Stampa*.

¹⁸See Appendix E for further details

¹⁹See Appendix Figure A.15 for murders with male victims.

²⁰Registration is weakly enforced, so some contributors are not registered. In my sample, 85% of reporters are.

²¹Appendix Table A.39 shows the distribution of female reporters by newspaper.

²²Appendix Figure A.18 shows the distribution of the share of articles about murders with female victims per reporter, considering reporters who authored more than 5 articles in my sample.

Additional Data. Finally, I collect information about gender norms and calls to the VAW helpline number in Italy from the Italian Statistical Office (ISTAT).

The VAW helpline, launched by the Department of Equal Opportunities in 2006, supports women experiencing violence—including psychological abuse and stalking, inside or outside the family. The number is active 24 hours a day and closely collaborates with anti-violence centers to connect them with women in need.²³ Data on calls are available from 2013 for each province and week. Appendix Figure A.19 shows the distribution of calls, and it highlights the sparse nature of the variable, with the majority of province-week observations having zero or one call.

As a proxy for gender norms, I use a region-by-year measure of female labor-market participation: the share of households with children in which the woman does not work. As validation for this proxy, I show that its correlation with survey measures of agreement with traditional gender roles, sexual violence, and household stereotypes is above 0.7 (Appendix Table A.40), supporting its use as a gender-norms proxy.

3.2 Measuring Victim- and Perpetrator-Centered Narratives

I quantify reporting practices with a keyword-based approach. I first review the guidelines for reporting VAW, then describe how I build the narrative measures from them and from the linguistics literature.

Guidelines on Reporting about Violence Against Women. Journalists often rely on professional guidelines from journalists' organizations or news agencies as broad references for reporting. The main example of these guidelines is the *Associated Press Stylebook*. However, adoption of such guidelines is often flexible as newsrooms adapt to the preferences of their audiences and invoke the freedom-of-information principle affirmed in journalists' ethics codes.²⁴ This can lead to challenges in consistently enforcing these rules. For these reasons, guidelines for reporting on violence against women²⁵ are often non-mandatory, allowing for a lot of freedom of journalistic writing.

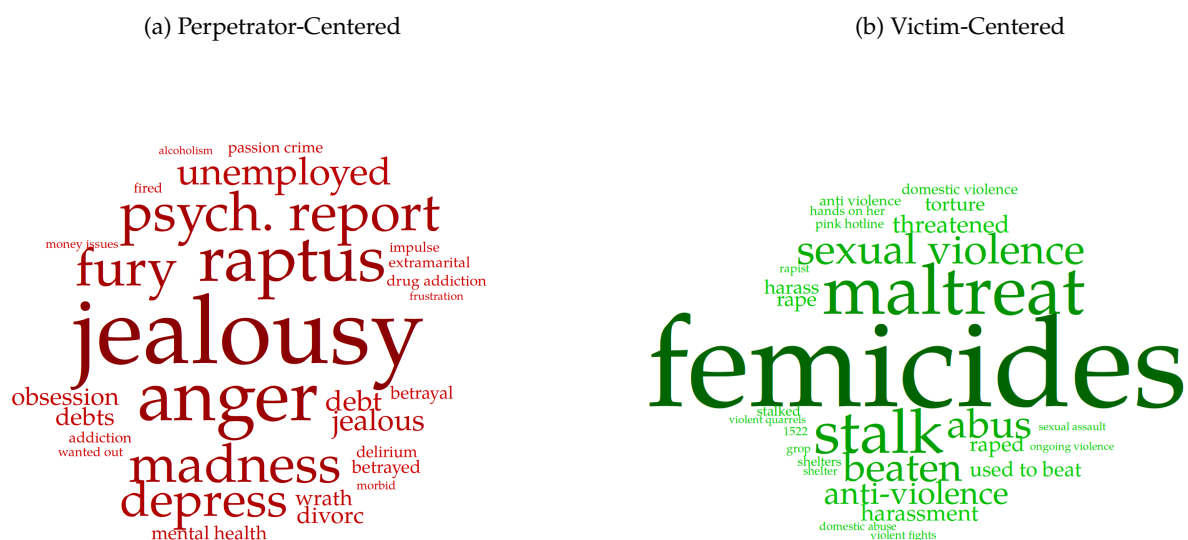
These principles echo work in linguistics, social psychology, and communication on how frames and rhetorical devices shape responsibility attribution (Ryan et al., 2006). For instance, many of these works highlight how the use of passive voice leads to diminishing perpetrators' responsibility (Henley et al., 1995; Bohner, 2001; De Freitas et al., 2017). Similarly, other studies suggest that the lack of social responsibility regarding VAW could be due to reporting information that diminishes perpetrators' culpability, e.g., an affair or the victim seeking separation. Additionally, these studies highlight the preference for episodic framing, i.e., focusing on single events rather than placing them in a broader context (Carlyle et al., 2008; Palazzolo and Roberto, 2011; Carlyle et al., 2014).

²³See <https://www.1522.eu/?lang=en> for additional information.

²⁴As an example, the Italian ethics code (*Testo Unico dei Doveri del Giornalista*) states that "Journalists' activity is inspired by the principle of freedom of speech affirmed in Italian Constitution [...] Journalists defend each person's right to information and freedom of expression.

²⁵See UNESCO (2019), *Zero Tolerance UK*, Warren et al. (2024), UNDP (2022), FNSI (2017).

Figure 2: Most Frequent Dictionary Words



Notes. Word clouds of the most frequent words appearing in articles, separately by practices that enter the perpetrator-centered narratives and those entering the victim-centered narratives. Words plotted in a larger font appear more frequently.

This framing, as opposed to framing the violence as a societal and public health issue (*thematic framing*) can decrease policy mobilization and support for victims (Iyengar, 1991; Maxwell et al., 2000; Carll, 2003).

Following these works, the guidelines can be summarized in a few common principles. They discourage passive voice and *perpetrator-centered* narratives, mitigating factors that shift blame or perpetuate stereotypes, such as framing the killing as a man snapping, mentioning a betrayal, or mental and financial problems. They encourage *victim-centered* narratives that contextualize the crime, report prior abuse, or situate it within the broader phenomenon of VAW through data and information on support resources.²⁶

Dictionary Approach. For the purpose of my analysis, I build dictionaries for the topics the guidelines and the linguistics literature say reporters should mention or avoid. Six capture *perpetrator-centered* narratives: *fit of rage*, *jealousy*, *betrayal*, *end of the relationship*, *financial*, and *mental problems*. Two more capture *victim-centered* narratives: one for pre-existing sexual violence (*stalking*, *abuse*, *rape*), one for support resources (anti-violence centers, the 1522 helpline). Together with an indicator for the word *femminicidio*, introduced below, these form the three components of the VC index. To make the dictionaries exhaustive, I expand each seed list with its nearest neighbors in a word-embedding space, keeping the highest-similarity terms related to the topic.

²⁶The *Manifesto di Venezia* (FNSI, 2017) posits that this practice often follows from an *abuse* of the mandate of “reporting the substantial truth about facts” included in the journalists’ ethics code. It argues that this mandate leads to over-engaging in superfluous details that translate into perpetrator-centered narratives and spectacularization.

Figure 2 plots the most frequent words of the dictionaries that appear in the articles, separately for practices that enter the perpetrator-centered and the victim-centered narratives. The Figure shows that words indicating jealousy and framing the crime as the result of the perpetrator snapping are the most common for the perpetrator-centered narratives, while femicide and maltreatment are the most used for victim-centered narratives. The full list of words for each dictionary is reported in Appendix Table C.1.

I pre-process the text of the articles by lowercasing and removing the names of the author, the victim, and the perpetrator, as well as the names of regions and municipalities. Then, for each word in the dictionaries, I first mask the keywords if they appear in expressions that do not refer to the reporting practice. For instance, for mentions of rape, I remove all instances where rape refers to the general phenomenon but not to the crime itself, e.g., “sexual violence episodes as serious as rape” or “181 cases of rape”. I also mask all instances where the word is preceded by a negative adverb within a three-word distance, such as “she was not raped”. After this step, for each dictionary k and article a , I create an indicator capturing the presence of one or more words from the dictionary:

$$Y_a^k = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } w^k \in a \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \quad (1)$$

I aggregate these indicators into two measures. First, I create a *Victim-Centered* (VC) index that averages indicators for pre-existing violence, “feminicidio”, and resources. Second, I construct a *Perpetrator-Centered* (PC) index by averaging the indicators for the remaining dictionaries.²⁷ I treat these two indexes as two separate dimensions rather than extremes of a single one: the two are close to orthogonal (correlation ≈ 0.09), so an article can emphasize the victim, the perpetrator, both, or neither. Appendix Figure A.20 shows that the prevalence of the PC index decreases over time, while that of the VC index increases, suggesting a general trend toward a more victim-centric narrative of these crimes. Additionally, Appendix Figure A.21 shows that the increasing trend in the VC index is more pronounced for female reporters, while there are more muted differences across reporters’ gender in the PC index.

Validation. A dictionary approach has two advantages for isolating specific concepts. It targets the element of interest, minimizing the noise that word embeddings or topic models introduce, and it yields easily interpretable measures, well-suited to causal inference.²⁸ A concern with this method is that the schema may miss true instances (false negatives) or flag spurious ones (false positives). I therefore benchmark the current approach against a large language model (LLM) and against human annotators.²⁹ For a sample of 1,000 and 500 articles, I ask the LLM and the

²⁷Appendix Section C.1 shows some example articles with different values for each index.

²⁸As an example, it is the case that dictionaries about *fit of rage* and *pre-existing violence* have high similarity with embeddings of words like *killed* or *murdered*, increasing the measurement error in the similarity measures.

²⁹I use gpt-4.1-mini as a large language model.

Table 1: Validation Dictionary Approach

Topic	F1 Score		
	Dictionary-LLM (1)	Dictionary-Human (2)	Human-LLM (3)
<i>Panel A: Perpetrator-Centered</i>			
Fit of Rage	0.781	0.830	0.805
Jealousy	0.917	0.910	0.881
Econ. Difficulties	0.888	0.929	0.922
Mental Health Prob.	0.894	0.898	0.876
Infidelity	0.962	0.956	0.968
End of Relationship	0.844	0.902	0.871
<i>Panel B: Victim-Centered</i>			
Past Violence	0.873	0.898	0.830
Info on VAW Resources	0.954	0.966	0.945

Notes. Weighted F1 scores pairs of coding approaches. Column 1 reports the F1 score between the main approach (the dictionary-based annotation) and the classification by the LLM, Column 2 that between the main approach and the human annotation, and Column 3 the F1 score between the human and LLM annotation. Scores range from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect agreement.

annotators, respectively, to code the presence of the different topics in the articles, giving them a definition of such topics instead of the keyword schema (see Appendix Section C.2.1). I report in Table 1 the F1 score, weighted to account for the classes’ imbalance, between the indicator in (1) and classification by the LLM and human annotators, and between the human and LLM annotations.

F1 scores are always at or above 0.8, except for fit of rage. The confusion matrices (Appendix Table C.2) show that the disagreements are driven by false positives. The LLM often over-infers information that is not directly reported in the texts, despite being explicitly told not to engage in over-inference.³⁰ This tendency of over-inference by the LLM is confirmed when looking at the classification by human annotators. Agreement with human coders is similar or higher—especially for over-inferred topics, such as a fit of rage, indicating that the current approach, not the LLM, is the more faithful benchmark.

A second, qualitative check confirms that high- and low-index articles on the same crime differ systematically in focus. I randomly select 4 crimes covered by articles that score high on the victim-centered or on the perpetrator-centered dimension—index larger than 0.6—, using only the sample of first and second articles for each event-newspaper (Table 2).³¹

Although each pair covers the same crime, articles with a high VC index focus more on the victim and frame violence against women as a broader societal problem. Conversely, those with a high PC index discuss the possible motives of the perpetrator and the specific situation of the

³⁰Appendix Section C.2.1 reports some examples of *false positive* articles annotated by the LLM.

³¹Appendix Section C.2.2 reports more examples and the text of the full articles.

Table 2: Pairs of Articles about the Same Crime

High Victim-Centered Index	High Perpetrator-Centered Index
[VICTIM], a 50-year-old INPS employee, was murdered in her 30-square-meter apartment in the Lorenteggio area of Milan by her husband of 20 years, [PERPETRATOR]. After returning from a month-long vacation, the couple got into a violent argument, resulting in him stabbing [VICTIM] [...] Neighbors reported previous violent altercations between the couple, highlighting a history of abuse and threats. Authorities describe the case as emblematic of a deeply troubled family dynamic characterized by unreported violence, emphasizing the importance of women seeking help from anti-violence centers and law enforcement in such situations. This is the second femicide in Milan within a short period [...] [PERPETRATOR] is suspected of premeditating the murder of his ex-wife, [VICTIM] [...] Reports suggest [VICTIM] had been subjected to threats and abuse in the months leading up to the tragic incident, with periodic mutual complaints filed from 2011 to 2012. A planned flash mob is scheduled to commemorate [VICTIM]’s sacrifice and protest against femicide, while the region has pledged financial and support assistance for her daughters.	In Milan, a man named [PERPETRATOR], 53, confessed to killing his wife, [VICTIM], 50, after a violent argument that escalated tragically. The couple had a history of intense disputes fueled by jealousy and accusations regarding [VICTIM]’s relationship with another man, which had driven a wedge between them. On the day of the murder, despite a seemingly peaceful morning, a heated argument led to [PERPETRATOR] attacking [VICTIM] with 23 stab wounds in a fit of rage. [PERPETRATOR], who has a history of violence, described the incident with vague recollections, claiming he lost control during the confrontation after [VICTIM] insulted him.[...] [VICTIM], a 41-year-old nurse and mother of two, was shot and killed by her ex-husband, [PERPETRATOR], a 42-year-old security guard, in a violent incident near Ostia in Rome. The couple was divorced, and [VICTIM] had previously reported his violent behavior to the police. The ex-husband, who was not accepting the separation, chased [VICTIM] in his car [...] The violent and tumultuous separation had led to mutual accusations and legal disputes between the couple but had not involved reported threats of gun violence prior to the tragic event.

Notes. Pairs of articles about the same crime. The articles in the left column have a victim-centered index higher than 0.6, while those in the right column have a perpetrator-centered index higher than 0.6. Highlighted are the parts captured by the highest-scoring index.

individuals involved. This reinforces the confidence that the topics and indexes constructed with the current methodology are indeed valid for capturing the differences outlined in the guidelines about the topic. As a final step in the validation, a research assistant classified 40 pairs of articles into victim- and perpetrator-centered categories, achieving 80% agreement with the index.

4 Gender Differences in Crime Reporting

In this section, I investigate gender differences in reporting about murders with female victims. I first ask, descriptively, whether a reporter’s gender can be predicted from their writing. I fine-tune a BERT classifier, trained on Italian, on the female-victim articles and generate out-of-sample predictions for reporters’ gender by cross-validation. The classifier reaches 0.61 accuracy, indicating that writing style carries statistically meaningful information about a reporter’s gender.³² Prediction alone, however, cannot isolate this signal, as it may reflect crime characteristics or other confounders. The rest of the section presents the identification strategy (Section 4.1), the results, and robustness checks (Section 4.2).

4.1 Empirical Strategy

A major concern in this analysis is that reporters with different characteristics select into murders to cover based on their preferences for specific crime characteristics. For instance, it could be that women prefer to write about murders in which the perpetrator is the intimate partner of the victim. If this were the case, any gender differences in mentions of the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator would be due to differences in case selection.

This concern is mitigated by how crime reporters are assigned to events. When a murder breaks, the story goes to the crime reporter who is on duty and in the region where it happened. A similar process applies as long as the news remains within the crime unit—i.e., it is not covered by the political, opinion, or judicial news sections. Most crimes are covered by only one or two reporters per newspaper (Appendix Figure A.17b), which limits selection at this stage. To test whether assignment is orthogonal to crime characteristics conditional on the newspaper, I run balance checks for the whole sample and separately for the first and fifth articles per newspaper:

$$Y_{a(e)jyn}^k = \beta FemaleRep_j + \alpha_{ny} + \varepsilon_{a(e)jyn} \quad (2)$$

where $Y_{a(e)jyn}^k$ indicates characteristics k of the murder reported in article a written by reporter j in newspaper n in year y . On the right-hand side, $FemaleRep_j$ is a binary variable indicating if the reporter writing the article is a woman or a man; α_{ny} are newspaper-year fixed effects.

³²I plot in Appendix Figure A.2 the distribution of predicted probabilities of articles being authored by a female journalist separately for articles authored by female and male journalists. The figure shows that predicted and real gender of the journalist are correlated, suggesting potentially meaningful gender differences in the language used in VAW reporting.

Table 3: Balance Test on Reporter's Gender

Variable	Mean		Difference in Means			
	Female Reporters	Male Reporters	Without FE		With FE	
	All (1)	All (2)	All (3)	All (4)	First Art. (5)	Fifth Art. (6)
Victim Italian	0.852 (0.355)	0.836 (0.371)	0.017** (0.007)	-0.003 (0.015)	0.003 (0.019)	0.027 (0.046)
Perpetrator Italian	0.786 (0.41)	0.801 (0.399)	-0.015* (0.008)	-0.004 (0.024)	-0.013 (0.018)	0.044 (0.051)
Perpetrator Partner	0.556 (0.497)	0.568 (0.495)	-0.012 (0.01)	-0.005 (0.014)	-0.009 (0.013)	-0.091 (0.054)
Perpetrator Relative	0.131 (0.337)	0.134 (0.341)	-0.003 (0.007)	0.001 (0.008)	0.016 (0.012)	0 (0.019)
Relationship Missing	0.146 (0.353)	0.13 (0.336)	0.016** (0.007)	0.005 (0.01)	0.01 (0.009)	0.034 (0.031)
Crime >5 Articles	0.515 (0.5)	0.522 (0.5)	-0.006 (0.01)	0.001 (0.022)		
Crime >10 Articles	0.341 (0.474)	0.368 (0.482)	-0.027*** (0.009)	-0.001 (0.018)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.318 (0.466)	0.325 (0.468)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.014 (0.02)		
Second Article - Female Vict.	0.149 (0.356)	0.138 (0.345)	0.01 (0.007)	0.007* (0.004)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.566 (0.496)	0.634 (0.482)	-0.068*** (0.012)	-0.046 (0.043)		
Second Article - Male Vict.	0.152 (0.359)	0.159 (0.366)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.008 (0.006)		
Victim Female	0.595 (0.491)	0.583 (0.493)	0.013* (0.007)	0.006 (0.018)		

Notes. Balance test of crime and article characteristics along reporters' gender. *First Article* and *Second Article* are indicators for whether the article is respectively the first or the second one about a specific crime in the same newspaper, presented separately for murders with male and female victims. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the whole sample, and Columns 5 and 6 report the results separately for the first and fifth articles, respectively. Columns 1 and 2 report the mean and standard deviation of crime and article characteristics separately for Female and Male reporters. Column 3 reports the simple difference in means between Female and Male reporters. Columns 4 to 6 report the difference in means after taking out newspaper-year fixed effects. Standard errors in Columns 4 to 6 are clustered at the newspaper level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 3 reports the results of the balance test. Columns 1 and 2 report the mean of each variable separately for female and male reporters, while Columns 3 and 4 report the simple difference in means and the coefficient β from regression 2 for the whole sample. From Column 3, it emerges that there are some small differences between cases covered by female and male reporters. For instance, women are less likely to cover cases where the perpetrator is Italian but more likely to cover crimes with an Italian victim. However, all of these differences disappear when newspaper-year fixed effects are included.³³ Importantly, after including the fixed effects, there are no differences between male and female reporters in the probability that they are assigned to the first or second article about a crime with either female or male victims. Additionally, female and male reporters write about crimes with female and male victims to a similar extent. Finally, Columns 5 and 6 show that the crime characteristics of crimes reported by female and male reporters are similar even when just looking at the first and fifth articles.

Overall, reporters' characteristics appear orthogonal to crime characteristics. Two concerns remain, each a potential correlate of gender that cannot be accounted for in the balance test. The first is geographic proximity. Female and male reporters are distributed differently across regions, which I account for by including reporters' region fixed effects. Second, work schedules could also be correlated with reporters' gender. If male reporters more often work nights, when intimate-partner homicides are likelier, reporter gender could correlate with crime timing even within a newspaper-year. Because I do not observe shift times, I address this by adding crime-event fixed effects, comparing female and male reporters who cover the very same murder. The final specification is:

$$Y_{a(e)jyn} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{FemaleRep}_j + \alpha_{ny} + \alpha_r + \alpha_e + \varepsilon_{a(e)jyn} \quad (3)$$

where $Y_{a(e)jyn}$ is one of the two standardized narrative indexes in article a about crime e written by journalist j in year y and newspaper n ; the explanatory variable is FemaleRep_j which indicates that the article is written by a female journalist, and the coefficient of interest is β_1 , which indicates differences in outcomes between female and male journalists. As mentioned above, I include newspaper-year and reporter-region fixed effects, α_{ny} and α_r , to account for reporters' selection into cases, and crime fixed effects, α_e , to account for potential correlations between crime and reporters' characteristics. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level.

4.2 Results

Table 4 reports the results from regression 3 in which the main explanatory variable is an indicator for the reporter being a woman. Columns 1 and 5 report the results from the simple OLS

³³The same orthogonality holds when I split reporters by age and by experience rather than by gender: crime characteristics are mostly balanced across these groups (Appendix Tables A.1 and A.2). The exception is the gender norms of the reporter's region. Reporters from more traditional-norm regions cover fewer crimes with female victims even within newspaper-year fixed effects (Appendix Table A.3). However, this could reflect differences in which murders are covered across regions rather than reporters' selection.

Table 4: Gender Differences in Reporting

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.165*** (0.032)	0.125*** (0.029)	0.142*** (0.029)	0.121*** (0.025)	-0.061** (0.027)	-0.056** (0.026)	-0.045* (0.026)	-0.052** (0.023)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.007	0.120	0.133	0.432	0.001	0.058	0.065	0.356
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

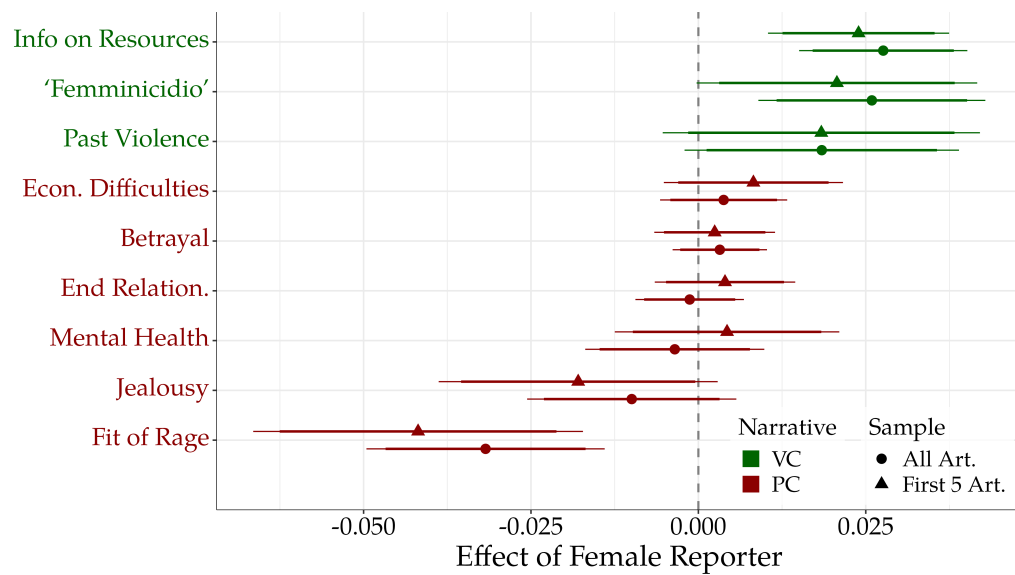
Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between Female and Male reporters. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the victim-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices complying with the guidelines on reporting about VAW; Columns 5 to 8 report the results for the perpetrator-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices that do not comply with such guidelines. Columns 1 and 5 report the OLS regression; Columns 2 and 6 include newspaper-year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 7 add reporter's region fixed effects; Columns 4 and 8 also include crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

regression of the indexes for victim-centered and perpetrator-centered narratives on reporters' gender, standardized to have a mean of 0 and a standard deviation of 1. Columns 2-3 and 6-7 add newspaper times year and reporter's region fixed effects to leverage the exogeneity of reporters to cases. The results from these columns show that female reporters are more likely than male ones to use victim-centered narratives and, at the same time, less likely to use perpetrator-centered narratives. The results are stable across all specifications and robust to the inclusion of crime fixed effects (Columns 4 and 8), while the R^2 increases substantially, suggesting that these gender differences persist when accounting for differences in crimes. In particular, the results from these two columns show that female reporters have a VC index that is 0.12 standard deviations higher than that of male reporters. At the same time, their PC index is 0.05 standard deviations lower than that of male reporters.³⁴

As a next step, I break down the effect of the reporter's gender by topic. Namely, I run regression 3 using an indicator for each reporting topic separately as an outcome. I plot the resulting coefficients in Figure 3 with both 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The results show that female reporters are around 2.5 percentage points more likely than male reporters to call the crime a femicide and to provide information about resources to counter VAW, and 1.8 percentage points more likely to mention past violence. By contrast, male reporters are between 3 and 4 percentage points more likely to mention a fit of rage and between 1 and 2 percentage points more likely to mention jealousy. Relating these estimates to the average prevalence of these practices,

³⁴To investigate whether these gender differences in text are also reflected in differences in headlines, in Appendix Table A.4, I report the results from the same specification using as outcomes the VC and PC indexes constructed using headlines instead of the main article text. The table shows that while the sign on the coefficients for female reporters is the same as that of Table 4, the magnitude is much smaller and mostly non-significant. This suggests that while headlines may reflect the content of the articles, ultimately, they are chosen using different criteria and are likely to capture mainly the preferences of section editors, as described in Section 2.

Figure 3: Effect of Female Reporters on Reporting Practices



Notes. Effect of female reporters on topic presence in articles. Regressions include newspaper-year, crime, and reporter's region fixed effects, and for coefficients represented by triangles, are run on a sample that includes only the first 5 articles for each crime and newspaper. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level, and the figure shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals. The coefficients colored in green indicate practices that form the victim-centered index, while the coefficients in red are those that form the perpetrator-centered index.

the results suggest that female reporters are 20% more likely than male reporters to call the crime a femicide and 80% more likely to report information on help resources. On the other hand, male reporters are around 15% and 10% more likely than female reporters to mention a fit of rage and jealousy, respectively.

Mechanisms. These differences operate at the level of the individual journalist, not merely the outlet. To capture the contribution of individual reporters to narrative variation, I estimate an AKM-style variance decomposition (Abowd et al., 1999) that separates each index into journalist, outlet (newspaper-year), and crime components. I find that journalists account for a large share of the variation in narratives, about 37% of the variance in the victim-centered index and 44% in the perpetrator-centered one, around the same amount as the crime component (48% and 43%) and higher than the outlet component (19% and 30%). These shares are likely an upper bound, since reporters write few articles each and there are few movers (Appendix Table A.6).

The journalists' effects act mainly through their gender, making their preferences for narratives identity-driven. These gender differences are not explained by other characteristics on which female and male reporters differ. Women are younger, less experienced, and likely to be more progressive than men (Appendix Table A.38), and differences along these dimensions are consistent with more progressive gender norms: victim-centered narratives are used more in liberal outlets and in regions with less traditional gender norms. Yet the gender differences are stable and significant when I control for age, regional gender norms, and outlet political leaning, and when I estimate them separately within each of these groups (Appendix Tables A.7–A.9, Figure A.3).

An alternative explanation is that women who become journalists differ in their writing skills or in how they approach crime reporting. First, because women face higher barriers to entry in a male-dominated profession, those who become journalists may be of higher average quality and adhere to professional guidelines more closely in general (Ashraf et al., 2024). Second, women may be more empathetic toward victims and so write more sympathetically regardless of the crime. Both predict that the gender differences should also appear when the victim is a man, yet they do not. Among reporters covering homicides with male victims and perpetrators, where the gender-identity channel is absent, I find no gender difference in perpetrator-centered practices or in sensationalist language (Appendix Figure A.1).³⁵ Similarly, a classifier trained to predict a reporter's gender from the text of male-victim articles achieves an accuracy of 0.53, close to random guessing (Appendix Figure A.2b). Finally, Appendix Table A.16 shows that female and male reporters score similarly on different indicators of reporting and writing quality.

A related possibility is that female reporters write differently because they specialize in violence against women, bringing more expertise to these stories rather than a different perspective. Female reporters have more experience in writing on these topics, but controlling for each reporter's prior

³⁵The victim-centered practices, and the practices reported in guidelines more broadly, are specific to violence against women. How a homicide is reported depends systematically on the victim's gender, so these practices have no counterpart for male-victim homicides. I therefore compare female and male reporters only on the perpetrator-centered practices and sensationalist language, which general crime-reporting guidelines address for any homicide.

and total volume of VAW coverage does not affect the female reporter coefficient (Appendix Table A.10). Moreover, gender differences in the use of VC narratives emerge for all reporters, regardless of their degree of specialization (Appendix Table A.11). Similarly, gender differences in the use of PC narratives are observed only among VAW reporters, ruling out the role of higher VAW expertise in explaining the results.

Narratives could also be shaped less by the reporter than by the editorial process around them, like the desk editor who assigns the story. Although crime desk editors are mainly men, I investigate this channel by hand-collecting information about desk editors for the newspapers in my sample.³⁶ Looking at the effect of desk editors' gender, Appendix Table A.12 shows no differences along this dimension, confirming the role of reporters in driving the effect. Similarly, focusing only on articles written on weekends, when editorial oversight is lower, reinforces the gender differences rather than eliminating them (Appendix Table A.13).

Additionally, how reporters' identities translate into different narratives may depend on the sources they draw on: a reporter who speaks with the victim's family, rather than with the police, will more naturally produce a victim-centered account. Reporters in my sample do not systematically differ in their mentions of most sources, like police, family, or neighbors (Appendix Table A.14). Moreover, controlling for the sources cited does not move the main effect (Appendix Table A.15).

Finally, female and male reporters may simply hold different beliefs about what is newsworthy regarding these crimes. This channel is the hardest to isolate, since I do not directly observe beliefs about newsworthiness. However, it is plausible to assume that such beliefs are formed largely at the outlet level, a dimension held fixed by the newspaper-year fixed effects. I also investigate readers' preferences more directly in the online experiment (Section 6).

Robustness. I show that the results on gender differences in reporting are robust to a series of alternative specifications and sample restrictions. First, I consider the probability of at least one topic for each index appearing in the article. Appendix Table A.5 shows a similar pattern to the main results with the standardized index.

Additionally, I address the concern that journalists may select into crimes for articles after the first one. To account for the possibility of selection in follow-up articles, I show that the results are robust to the inclusion of article order times crime fixed effects (Column 1 of Appendix Tables A.17 and A.18) and to restricting the sample to the first or first five articles per newspaper-crime (Appendix Tables A.20 and A.21). Because only 40% of the articles carry a byline, I also verify that this selection does not drive the results. Appendix Table A.23 shows that whether an article is signed is predicted by its length and format rather than by the characteristics of the crime. Moreover, adding the unsigned articles back with an indicator for missing authorship (Appendix

³⁶I reconstruct the head of each newspaper's local crime desk by cross-checking newspaper composition and staff pages, trade-press archives (professionereporter.eu, primaonline.it), in-house newsroom histories, and incidental mentions of editors at public events. The panel documents 101 desk editors, 17 of whom are women. The few documented female desk heads are concentrated in small editions of local newspapers.

Table A.24), and separately controlling for article length or including length-decile fixed effects (Appendix Table A.25), both leave the main effect unchanged.

Moreover, I show that the results are robust to different fixed effects and clustering options (Appendix Tables A.17, A.18, and A.19). Also, it could be that the effect is driven by a few popular crimes that attract media attention due to their characteristics. To account for this, I show that the results are robust to weighting by the inverse of the number of articles about the same crime in each newspaper and excluding crimes that are covered by 10 or more articles in the same newspaper (Column 5 in Appendix Tables A.20, A.21, A.17 and A.18). Finally, Appendix Tables A.20 and A.21 show that the results are stable when restricting the sample to murders by intimate partners and Italian perpetrators, when including only reporters who appear in my sample as authors of both crimes with female and male victims, and when restricting to newspapers with enough reporters writing on these crimes, where the assignment to news is unlikely to be mechanical (Appendix Table A.22).

5 Effects of Exposure to Female Reporters on Help-Seeking

Section 4 shows that reporters' gender shapes how murders of women are covered. A natural question that follows the analysis in the previous section is: do these different narrative choices matter, or are they simply a way for reporters to express their writing preferences? This section shows that they have real consequences for readers' behavior. First, it shows that higher exposure to articles written by female reporters increases help-seeking behavior by VAW victims, proxied by calls to the Italian helpline to counter VAW. Next, it provides evidence that this effect is driven by victim-centered narratives. Section 5.1 describes the empirical strategy, and Section 5.2 reports the results, mechanisms, and robustness checks.

5.1 Empirical Strategy

I investigate whether exposure to articles on murders of women written by female reporters affects help-seeking behavior, measured through the number of calls to the VAW helpline. To correctly capture exposure to female reporters, I combine the articles data with information about their readership in each province and year. I construct the exposure measure for each province (p) and week (yw) as the share of articles written by a woman in a week, where articles are weighted by the lagged market share of the newspaper in that province:

$$FemExp_{pyw} = \sum_n \frac{\sum_a \mathbf{1}[FemaleRep_{a(e)nyw}]}{TotArt_{nyw}} MktShr_{np,y-1} \quad (4)$$

where $FemaleRep_{a(e)nyw}$ is an indicator of whether article a about crime e in newspaper n and in week yw is written by a woman, $TotArt_{nyw}$ is the total number of articles about those types of crime by n in week yw , and $MktShr_{np,y-1} = \frac{Readership_{np,y-1}}{\sum_n Readership_{np,y-1}}$ is the market share of newspaper n

in province p and year $y - 1$. This way, the measure captures only newspapers read in a specific province and weights them for their relative popularity in that province. $FRExp_{pyw}$ captures the exposure to articles by female reporters in p and yw , considering articles about *any* murders of women.

The coefficient from an OLS regression of helpline calls on this measure is likely to be biased.³⁷ Therefore, I leverage a generalized difference-in-differences design with a continuous treatment as an empirical approach, relying on the within-newspaper exogeneity in the assignment of journalists to murders and on the timing of these events. A primary concern regarding the timing and location of the murders is that they are more likely to occur in places that already have high crime rates. To alleviate this concern, I show that female-victim murders are uncorrelated with male-victim murders ($\rho = 0.02$) and with other crime rates (Appendix Figure A.23). Additionally, Appendix Figure A.22 shows that female-victim murders are almost always isolated, with mainly one per province-month, whereas male-victim murders are more dispersed, clustering in place and time.

To avoid considering reporters selected to cover such crimes, I construct the exposure measure using only the first five articles for each crime and newspaper if these articles were published in the same week as the murder or the following one. Moreover, I consider as *treated* only provinces where the murder occurs. Finally, each province remains *treated* for a limited period after the murder, as provinces can be treated more than once in my sample.³⁸ Indeed, while the majority of provinces witness only one crime each year (Appendix Figure A.13a), in some years provinces can experience as many as 13 murders each year. At the same time, two murders rarely happen within the same month (Appendix Figure A.13b). The main regression of interest is as follows:

$$Calls_{pyw} = \delta_1 FemExp_{pyw}^{5Art.} + \delta_2 FemExp_{pyw}^{5Art.} \times PostMurder_{pyw} + \alpha_p + \alpha_m + \alpha_i + \varepsilon_{pyw} \quad (5)$$

where $Calls_{pyw}$ is the number of calls in each province and week. $FemExp_{pyw}^{5Art.}$ is the treatment for crime c , i.e., the measure of exposure to articles by female reporters, considering the first five articles for each newspaper and crime in the first two weeks following the crime, and $PostMurder_{pyw}$ is an indicator for the period after the murder. α_p , α_m , and α_i are province, month, and time-from-murder fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the province level.

The main assumption for δ_2 to causally estimate the effect of exposure to female reporters on calls in a standard DiD design is that calls in provinces with different exposure to female reporters would have followed the same trajectory, absent a murder and its subsequent coverage. I test this parallel-trends assumption with the event-study regression below, checking for pre-trends. However, settings with a continuous treatment demand a *stronger* version of the parallel trends assumption: units exposed to different treatment doses would have reacted similarly at

³⁷Recall that the exogenous assignment of reporters to crimes holds only for the first few articles following the crime. Therefore, selection of reporters into articles could arise for follow-up pieces, particularly for articles by reporters outside of the crime unit, e.g., editors may ask female reporters to write opinion articles about cases that become popular, which are also more likely to lead to an increase in calls.

³⁸I use an eight-week window around the murder in the regression analysis and a fifteen-week window in the event-study.

every *dose* of treatment (Callaway et al., 2024). In this context, this means that provinces with different likelihoods of being exposed to female reporters would have reacted similarly had they been exposed to the same share. To partially capture potentially different reactions to articles, I include in regression (5) the proxies for gender norms at the regional level. Moreover, because each province is treated more than once, province fixed effects let me identify the effect from within-province variation in exposure, addressing this concern. As a final test for the plausibility of this stronger assumption, I compare crime characteristics across crimes with above- and below-median exposure, following Callaway et al. (2024), and show this is indeed balanced on crime characteristics (Appendix Table A.26).

Finally, I estimate an event study with a binarized treatment, using the estimator of Chaisemartin et al. (2024) and Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille (2024). This allows units to switch treatment status and corrects the bias that heterogeneous treatment effects introduce in staggered designs (Goodman-Bacon, 2021; Callaway and Sant’Anna, 2021):

$$Calls_{pyw} = \sum_{i \in [-5, 10]} \delta_i^g Treat_{pyw}^g \times W_{yw+i} + \alpha_p + \alpha_{yw} + \varepsilon_{pyw}, \quad g \in \{TopQ, BottomQ\} \quad (6)$$

where $Treat_{pyw}^{TopQ}$ and $Treat_{pyw}^{BottomQ}$ are indicators of whether the crime has the exposure measure in the top quartile or the bottom quartile of the treatment distribution, and W_{yw+i} is an indicator for being in week $yw + i$.

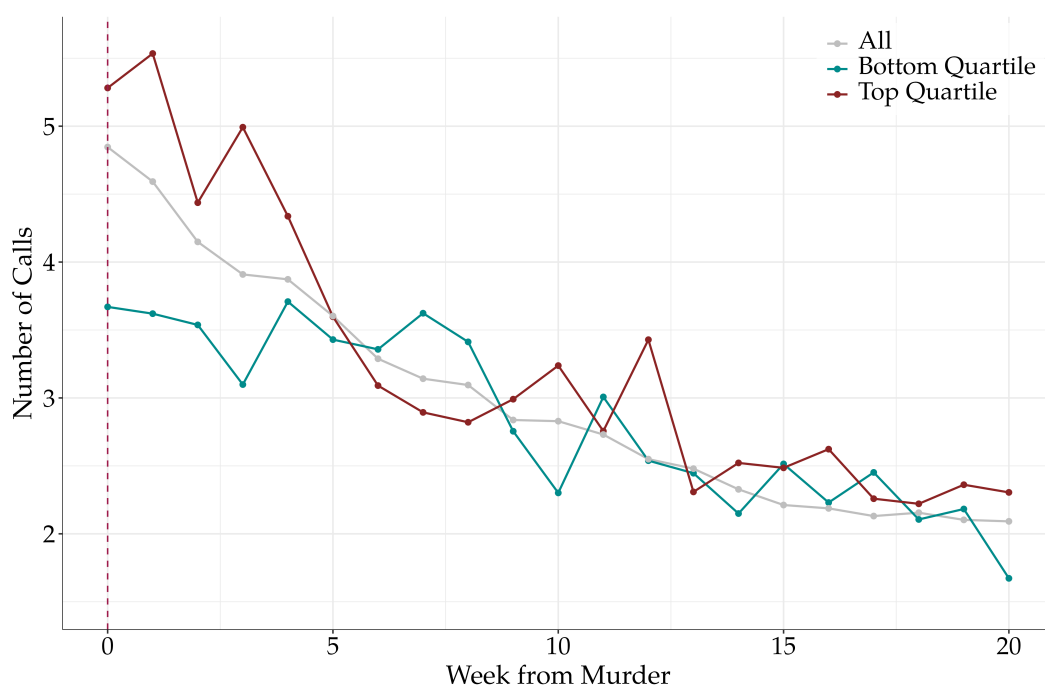
5.2 Results

The OLS results in Appendix Table A.27 show a positive effect of female-reporter exposure on calls, significant across all specifications and outcomes except the logarithmic transformation. In particular, Column 3 shows that a 50-percentage-point increase in the exposure measure, corresponding to an additional article written by a woman per crime and newspaper, is associated with a 0.06 increase in calls, or a 4% increase. This effect is about a quarter the size of a murder in the same province-week and 80% of one in the same region, so the murder itself remains the main driver of calls. The evolution of calls in the weeks after a murder reported in Figure 4 shows a similar pattern. After the murder of a woman, calls in the same province increase. However, the increase is larger for observations with high exposure to female reporters in the first five weeks following the murder.³⁹

Next, I estimate the two-way fixed effects regression (5), looking at both the probability of at least one call and the total number of calls in an eight-week window around the murder. To account for potential differences in treatment effects depending on the level of the treatment received, I also include a proxy for gender norms in the region of the murder. The results reported in Table 5 confirm the positive effect of exposure to female reporters on calls and suggest a much stronger

³⁹ Appendix Figure A.4, which plots the number of calls residualized on province fixed effects, shows that this is true only for articles on murders of women, while there is no difference across female or male reporters’ coverage for articles on murders with male victims.

Figure 4: Calls to Helpline in the Weeks after Murder by Exposure to Female Reporters



Notes. Time series of the number of calls in the province of the murder in the 20 weeks after the murder happens. The time series is plotted considering all province-week observations and separately for observations with the female reporters' exposure measure in the bottom and top quartiles of its distribution.

Table 5: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Helpline Calls

	At Least 1 Call				Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art} × Post	0.106 (0.068)	0.116* (0.067)	0.116* (0.067)	0.140* (0.072)	0.246 (0.177)	0.302* (0.183)	0.302* (0.181)	0.426 (0.299)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art}	-0.047 (0.059)	-0.083 (0.057)	-0.083 (0.057)		-0.078 (0.187)	-0.271 (0.168)	-0.270 (0.167)	
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6905
R ²	0.268	0.282	0.282	0.393	0.535	0.564	0.564	0.567
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Crime FE				X				X
Gender Norms Control			X	X			X	X

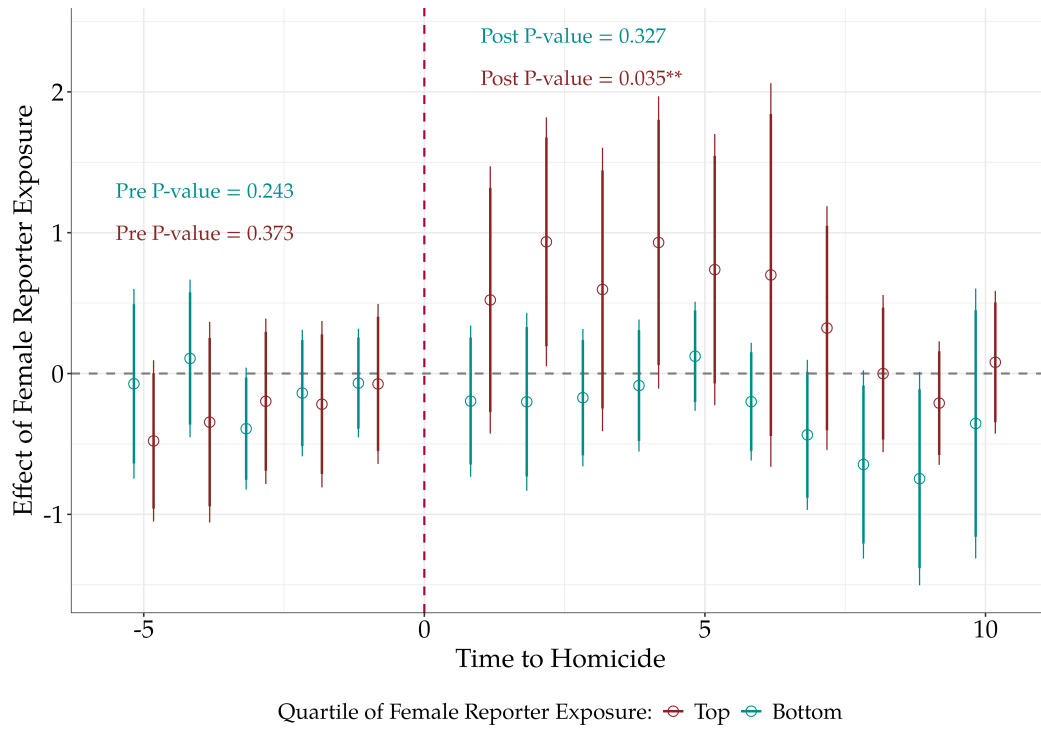
Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on calls estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. Columns 1 to 4 report the linear probability estimate of there being at least one call (extensive margin). Columns 5 to 8 report results using the number of calls as outcomes and a Poisson model. Columns 1 and 5 report the OLS and Poisson estimates, including province and weeks-from-murder fixed effects, while Columns 2 and 6 also add month fixed effects, and Columns 3 and 7 control for the proxy for gender norms. Columns 4 and 8 also include crime fixed effects. The R² in Columns 5 to 8 corresponds to the pseudo R² calculated for the Poisson regression. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

relationship than the one highlighted in Appendix Table A.27. The interaction coefficient on the probability of having at least one call is positive and significant in Columns 2 to 4. The estimate in Column 3 implies that higher female-reporter exposure after a murder raises the probability of at least one call by 12 percentage points in the province of the murder. Second, I investigate the effect on the number of calls. One potential issue when using the number of calls and a linear model is that the distribution of calls is skewed towards zero (Appendix Figure A.19). To account for this, I use a Poisson model and report the results in Columns 5 to 8 of Table 5.⁴⁰ As with the probability of at least one call, the coefficient is positive across all columns and significant in most models. Assuming an increase of one article per newspaper and crime written by a female reporter—corresponding to a 50 percentage point increase in the female exposure measure—the number of calls increases by 17%, corresponding to around one additional call for each province and week. Columns 4 and 8 also include crime fixed effects to account for crime-specific characteristics that might affect the number of calls, yielding similar results despite the conservative specification.

Finally, in Figure 5, I report the coefficients from the event study regression 6 for the two versions of the binarized treatments. Reassuringly, the figure shows no effect of the treatment in the weeks before the murder for both treatment variables. Moreover, being in the bottom quartile of exposure has no effect on calls, even after the murder. By contrast, being in the top quartile of exposure raises calls by between half and one additional call per province-week in the first

⁴⁰ Appendix Table A.33 reports the results using the zero-inflated Poisson model to further alleviate this concern.

Figure 5: Event Study: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Helpline Calls



Notes. Calls to the helpline number before and after a murder happens in the same province for increasing exposure to female reporters in the first five articles covering the crime. The figure plots the coefficient from regression 6 using two binarized versions of the treatment: being in the bottom quartile and the top quartile of the distribution. The regression includes province and week fixed effects. It shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals constructed by clustering errors at the province level. Overlaid text reports the p-value from an F-test for the joint significance of the pre- (top left) and post-murder (top right) coefficients: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 6: Effect of Exposure to Narratives on Helpline Calls

	Number of Calls (Poisson)					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Victim-Cent. Narr. ^{5Art}	0.460** (0.189)	-0.067 (0.151)	-0.071 (0.151)			
Victim-Cent. Narr. ^{5Art} × Post	0.512*** (0.161)	0.514*** (0.186)	0.521*** (0.187)			
Perp.-Cent. Narr. ^{5Art}				1.601*** (0.338)	0.492* (0.297)	0.494* (0.295)
Perp.-Cent. Narr. ^{5Art} × Post				-0.152 (0.439)	0.225 (0.501)	0.229 (0.498)
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980
R ²	0.538	0.564	0.564	0.538	0.564	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.111	0.111	0.111	0.079	0.079	0.079
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE		X	X		X	X
Gender Norms Control			X			X

Notes. Effect of exposure to victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered narratives (Columns 4 to 6) on calls estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. All columns report the results from a Poisson regression, including province and weeks-from-murder fixed effects. Columns 2-3 and 5-6 also add month fixed effects and control for the proxy for gender norms. The R² corresponds to the pseudo R² calculated for the Poisson regression. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

four weeks after the murder. Overall, this evidence points towards a positive and sizable effect of exposure to female reporters on help-seeking behavior in the weeks following the murder of a woman.

Mechanisms. A potential explanation for this effect is that higher exposure to female reporters could have a direct effect on readers through the *product* itself. Given the evidence in Section 4 on differences in narrative choices by female and male reporters, narratives used by female reporters may change perceptions of VAW and help-seeking, triggering more calls. To investigate this, I construct a measure of initial exposure to victim-centered and perpetrator-centered narratives similarly to the main treatment variable. Appendix Table A.28 confirms that female-reporter exposure is positively correlated with VC-narrative exposure and negatively correlated with PC-narrative exposure. Next, I run the difference-in-differences regression 5 using initial exposure to narratives as the treatment and report the results in Table 6. The results show a positive, significant effect of victim-centered exposure on calls (Columns 1–3) and no significant effect of perpetrator-centered exposure (Columns 4–6), suggesting a direct effect of victim-centered narratives.

Alternatively, the effect could occur via exposure to female news producers. Echoing the literature on role models, female readers may be more attentive to news written by female reporters or more likely to react to an article when seeing the name of a woman, leading to more calls (Miller and Segal, 2019; Beaman et al., 2009). I find no evidence for this channel in Appendix Table A.29, showing that the positive effect on calls is driven by female reporters who use victim-centered narratives, while there is a null effect for those who do not use such narratives. Finally, it could be that greater female reporter coverage leads to more coverage of the crime. To rule this out, Appendix Figure A.5 shows no difference in the volume of articles on murders of women beyond the first two weeks between high- and low-exposure places.

Taken together, all this evidence points towards the effect of exposure to female reporters on calls being driven by the narratives they use rather than by a role model effect or increased salience or volume of reporting. Why would exposure to victim-centered coverage raise calls? Two channels are plausible: victim-centered narratives may lower *informational* barriers by making readers aware that help resources exist, or shift the perceived *social norms* around help-seeking by increasing the stakes and making it more visible. I provide preliminary evidence on this, splitting the exposure measure into its three victim-centered components: mentioning the pre-existing violence underlying the crime, labeling it as a femicide, and providing information on support resources. Appendix Table A.30 hints that the effect operates mainly through mentions of pre-existing violence. The resource coefficient is similar in magnitude but non-significant, as this component appears in fewer than 4% of early articles, too rarely to be informative.

This pattern is more consistent with the social-norms channel than with pure information provision. Still, the resource component is too sparse to draw any conclusions. Additionally, given the endogeneity of narratives to reporters' gender, this setting does not allow me to identify the effect of different narratives on readers' behavior. Therefore, in Section 6, I complement this analysis with an experiment that isolates the mechanisms behind the effect and measures outcomes unavailable in observational data.

Robustness. This section presents additional robustness checks, reported in Appendix Section A.6. First, to rule out that the effect reflects general exposure to female crime reporters, I use murders with male victims as a placebo. Building an analogous treatment from their coverage, in Appendix Figure A.6, I find a null effect, and show that the same holds for male-victim murders occurring shortly before a female-victim one in the same province (Appendix Table A.31). I confirm this in a triple-difference design that pools the two types of murder and adds victim gender as a third source of variation. Appendix Table A.32 shows that the triple interaction is positive and close to the main estimate, while the effect for male victims is null. This holds when I drop male-victim murders occurring close in time to a female-victim one, ruling out contamination across windows.

A second concern is that spillovers could violate the stable unit treatment value assumption (SUTVA): if female exposure raises calls in the province where the crime occurs, it may also do so in other provinces exposed to similar news, attenuating my estimates. I test for this by estimating

the effect of female exposure on neighboring provinces. There, the effect is weaker than in the province of the crime and non-significant (Appendix Figure A.7), mitigating this concern. The effect thus appears only where the crime is most salient, consistent with residents of the affected province being more likely to read femicide coverage in full, which would confine the narratives' influence to that province and further alleviate SUTVA concerns.

Next, in Appendix Tables A.33 and A.34, I provide evidence that the results are similar when using different treatment definitions, like varying the number of articles used to compute it, although the results are less precise. I also show that the results hold when excluding crimes occurring within 10 weeks of another crime in the same province (Appendix Figure A.8). In Appendix Table A.35, I show that the results hold when including gender norms times year fixed effects, and controlling for the total number of murders with female victims, the total number of female reporters on other murders, and other crime rates in each province-year.

Finally, I use randomization inference to check that the effect reflects the crime-specific female coverage rather than a province's overall exposure. Re-estimating the main specification with a reshuffled version of the weekly female-reporter shares across weeks within each province and each province-year produces a null distribution centered at zero, with the true estimate in its tail (Appendix Figure A.9). The effect thus depends on which weeks actually carried female-heavy coverage, not on cross-province differences in average exposure. I also find no effect using placebo murders that replicate the yearly distribution of murders across provinces (Appendix Figure A.10).

6 Experimental Evidence on VC and PC Narratives

Section 5 shows that exposure to victim-centered narratives raises help-seeking and hints at a role for mentioning pre-existing violence, though observational data cannot identify this cleanly. As anticipated above, several mechanisms could drive the rise in calls: victims may underestimate how widespread this phenomenon is, a misperception that reporting data can correct (Kuziemko et al., 2015; Alesina et al., 2018); they may be unaware that help resources exist (Daponte et al., 1999; Bettinger et al., 2012); or they may underestimate how often other women experience violence before the murder and seek help, so that making it visible increases help-seeking stakes and lowers its perceived social cost (Bursztyn et al., 2020b). Separating these channels requires exogenous variation in narratives and outcomes that administrative data do not provide.

This section supplies that variation through an online experiment, isolating the effect of narratives on individuals' attitudes and beliefs. Additionally, to understand the drivers of reporters' narrative choices, I test the effect of narratives on engagement as a proxy for reporters' monetary and career incentives. Section 6.1 describes the design, and Section 6.2 reports the results.

6.1 Experimental Design

I conduct an online experiment with 1,508 Italian respondents.⁴¹ Appendix Figure B.3 reports summary statistics about the sample. The figure shows that the sample is balanced across gender, but it is unbalanced across dimensions like age and political affiliation. In particular, while the sample accurately captures abstention levels in Italy, it is heavily skewed towards the left and the right is under-represented, leading progressive gender norms to be over-represented (Appendix Figure B.6).⁴² Respondents are also most likely to use websites of newspapers and social media to stay informed and are equally distributed across Italy once accounting for the population of provinces (Appendix Figures B.4 and B.5).

Respondents are randomly assigned to one of four experimental conditions, each containing the same newspaper article and a different narrative reflecting the gender differences uncovered in Section 4.⁴³ In the *Control* group, respondents read only the baseline article, either on crime A or crime B. The first treatment, *Perpetrator-Centered (PC) Treatment*, provides background on the possible motives of the perpetrator, highlighting the two most distinctive aspects of male reporters' writing: jealousy and a fit of rage. I then create two versions of the VC narratives treatment to capture the two different pieces of information provided by news articles. First, the *Episodic Victim-Centered (EVC) Treatment* focuses on the pre-existing violence between the victim and the perpetrator and her actions, like seeking help. Second, the *Thematic Victim-Centered (TVC) Treatment* provides information on help resources and data about violence against women in Italy.⁴⁴ All treatments are reported both in Italian and English in Appendix Section E.2.1.

I focus on four different outcomes. First, I elicit attitudes towards the victim and the perpetrator by using a version of the empathy-thermometer question by Alrababa'h et al. (2021). Second, I look at preferences for government intervention by asking respondents to sign a *simulated* petition to increase the resources dedicated to supporting policies that counter violence against women.⁴⁵ Third, I measure the perceived prevalence of VAW (non-incentivized) and help-seeking through police reporting and helpline calls (incentivized) in the province where the respondent resides.⁴⁶

⁴¹The experiment was run in February and March 2026, pre-registered at the AEA RCT Registry ([AEARCTR-0017870](#)) and approved by the IRB at Harvard University. Appendix Table B.13 shows that respondents' characteristics are balanced across treatments.

⁴²At the last national elections held in 2022, the right-wing coalition won with 44% of votes, while the left-wing coalition obtained 26% of votes. About 36% of people did not turn out.

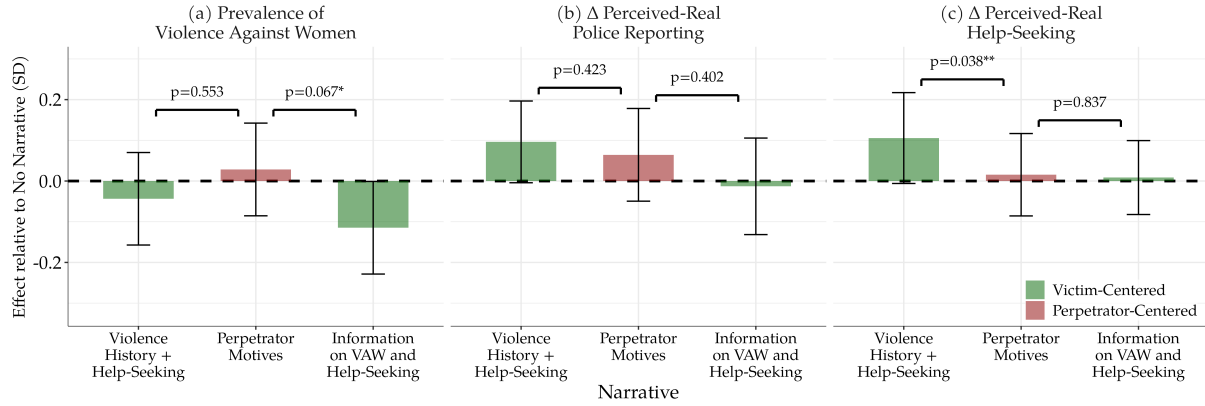
⁴³The articles are based on real news articles about crimes where the names of the people involved are changed. These articles are attributed to a fictional outlet rather than a real one to avoid confounding the narrative treatment with respondents' priors about that outlet.

⁴⁴This distinction of victim-centered narratives into the background of the victim (episodic framing) and information on the context (thematic framing) is important from both a policy and theoretical perspective. From a theoretical perspective, the literature in political science and linguistics predicts that framing news in an episodic versus a thematic way affects whether the crime is perceived as an isolated event or a signal of a more systematic issue, and, consequently, preferences for government intervention and perceptions (Iyengar, 1991). Additionally, if these narratives lead to different effects, the distinction would also be important for journalists and policymakers.

⁴⁵To increase the stakes of the outcome, I tell them I will report to a parliamentary commission the share of respondents who signed the petition.

⁴⁶For perceptions of help-seeking, I have access to the real corresponding data. Therefore, I incentivize the questions by offering a monetary reward if their guesses are close to the true value, and I use the deviation of their guesses from

Figure 6: Effect of Narratives on Perceptions of VAW and Help-Seeking



Notes. Perceptions about prevalence of violence against Women (Panel a) and deviations between perceived and real police reporting (Panel b) and help-seeking behavior (Panel c), separately by treatment. The outcomes are measured as prevalence among 10,000 women in the province of the respondents and then standardized to have mean equal 0 and standard deviation equal 1. The treatment descriptions are reported in Appendix Section E.2.1. The figure reports 90% confidence intervals. Stars above each VC bar report the p-value of that treatment versus PC, from a regression on all treatments (excluding the control) with covariates, as pre-registered: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Finally, I test the treatments' effect on engagement with the newspaper. I rely on two metrics used in newsrooms to measure engagement: retention and click-through rate. To proxy retention, I measure respondents' willingness to return to the newspaper (*declared retention*) by asking whether they would use the same outlet for crime information. Then, I mimic the visual layout of news articles in online newspapers by adding links below the main article to other articles they can click on, and record their clicks to simulate a click-through rate. I focus on these two metrics because newsrooms track them and because they map onto the two revenue models an outlet can rely on.⁴⁷

6.2 Experimental Results

To investigate the mechanisms behind the effect on calls, Figure 6 tests whether exposure to different narratives affects perceptions of the prevalence of violence against women, police reporting of such crimes, and help-seeking behavior, proxied by helpline calls.⁴⁸ Panel (a) shows that the TVC treatment reduces the perceived prevalence of VAW relative to other treatments, suggesting that respondents overestimate the extent of the phenomenon rather than underestimate it.⁴⁹ Next, Panels (b) and (c) show episodic victim-centered narratives increase perceptions of prevalence of

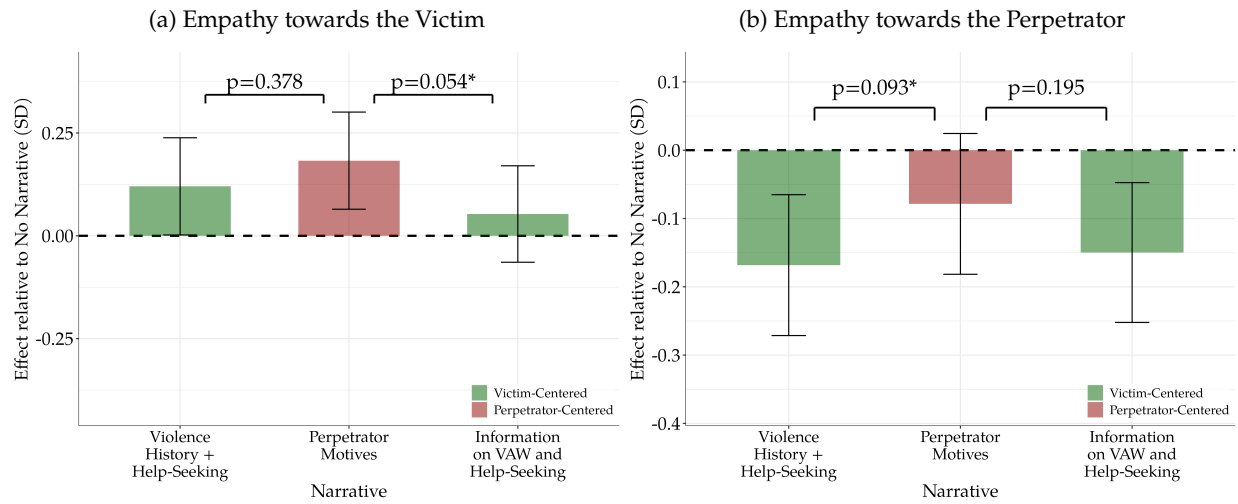
the true value as the outcome. I report the full questionnaire in Appendix Section E.2.2.

⁴⁷Click-through rate is mainly associated with the advertising-based model, as a reader clicking through to a linked article delivers an additional page view carrying an additional set of ads. In contrast, retention sustains a subscription-based model. The two are not mutually exclusive, since returning readers also generate impressions, but click-through is the within-session margin that directly drives advertising gains.

⁴⁸As pre-registered, I test whether the victim-centered treatments increase perceptions about these variables compared to perpetrator-centered narratives.

⁴⁹Respondents in fact overestimate prevalence in every treatment arm, so the thematic treatment's real statistics pull beliefs toward the truth.

Figure 7: Effect of Narratives on Empathy towards Victim and Perpetrator



Notes. Standardized respondents' attitudes separately by treatment. Panel (a) reports the results for empathy towards the victim, while Panel (b) for empathy towards the perpetrator. Empathy is measured on a scale from 0 (*not feeling close*) to 100 (*feeling very close*) and then standardized to have mean equal 0 and standard deviation equal 1. The treatment descriptions are reported in Appendix Section E.2.1. The figure reports 90% confidence intervals. Stars above each VC bar give the p-value of that treatment versus PC, from a regression on all treatments (excluding the control) with covariates: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

helpline calls compared to PC narratives, whereas this is not true for TVC narratives. This suggests that, rather than increasing awareness of help resources, VC narratives increase awareness of help-seeking behavior and could lead to normalizing it and reducing the perceived social cost of doing so. In line with this interpretation, Appendix Tables B.4 and B.5 show that the effect is entirely driven by female respondents and respondents with daughters, who are more sensitive to the topic.⁵⁰

Next, in Figure 7, I investigate the narrative effects on standardized empathy, as a proxy for attitudes, separately by treatment.⁵¹ I find that respondents in the EVC treatment feel more empathetic towards the victim compared to the control. However, this is also true for PC narratives, contrary to what is hypothesized by the linguistic literature on this topic (Palazzolo and Roberto, 2011; Carlyle et al., 2014).⁵² Moving to empathy toward the perpetrator, Panel (b) shows no significant effect of PC narratives relative to the control. Victim-centered narratives, by contrast, lower empathy toward the perpetrator relative to both the control and the PC treatment. In

⁵⁰In Appendix Section B.2, I show that the results on the main outcomes are robust across different sample restrictions, such as when excluding respondents who failed at least one attention check, or when dropping variations of the treatments. Notably, the effect of the VC narrative on perceptions of help-seeking is stronger when the victim goes to the authorities for help, strengthening the interpretation of the mechanism through the social norms channel.

⁵¹Regression results are reported in Appendix Tables B.1 and B.2.

⁵²One potential explanation for this pattern could be the skewness to the left of the sample: given that, from a legal perspective, jealousy falls into the futile motives category in the context of murders, most progressive individuals might feel closer to the victim if they read about it. In line with this, Appendix Table B.1 shows that the effect seems to be driven by left-leaning respondents, although the sample of right-leaning respondents is too small to reach any conclusions about this.

Appendix Figure B.1, I also look at the treatment effect on the share of respondents signing the petition as a proxy for preferences for government intervention. I find a null effect of all treatments on willingness to sign the petition. Thus, I find no support for the prediction from Iyengar (1991) that thematic framing increases preferences for government intervention in this context.

Finally, I investigate the potential engagement returns from narratives. The full sample results (Appendix Figure B.2) show that PC narratives lead to a lower declared retention rate, but generate a higher click-through rate. To better understand these dynamics, I investigate the effect on engagement separately by gender and report the results in Figure 8. The results for male and female respondents show substantial heterogeneity: the drop in retention under perpetrator-centered narratives comes entirely from women, while male respondents display a lower click-through rate when seeing VC narratives. Newspapers thus face a trade-off in framing such news: perpetrator-centered narratives risk alienating female readers and their future readership, but relying entirely on victim-centered narratives forgoes articles' click-through engagement by men.

7 Discussion

Taken together, the results provide robust evidence that journalists are identity-motivated when choosing crime-reporting narratives, and that this identity-driven persuasion channel shapes help-seeking and attitudes. To better interpret the results of the paper, in Appendix Section D I propose a model of identity-motivated journalists in which journalists decide which narratives to use, accounting for readers' preferences and the direct effects of these narratives on readers. As in a standard probabilistic voting model (Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987), journalists maximize monetary returns from narratives by computing the share of readers they would capture, given the distribution of readers' preferences, which differ across groups. Moreover, I assume that the reader's identity mediates how they are directly affected by narratives, and I include the utility of in-group readers in that of journalists.⁵³

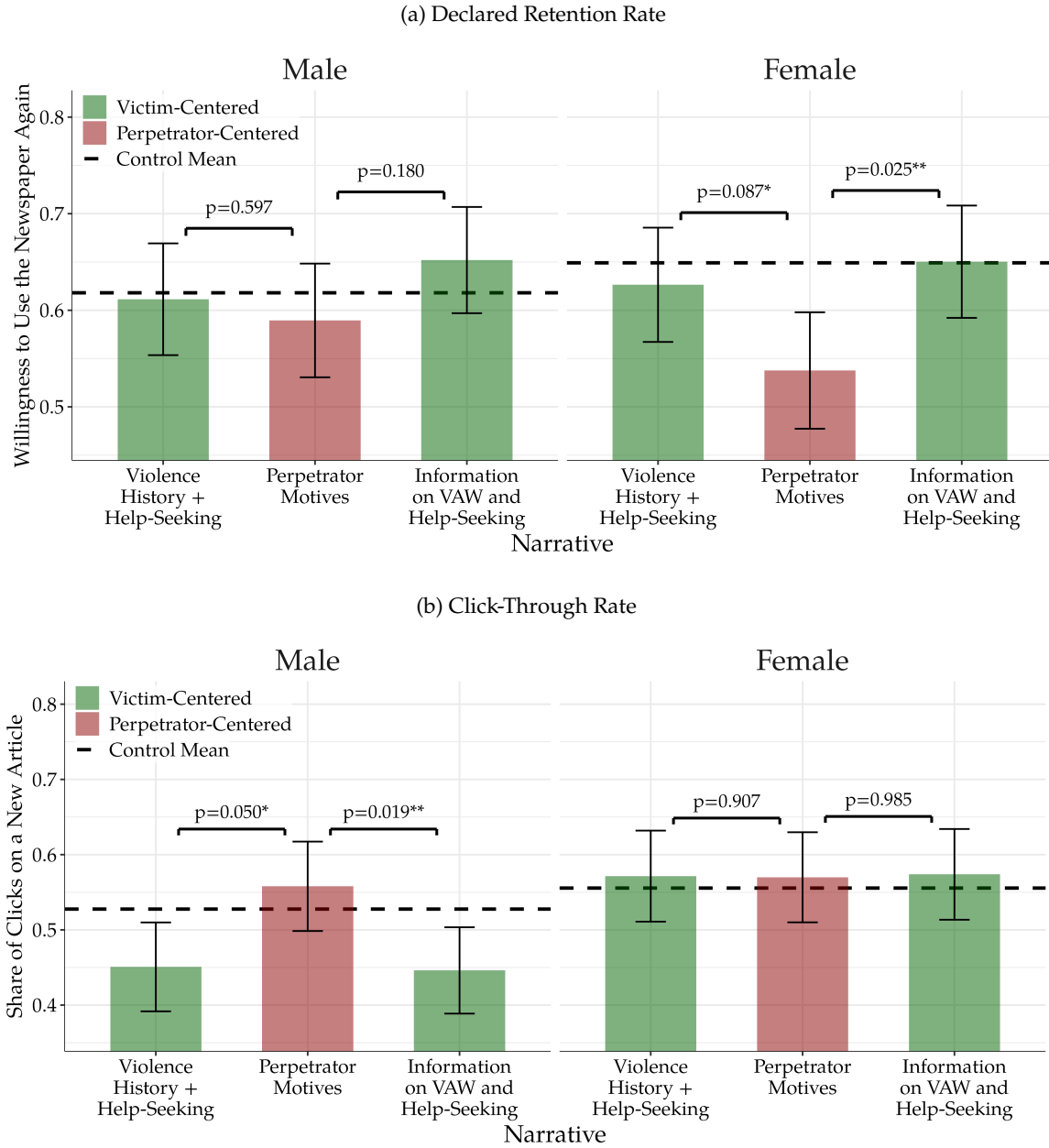
In the absence of identity concerns among journalists, the optimal narrative depends solely on maximizing readers' utility from both groups, leading all journalists to converge on the same narrative, assuming they share the same consumer base.⁵⁴ Conversely, if journalists are also driven by identity motives, namely, if their utility increases with that of their in-group, they do not always choose the profit-maximizing narrative.⁵⁵ Specifically, journalists choose the narrative that benefits their group rather than the profit-maximizing one when they either strongly care about

⁵³This component combines insights from the literature on social identity in psychology and economics, which suggest that group identity affects individuals' choices and behavior (Turner et al., 1979; Akerlof and Kranton, 2000; Chen and Li, 2009), with that on other-regarding preferences (Andreoni and Miller, 2002; Fehr and Schmidt, 2006), suggesting that individuals are more likely to favor in-group members.

⁵⁴The optimal narrative depends on the preferences of the largest group among readers (Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Grossman and Helpman, 1996; Persson and Tabellini, 2002).

⁵⁵Works in social psychology (Tajfel and Turner, 2004) and in economics (Chen and Li, 2009; Shayo, 2009) show that individuals are more likely to favor members of their in-group when identity is salient. However, other studies provide mixed evidence on in-group bias in contexts where decision-makers also need to account for other incentives (Depew et al., 2017; Ash et al., 2025; Guo et al., 2023), as here, where journalists must also account for monetary incentives.

Figure 8: Effect of Narratives on News Engagement by Gender



Notes. Engagement metrics by treatment, presented separately by gender. Panel (a) reports the results for the declared retention rate, measured as the willingness to use newspapers in the future. Panel (b) reports the results for click-through rate, measured by monitoring respondents' clicks on another article linked at the bottom of the main one. The dashed line marks the control mean. The treatment descriptions are reported in Appendix Section E.2.1. The figure reports 90% confidence intervals. Stars above each VC bar give the p-value of that treatment versus PC, from a regression on all treatments (excluding the control) with covariates: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

their group's utility or when the narrative is more likely to be their group's preferred one.

Through the lens of this model, the evidence in Section 4 implies that journalists are not driven solely by reader-maximizing motives. Instead, since the results show that female and male reporters systematically choose different narratives when reporting on murders of women, they are also likely to be driven by identity motives. In the model, this follows from two components of readers' utility functions: first, exposure to a specific narrative can affect readers differently across groups; second, readers from different groups have different preference distributions over narratives. Sections 5 and 6 provide evidence that both conditions hold in this setting.

The analysis in Section 5 shows that higher initial exposure to female reporters after the murder of a woman raises calls to the VAW helpline. Two channels could underlie this effect. First, an indirect channel operating through reporter identity: echoing the broader literature on descriptive representation, female readers may be more attentive to, or more likely to be persuaded by, articles written by women (Miller and Segal, 2019; Beaman et al., 2009). Second, a direct channel operating through content: the different narratives female reporters employ may increase awareness of resources and update readers' perceptions of help-seeking norms, thereby reducing informational and norms-related barriers to calling the helpline. Additional analyses support the latter interpretation. Replacing the female exposure measure with narrative-specific ones shows a positive, significant effect of victim-centered narratives on calls, while the effect of perpetrator-centered narratives is small and non-significant. Additionally, the positive effect of exposure to female reporters is driven only by those who use victim-centered narratives, suggesting a direct effect of such narratives on help-seeking behavior. This connects to Colagrossi et al. (2023), who show that coverage of murders with female victims raises calls to the same helpline, and suggests that a substantial part of that aggregate effect may operate through female reporters' use of victim-centered narratives.

The experimental evidence reported in Section 6 allows me to disentangle the mechanisms behind this narrative-induced change in behavior. The results show that providing information about victims' behavior increases perceptions of help-seeking, whereas information about the prevalence of the phenomenon or help resources does not, and even lowers perceived VAW prevalence. Further, the effect is driven by women and is larger for respondents with at least one daughter, whose perceptions of help-seeking norms are most socially relevant. I interpret this evidence as supporting a social norms channel (Bursztyn et al., 2020b): by making help-seeking behavior visible, VC narratives can shift perceived social norms around seeking formal assistance.

The increase in calls is not necessarily a welfare improvement. Even if victim-centered narratives marginally increase help-seeking through a social norms channel, the same increase could reflect changes in the underlying violence itself. Indeed, while it is possible that victim-centered coverage does not affect or even discourages the underlying violence, it could also lead to backlash from potential perpetrators and thus increase the incidence of violence against women. Isolating this would require outcomes that capture actual violence incidence, such as hospital admissions, which

are unavailable at the province-week level.⁵⁶ In the experiment, I attempt to capture this backlash by looking at empathy towards the victim and the perpetrator. The results show that VC narratives increase empathy towards the victim, as PC ones do, and lower empathy towards the perpetrator. Readers therefore turn against the perpetrator rather than the victim. However, this evidence is only suggestive and falls short of what would be needed to interpret the increase in calls in welfare terms.

Finally, the experimental results on engagement reveal an important asymmetry with direct implications for reporters' incentives. Perpetrator-centered narratives make female readers less likely to return to the outlet, while male readers click through less when they read victim-centered ones, reflecting the model's assumption that readers from different groups have different preferences over narratives. This creates a trade-off for outlets, even where the two motives align for the individual reporter. Maximizing short-term digital engagement pushes reporters toward perpetrator-centered framing, while retaining female readership pulls in the opposite direction. Which side dominates depends on how the outlet is financed, since each margin supports different revenue sources. Click-through rate is directly linked to advertising revenue, whereas subscription-based models mainly rely on retention.⁵⁷ Both models, though, assume that a story carries a single narrative. However, if preferences over narratives are group-specific, the engagement-maximizing strategy is instead a different narrative per reader, holding constant the story, a degree of personalization that newsrooms have not yet implemented.

This tension could also partially explain the gender differences in narrative choice: if female reporters prioritize retaining female readers and male reporters prioritize online engagement, narrative choices could partly reflect same-gender audience-maximizing behavior, consistent with the logic of Gentzkow and Shapiro (2010). Newspapers, however, observe readership only at the outlet level and cannot measure who reads a given article, so reporters are unlikely to be deliberately optimizing for a gendered audience, although they might be better at inferring what in-group readers prefer.

While I cannot fully disentangle these supply- and demand-side factors, the evidence presented in this paper highlights a determinant of news content one level below the outlet. Within the same newsroom, covering the same event, reporters make systematically different narrative choices, and those choices affect readers' behavior. This finding speaks directly to ongoing debates about diversity in media. If the gender composition of a newsroom shapes how stories are told, then policies aimed at increasing demographic diversity in journalism are not merely matters of representation but potentially consequential interventions in the information environment, with downstream effects. This is particularly relevant given the rapid rise of news influencers, creators who make personal identity a primary element of their news delivery. Among adults under 30, nearly four in ten now regularly get their news from such figures, with young audiences increasingly drawn to the intimacy and authenticity of personality-led content over traditional outlets (Forman-Katz

⁵⁶The closest outcome I observe is the murder frequency itself, which is too rare to allow for a powered analysis.

⁵⁷Consistent with this result, a related literature shows that an outlet's revenue structure shapes its content (Petrova, 2011; Angelucci and Cagé, 2019; Djourelova et al., 2025; Balbuzanov et al., 2025).

et al., 2025; Owen, 2026).

8 Conclusion

The question of who tells the news has taken on renewed importance as media outlets increasingly emphasize newsroom diversity and as personality-driven formats, from bylined columns to news influencers, place the identity of the messenger at the center of how information reaches the public. Whether and how reporter identity shapes the content audiences receive, and their responses to it, is a first-order question for both media research and policy.

This paper provides novel evidence that reporter identity shapes news content and, in turn, readers' behavior. Focusing on coverage of violence against women in Italy, the analysis estimates gender differences in reporting, relying on the exogenous assignment of journalists to crime stories. Female journalists are significantly more likely to adopt victim-centered narratives, contextualizing crimes within broader patterns of gender-based violence and referencing available support resources, while male reporters rely more heavily on perpetrator-centered narratives that foreground motives such as jealousy or fits of rage.

These differences are not merely descriptive but directly affect readers' behavior. An additional article by a woman for each crime and newspaper leads to a 17% increase in calls to the national VAW helpline in the aftermath of a murder. Evidence from the online experiment further suggests that the mechanism operates through narrative: victim-centered narratives increase the perceived prevalence of help-seeking, potentially lowering its perceived cost.

The findings are relevant beyond the Italian context of crime reporting. Similar dynamics are likely to manifest wherever reporter identity intersects with socially salient topics, as illustrated by ongoing debates over race-related reporting in the United States. They also speak to the industry's trajectory. As newsrooms increasingly adopt large language models, the growing salience of who tells the news stands against the broader trend toward AI-driven standardization and depersonalization of the news. My findings suggest that journalists are better interpreters of in-group readers' preferences and more likely to use narratives that also benefit those readers, underscoring what may be lost as news production is standardized.

Finally, this paper highlights a potential trade-off within newsrooms between engagement-maximizing narratives and those that affect readers' behavior in a beneficial way, assuming the effect on calls only reflects increased help-seeking. Since the two engagement margins map onto different revenue models, the implications of this tension for a revenue-maximizing outlet are unclear. This also makes the policy implications of the paper far from straightforward. Increasing the share of female reporters may not be sustainable on its own, as it relies on in-group identity to drive narrative choices rather than addressing the underlying incentive structure. More broadly, it remains unclear whether and how outlets could be nudged toward narratives that benefit readers without distorting reporters' incentives or compromising editorial independence. However, given that the narrative shift I document works through reporters' identity rather than top-down editorial

standards, the more promising levers may lie in who produces the news, such as newsroom composition or pairing reporters through co-authorship, rather than in formal guidelines alone.

These findings point to several open questions. Understanding reporters' incentives and the factors that shape their narrative choices beyond outlet-level directives would have direct implications for the design of news policies. Establishing whether the rise in help-seeking reflects a genuine welfare improvement will require linking coverage to administrative outcomes that capture crime incidence. And while this paper focuses on the victim- versus perpetrator-centered dimension of narratives, other dimensions, such as the framing of immigration status, may shape reader responses in ways worth studying.

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A Additional Results

A.1 Balance Tables on Other Reporters' Characteristics

Table A.1: Balance Table for Reporter's Age

Variable	Mean		Difference in Means			
	Old	Young	Without FE		With FE	
	All (1)	All (2)	All (3)	All (4)	First Art. (5)	Fifth Art. (6)
Victim Italian	0.845 (0.362)	0.84 (0.366)	0.005 (0.007)	0.013 (0.016)	0.015 (0.016)	0.009 (0.037)
Perpetrator Italian	0.799 (0.401)	0.787 (0.41)	0.012 (0.008)	-0.011 (0.022)	-0.004 (0.014)	-0.083*** (0.028)
Perpetrator Partner	0.586 (0.493)	0.548 (0.498)	0.038*** (0.01)	0.015 (0.016)	0.009 (0.02)	-0.041 (0.052)
Perpetrator Relative	0.127 (0.333)	0.134 (0.341)	-0.007 (0.007)	-0.004 (0.011)	-0.007 (0.017)	0.015 (0.03)
Relationship Missing	0.137 (0.344)	0.139 (0.346)	-0.002 (0.007)	0.016 (0.015)	0.02** (0.009)	-0.005 (0.037)
Crime >5 Articles	0.492 (0.5)	0.55 (0.498)	-0.058*** (0.01)	-0.008 (0.015)		
Crime >10 Articles	0.325 (0.468)	0.39 (0.488)	-0.065*** (0.01)	-0.015 (0.015)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.344 (0.475)	0.298 (0.457)	0.046*** (0.009)	0.013 (0.013)		
Second Article - Female Vict.	0.145 (0.352)	0.141 (0.348)	0.005 (0.007)	-0.003 (0.007)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.584 (0.493)	0.621 (0.485)	-0.036*** (0.012)	-0.01 (0.024)		
Second Article - Male Vict.	0.159 (0.365)	0.154 (0.361)	0.004 (0.009)	-0.002 (0.005)		
Victim Female	0.587 (0.492)	0.588 (0.492)	-0.001 (0.008)	0.019 (0.012)		

Notes. Balance test of crime and article characteristics along reporters' age. *First Article* and *Second Article* are indicators for whether the article is respectively the first or the second one about a specific crime in the same newspaper, presented separately for murders with male and female victims. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the whole sample, and Columns 5 and 6 report the results separately for the first and fifth articles, respectively. Columns 1 and 2 report the mean and standard deviation of crime and article characteristics separately for reporters older or younger than the average age. Column 3 reports the simple difference in means between older and younger reporters. Columns 4 to 6 report the difference in means after taking out newspaper-year fixed effects. Standard errors in Columns 4 to 6 are clustered at the newspaper level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.2: Balance Table for Reporter's Experience

Variable	Mean		Difference in Means			
	More Exp.	Less Exp.	Without FE		With FE	
	All (1)	All (2)	All (3)	All (4)	First Art. (5)	Fifth Art. (6)
Victim Italian	0.848 (0.359)	0.837 (0.37)	0.011 (0.007)	0.012 (0.009)	0.012 (0.019)	0.047 (0.044)
Perpetrator Italian	0.787 (0.41)	0.798 (0.401)	-0.012 (0.008)	-0.023 (0.014)	-0.009 (0.014)	-0.094*** (0.033)
Perpetrator Partner	0.579 (0.494)	0.552 (0.497)	0.027*** (0.01)	0.014 (0.017)	0.007 (0.019)	-0.05* (0.028)
Perpetrator Relative	0.121 (0.327)	0.139 (0.346)	-0.018*** (0.007)	-0.008 (0.007)	-0.021 (0.014)	-0.019 (0.037)
Relationship Missing	0.143 (0.35)	0.133 (0.34)	0.01 (0.007)	0.011 (0.017)	0.022 (0.014)	0.015 (0.024)
Crime >5 Articles	0.496 (0.5)	0.549 (0.498)	-0.053*** (0.01)	-0.01 (0.013)		
Crime >10 Articles	0.324 (0.468)	0.393 (0.489)	-0.069*** (0.01)	-0.021* (0.013)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.343 (0.475)	0.297 (0.457)	0.046*** (0.009)	0.016 (0.017)		
Second Article - Female Vict.	0.148 (0.355)	0.138 (0.345)	0.01 (0.007)	0.004 (0.007)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.587 (0.492)	0.619 (0.486)	-0.032*** (0.012)	-0.002 (0.027)		
Second Article - Male Vict.	0.154 (0.361)	0.159 (0.366)	-0.006 (0.009)	-0.014*** (0.004)		
Victim Female	0.589 (0.492)	0.586 (0.493)	0.003 (0.008)	0.017 (0.015)		

Notes. Balance test of crime and article characteristics along reporters' years of experience. *First Article* and *Second Article* are indicators for whether the article is respectively the first or the second one about a specific crime in the same newspaper, presented separately for murders with male and female victims. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the whole sample, and Columns 5 and 6 report the results separately for the first and fifth articles, respectively. Columns 1 and 2 report the mean and standard deviation of crime and article characteristics separately for reporters with more or fewer than the median years of experience. Column 3 reports the simple difference in means between more or less experienced reporters. Columns 4 to 6 report the difference in means after taking out newspaper-year fixed effects. Standard errors in Columns 4 to 6 are clustered at the newspaper level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.3: Balance Table for Reporter's Gender Norms

Variable	Mean		Difference in Means			
	Traditional	Progressive	Without FE		With FE	
	All (1)	All (2)	All (3)	All (4)	First Art. (5)	Fifth Art. (6)
Victim Italian	0.875 (0.331)	0.842 (0.365)	0.033*** (0.008)	0.011 (0.043)	0.057*** (0.007)	0.008 (0.104)
Perpetrator Italian	0.835 (0.371)	0.768 (0.422)	0.067*** (0.009)	0.009 (0.029)	0.057*** (0.011)	0.001 (0.031)
Perpetrator Partner	0.55 (0.498)	0.586 (0.493)	-0.036*** (0.011)	-0.076 (0.053)	-0.043 (0.028)	0.021 (0.092)
Perpetrator Relative	0.112 (0.315)	0.116 (0.321)	-0.004 (0.007)	0.002 (0.014)	0.034 (0.021)	-0.012 (0.026)
Relationship Missing	0.157 (0.364)	0.139 (0.346)	0.018** (0.008)	0.062** (0.028)	0.024** (0.01)	0.038 (0.054)
Crime >5 Articles	0.507 (0.5)	0.55 (0.498)	-0.044*** (0.011)	0.039 (0.06)		
Crime >10 Articles	0.34 (0.474)	0.403 (0.491)	-0.063*** (0.011)	0.027 (0.057)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.351 (0.477)	0.295 (0.456)	0.057*** (0.011)	0.015 (0.035)		
Second Article - Female Vict.	0.146 (0.353)	0.136 (0.343)	0.01 (0.008)	-0.019** (0.009)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.606 (0.489)	0.661 (0.474)	-0.054*** (0.014)	-0.05*** (0.016)		
Second Article - Male Vict.	0.141 (0.348)	0.165 (0.372)	-0.024** (0.01)	-0.018 (0.012)		
Victim Female	0.498 (0.5)	0.673 (0.469)	-0.175*** (0.008)	-0.082*** (0.024)		

Notes. Balance test of crime and article characteristics along reporters' region of residence, gender norms, proxied by the share of couples in which only the husband works. *First Article* and *Second Article* are indicators for whether the article is respectively the first or the second one about a specific crime in the same newspaper, presented separately for murders with male and female victims. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the whole sample, and Columns 5 and 6 report the results separately for the first and fifth articles, respectively. Columns 1 and 2 report the mean and standard deviation of crime and article characteristics separately for reporters living in more or less conservative regions. Column 3 reports the simple difference in means between reporters in more and less conservative regions. Columns 4 to 6 report the difference in means after taking out newspaper-year fixed effects. Standard errors in Columns 4 to 6 are clustered at the newspaper level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

A.2 Additional Results on Gender Differences in Crime Reporting

Table A.4: Gender Differences in Article Headlines

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.065** (0.028)	0.050* (0.026)	0.062** (0.025)	0.029 (0.024)	-0.033 (0.021)	-0.034 (0.022)	-0.034 (0.022)	-0.026 (0.021)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.001	0.077	0.081	0.301	0.000	0.040	0.042	0.266
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices in headlines between female and male reporters. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the victim-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices complying with the guidelines on reporting about VAW; Columns 5 to 8 report the results for the perpetrator-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices that do not comply with such guidelines. Columns 1 and 5 report the OLS regression; Columns 2 and 6 include newspaper times year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 7 add reporter's region fixed effects; Columns 4 and 8 also include crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.5: Gender Differences in Reporting: At Least One Topic

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.054*** (0.014)	0.036*** (0.012)	0.043*** (0.012)	0.034*** (0.010)	-0.030** (0.013)	-0.029** (0.013)	-0.023* (0.013)	-0.025** (0.012)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.004	0.091	0.103	0.401	0.001	0.060	0.066	0.317
Mean Index	0.277	0.277	0.277	0.277	0.373	0.373	0.373	0.373
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

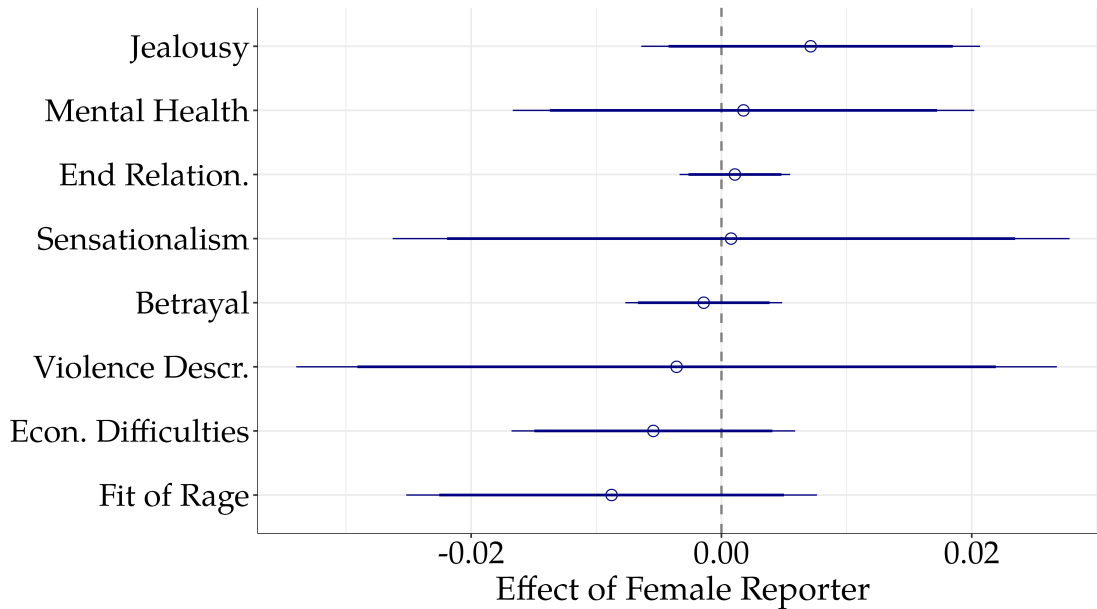
Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between female and male reporters. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for at least one topic in the victim-centered index; Columns 5 to 8 report the results for at least one topic for the perpetrator-centered index. Columns 1 and 5 report the OLS regression; Columns 2 and 6 include newspaper times year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 7 add reporter's region fixed effects; Columns 4 and 8 also include crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.6: Journalist, Outlet, and Case Components of Narrative Variation

Share of Var(y)	VC (1)	PC (2)	VC (≥ 5 arts.) (3)	PC (≥ 5 arts.) (4)
Journalist var(α)	0.367	0.441	0.276	0.327
Outlet var(ψ)	0.185	0.295	0.218	0.233
Case var(κ)	0.479	0.432	0.480	0.429
Sorting 2cov(α, ψ)	-0.190	-0.424	-0.181	-0.296

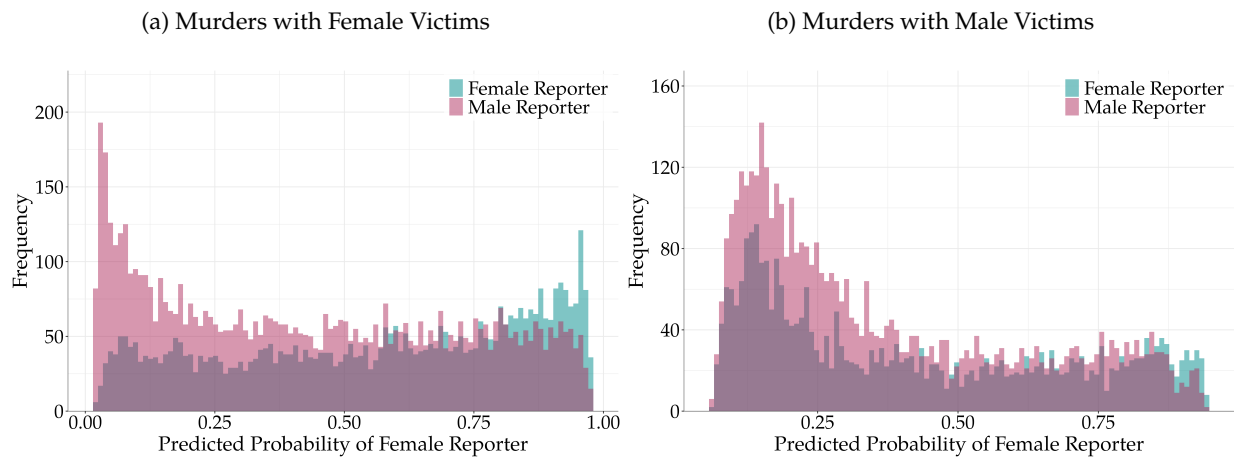
Notes. Decomposition of the variance of the victim-centered and perpetrator-centered indexes into journalist, outlet, and case components. The components are estimated with a two-way fixed-effects model including journalist, newspaper-year, and crime fixed effects, on the largest connected set of reporters. Each cell reports the share of the total variance of the index attributable to the journalist (α), outlet (ψ , newspaper $\times$ year), and crime (κ) components, and to the journalist-outlet sorting covariance. Columns 1 and 2 use the full sample; Columns 3 and 4 restrict to reporters with at least five articles.

Figure A.1: Gender Differences in Reporting on Murders with Male Victims



Notes. Gender differences in reporting about murders of male victims. All regressions include newspaper-year, crime, and reporter's region fixed effects. The reporting practices used are the same that compose the perpetrator-centered index from the analysis of murders with male victims, with two additions. First, an index for sensationalistic language; second, an index capturing description of the violence that occurred in the murder. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level, and the figure shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals.

Figure A.2: Predicted Probability of Female Reporter by Real Reporter's Gender



Notes. Distribution of the predicted probabilities of each article being written by a female reporter plotted separately by *real* reporters' gender. The predicted probabilities are computed with a fine-tuned BERT classifier trained on an Italian corpus. Panel (a) shows the predicted probabilities for articles on murders with female victims, while Panel (b) shows those for articles on murders with male victims.

A.3 Additional Differences in Reporting across Reporters' Characteristics

Table A.7: Differences in Reporting across Reporters' Age

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Age<50	-0.021 (0.033)	-0.062** (0.030)	-0.048 (0.032)	-0.026 (0.028)	-0.037 (0.030)	-0.016 (0.026)	-0.025 (0.027)	-0.045* (0.026)
Female Reporter				0.125*** (0.025)				-0.047** (0.023)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.000	0.118	0.129	0.432	0.000	0.058	0.064	0.356
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between reporters younger and older than the average reporters' age. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the victim-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices complying with the guidelines on reporting about VAW; Columns 5 to 8 report the results for the perpetrator-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices that do not comply with such guidelines. Columns 1 and 5 report the simple OLS regression; Columns 2 and 6 include newspaper times year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 7 add reporter's region fixed effects; Columns 4 and 8 also include crime fixed effects and controls for author's gender. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.8: Differences in Reporting across Reporters' Region Norms

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Reg. Norms	1.299 (0.873)	0.693 (0.943)	-3.030*** (0.923)	-2.781*** (0.932)	1.818** (0.827)	2.049** (0.979)	0.677 (1.037)	0.469 (1.048)
Female Reporter				0.112*** (0.029)				-0.068*** (0.026)
Age				0.003** (0.001)				0.005*** (0.001)
Observations	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731
R ²	0.005	0.111	0.419	0.421	0.006	0.067	0.376	0.379
Shr. Female Reporters	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Crime FE			X	X			X	X

Notes. Effect of reporters' gender norms, proxied by norms in their region of residence. Columns 1 to 4 report the results for the victim-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices complying with the guidelines on reporting about VAW; Columns 5 to 8 report the results for the perpetrator-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices that do not comply with such guidelines. Columns 1 and 5 report the OLS regression; Columns 2 and 6 include newspaper times year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 7 add crime fixed effects and Columns 4 and 8 include controls for reporters' characteristics like gender and date of birth. All columns control for the reporter residing in the North. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.9: Differences in Reporting across Newspaper Ideology

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Liberal	0.034 (0.059)	0.072** (0.034)	0.116*** (0.038)	0.011 (0.051)	-0.046 (0.029)	-0.046 (0.030)
Female Reporter			0.128*** (0.032)			-0.050** (0.025)
Age			-0.001 (0.001)			-0.003* (0.001)
Observations	8934	8934	8934	8934	8934	8934
R ²	0.000	0.420	0.429	0.000	0.344	0.348
Shr. Female Reporters	0.409	0.409	0.409	0.409	0.409	0.409
Crime FE		X	X		X	X
Year FE		X	X		X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X			X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between progressive and conservative newspapers. Columns 1 to 3 report the results for the victim-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices complying with the guidelines on reporting about VAW; Columns 4 to 6 report the results for the perpetrator-centered index, standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1, capturing the use of practices that do not comply with such guidelines. Columns 1 and 4 report the OLS regression; Columns 2 and 5 include crime and year fixed effects, while Columns 3 and 6 add reporters' characteristics among the controls. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.10: Gender Differences Controlling for the Reporter's VAW Specialization

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered			Perpetrator-Centered		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.121*** (0.025)	0.120*** (0.025)	0.120*** (0.025)	-0.052** (0.023)	-0.052** (0.023)	-0.051** (0.023)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.432	0.432	0.432	0.356	0.356	0.356
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
VAW Spec. Control	-	Total	Prior	-	Total	Prior

Notes. Differences in the use of victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 4 to 6) narratives between female and male reporters, controlling for the reporter's prior coverage of violence against women. Columns 1 and 4 include no experience control; Columns 2 and 5 control for the reporter's total number of femicide articles in the sample; Columns 3 and 6 control for the number written before the current article. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.11: Gender Differences by Reporter's VAW Specialization

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered			Perpetrator-Centered		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.129** (0.052)	0.090*** (0.030)	0.100*** (0.034)	0.011 (0.041)	-0.064** (0.028)	-0.055* (0.030)
Observations	2677	7910	6210	2677	7910	6210
R ²	0.594	0.472	0.509	0.558	0.397	0.439
Shr. Female Reporters	0.435	0.416	0.405	0.435	0.416	0.405
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
VAW Arts.	<5	≥ 5	≥ 10	<5	≥ 5	≥ 10

Notes. Differences in the use of victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 4 to 6) narratives between female and male reporters, estimated separately by the reporter's degree of specialization in VAW coverage. Columns 1 and 4 report the results for non-specialists with fewer than five femicide articles, and the remaining columns for specialists with at least five (Columns 2 and 5) or at least ten (Columns 3 and 6). All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.12: Narratives and the Gender of the Crime-Desk Editor

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Desk Editor	-0.051 (0.149)	0.121 (0.160)	0.142 (0.199)	-0.195* (0.106)	0.049 (0.143)	-0.031 (0.167)
Observations	9911	9911	9911	9911	9911	9911
R ²	0.000	0.088	0.380	0.002	0.042	0.314
Shr. Female Editor	0.043	0.043	0.043	0.043	0.043	0.043
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X		X	X
Crime FE			X			X

Notes. Effect of a female crime-desk editor on the victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 4 to 6) indexes, based on a hand-collected panel of the heads of local crime desks over 2006–2022 (101 editors). Columns 1 and 4 include no fixed effects; Columns 2 and 5 add newspaper-year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 6 add crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.13: Gender Differences under Low Editorial Oversight

Sample	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index		Perpetrator-Centered Index	
	Weekday (1)	Weekend (2)	Weekday (3)	Weekend (4)
Female Reporter	0.104*** (0.028)	0.210*** (0.050)	-0.032 (0.026)	-0.082** (0.040)
Observations	8072	2515	8072	2515
R ²	0.453	0.574	0.391	0.530
Shr. Female Reporters	0.425	0.406	0.425	0.406
Crime FE	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X

Notes. Gender differences in the victim-centered (Columns 1 and 2) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 3 and 4) indexes, estimated separately on weekday and weekend editions. Weekend editions (Sunday–Monday) are produced with reduced staff and lighter editorial screening. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter’s region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.14: Gender Differences in Cited Sources

	Police (1)	Judiciary (2)	Family (3)	Neighbors (4)	Lawyer (5)
Female Reporter	-0.017 (0.011)	-0.008 (0.007)	0.013 (0.010)	-0.002 (0.009)	0.029*** (0.008)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.225	0.179	0.222	0.209	0.181
Mean Dep. Var.	0.216	0.102	0.193	0.141	0.100
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Differences between female and male reporters in the probability of attributing information to each type of source: police, judiciary, the victim’s family, neighbors, and lawyers. *Mean Dep. Var.* is the share of articles citing each source. Anti-violence centers are excluded because their mention is itself a component of the victim-centered index. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter’s region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.15: Gender Differences Controlling for Cited Sources

	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index		Perpetrator-Centered Index	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Female Reporter	0.121*** (0.025)	0.124*** (0.025)	-0.052** (0.023)	-0.054** (0.022)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.432	0.433	0.356	0.366
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Source Controls		X		X
Crime FE	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X

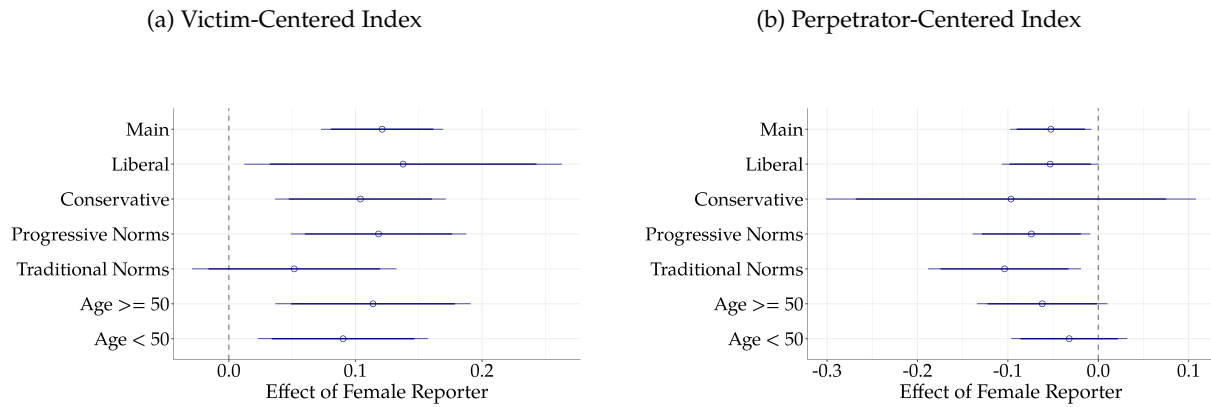
Notes. Differences in the use of victim-centered (Columns 1 and 2) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 3 and 4) narratives between female and male reporters, with and without controls for the sources cited in the article. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.16: Gender Differences in Reporting Quality

	Reporting Quality Metric					
	Gulpease	Lexical Div.	Words/Sent.	Length	No. Sources	Source Div.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.200 (0.169)	0.103 (0.769)	-0.154 (0.163)	7.095 (5.478)	0.015 (0.025)	0.014 (0.029)
Observations	10288	10256	10288	10288	10587	10587
R ²	0.157	0.159	0.161	0.229	0.221	0.221
Mean Dep. Var.	53.600	164.948	20.883	453.030	0.752	0.838
Shr. Female Reporters	0.422	0.422	0.422	0.422	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Differences between female and male reporters in general measures of reporting quality: the Gulpease readability index (Column 1), lexical diversity measured by the MTLD index (Column 2), the average number of words per sentence (Column 3), the length of the article in words (Column 4), the number of human source types cited (Column 5), and the source diversity index (Column 6), which adds the documentary sources the article attributes information to. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure A.3: Gender Differences in Reporting by Sub-Groups



Notes. Effect of female reporter on the victim-centered (Panel A) and perpetrator-centered indexes (Panel B), standardized to have mean 0 and standard deviation of 1. All regressions include crime and reporter's region fixed effects. Regressions run on the samples of progressive and conservative newspapers also include year fixed effects, while the remaining ones include newspaper times year fixed effects. The top coefficient shows the effect of the main specification. The estimates labeled as "Progressive" and "Conservative" come from regressions on the group of conservative and Progressive newspapers. Those labeled "Low Region Norms" and "High Region Norms" are from regressions on the sample of reporters living in regions with gender norms below and above the median level, while the final ones are from regressions run on the sample of reporters older or younger than 50 years old. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level, and the figure shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals.

A.4 Robustness Checks on Gender Differences in Crime Reporting

Table A.17: Gender Differences in Reporting: Alternative Specification—VC Index

	Victim-Centered Index				Weighted
	Art. Order× Crime FE	Crime× Newsp FE	Crime× Year Clust.	Crime× Auth. Clust.	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Female Reporter	0.117*** (0.028)	0.117*** (0.029)	0.121*** (0.024)	0.121*** (0.024)	0.132*** (0.034)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.367	0.593	0.432	0.432	0.580
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE			X	X	X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between female and male reporters in the victim-centered index. Column 1 includes fixed effects for whether the article is the first, second, etc. on the same crime in newspaper n ; Column 2 includes crime times newspaper fixed effects; Column 3 has standard errors clustered at the crime times year level and column 4 at the crime times author level; Column 5 adds weights for the inverse number of articles for each newspaper-crime. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level in all columns except for Columns 3 and 4 (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.18: Gender Differences in Reporting: Alternative Specification—PC Index

	Perpetrator-Centered Index				Weighted
	Art. Order× Crime FE	Crime× Newsp FE	Crime× Year Clust.	Crime× Auth. Clust.	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Female Reporter	−0.041 (0.025)	−0.065** (0.029)	−0.052** (0.022)	−0.052** (0.023)	−0.029 (0.030)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.318	0.525	0.356	0.356	0.509
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE			X	X	X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between female and male reporters in the perpetrator-centered index. Column 1 includes fixed effects for whether the article is the first, second, etc. on the same crime in newspaper n ; Column 2 includes crime times newspaper fixed effects; Column 3 has standard errors clustered at the crime times year level and column 4 at the crime times author level; Column 5 adds weights for the inverse number of articles for each newspaper-crime. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level in all columns except for Columns 3 and 4 (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.19: Gender Differences in Reporting: Month and Week Fixed Effects

	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index		Perpetrator-Centered Index	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Female Reporter	0.103*** (0.026)	0.094** (0.044)	−0.069** (0.026)	−0.029 (0.042)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.558	0.676	0.475	0.617
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Time FE	Month	Week	Month	Week

Notes. Differences between female and male reporters in the victim-centered (Columns 1 and 2) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 3 and 4) indexes. Columns 1 and 3 replace the newspaper-year fixed effects with newspaper-by-month, and Columns 2 and 4 with newspaper-by-week fixed effects. All columns include crime and reporter's region fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.20: Gender Differences in Reporting: Alternative Samples—VC Index

	Victim-Centered Index					
	First Art.	First 5 Art.	IPV	Italian Perp.	No Viral Events	All Crimes Rep.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.140*** (0.047)	0.111*** (0.031)	0.148*** (0.039)	0.121*** (0.029)	0.126*** (0.030)	0.060* (0.033)
Observations	3391	7004	6006	8045	6577	6804
R ²	0.647	0.490	0.452	0.466	0.504	0.485
Shr. Female Reporters	0.415	0.426	0.415	0.414	0.433	0.394
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between female and male reporters in the victim-centered index. Column 1 restricts the sample to the first article for each crime in each newspaper; Column 2 restricts the sample to the first five articles about a crime in each newspaper; Column 3 to murders committed by the (ex-)partner; Column 4 to Italian perpetrators; Column 5 excludes events that are covered by 10 or more articles per newspaper; Column 6 excludes reporters who only cover femicides, i.e. restricts the sample to reporters who also write about other crimes. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.21: Gender Differences in Reporting: Alternative Samples—PC Index

	Perpetrator-Centered Index					
	First Art.	First 5 Art.	IPV	Italian Perp.	No Viral Events	All Crimes Rep.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	-0.056 (0.038)	-0.055* (0.031)	-0.071** (0.029)	-0.068** (0.027)	-0.051 (0.032)	-0.090*** (0.031)
Observations	3391	7004	6006	8045	6577	6804
R ²	0.611	0.416	0.346	0.351	0.415	0.422
Shr. Female Reporters	0.415	0.426	0.415	0.414	0.433	0.394
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Differences in the use of reporting practices between female and male reporters in the perpetrator-centered index. Column 1 restricts the sample to the first article for each crime in each newspaper; Column 2 restricts the sample to the first five articles about a crime in each newspaper; Column 3 to murders committed by the (ex-)partner; Column 4 to Italian perpetrators; Column 5 excludes events that are covered by 10 or more articles per newspaper; Column 6 excludes reporters who only cover femicides, i.e. restricts the sample to reporters who also write about other crimes. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.22: Gender Differences in Reporting: Varying Newsroom's Reporter Pool

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	Above-Median Coverage	≥5 Reporters	≥10 Reporters	≥2 Female & ≥2 Male	Above-Median Coverage	≥5 Reporters	≥10 Reporters	≥2 Female & ≥2 Male
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.118*** (0.025)	0.114*** (0.025)	0.113*** (0.026)	0.118*** (0.025)	-0.057** (0.024)	-0.052** (0.023)	-0.054** (0.024)	-0.053** (0.023)
Observations	9974	10315	9941	10221	9974	10315	9941	10221
R ²	0.435	0.422	0.426	0.422	0.360	0.353	0.356	0.354
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.418	0.424	0.420	0.420	0.418	0.424
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Differences between female and male reporters in the victim-centered (Columns 1 to 4) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 5 to 8) indexes. Each column restricts the sample to newsrooms with a sufficiently large pool of reporters covering these crimes, so that reporters of both genders are available when an event occurs. Columns 1 and 5 keep newspapers publishing more than the median number of articles per year; Columns 2 and 6 keep newspaper-years with at least five reporters writing about these crimes; Columns 3 and 7 with at least ten; Columns 4 and 8 with at least two female and two male reporters. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

Table A.23: Determinants of Byline Presence

	Article is Signed (Bylined)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Article Length (100 words)	0.040*** (0.008)	0.040*** (0.008)	0.039*** (0.008)	0.041*** (0.008)
Perp. is Partner		-0.004 (0.012)	-0.007 (0.014)	0.004 (0.013)
Perp. is Relative		0.003 (0.014)	-0.002 (0.015)	0.004 (0.015)
Victim Italian			-0.009 (0.015)	-0.013 (0.013)
Perp. Italian			0.007 (0.015)	0.017 (0.014)
Observations	27155	27155	26070	26070
R ²	0.253	0.253	0.252	0.263
Shr. Signed Articles	0.396	0.396	0.396	0.396
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X
Crime Region FE				X

Notes. Correlation between byline presence and article and crime characteristics. *Article Length* is measured in hundreds of words. All columns include newspaper-year fixed effects, and Column 4 adds crime-region fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

Table A.24: Gender Differences in Reporting: No Byline

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.182*** (0.035)	0.153*** (0.032)	0.139*** (0.025)	-0.065** (0.030)	-0.061** (0.029)	-0.055** (0.023)
No Author	-0.087*** (0.027)	-0.096*** (0.026)	-0.099*** (0.020)	-0.304*** (0.029)	-0.302*** (0.028)	-0.310*** (0.025)
Observations	25502	25502	25502	25502	25502	25502
R ²	0.010	0.087	0.322	0.019	0.058	0.257
Shr. Female Reporters	0.175	0.175	0.175	0.175	0.175	0.175
Newsp $\times$ Year FE		X	X		X	X
Crime FE			X			X

Notes. Differences in the victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 4 to 6) indexes when the articles without an identified author are added to the estimation sample. *Female Reporter* and *No Author* are indicators for female-authored and unsigned articles, respectively, relative to articles authored by men. Columns 1 and 4 include no fixed effects; Columns 2 and 5 add newspaper-year fixed effects; Columns 3 and 6 add crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.25: Gender Differences in Reporting Controlling for Article Length

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.121*** (0.025)	0.125*** (0.024)	0.126*** (0.024)	-0.052** (0.023)	-0.047** (0.023)	-0.046** (0.023)
Article Length		0.001*** (0.000)			0.001*** (0.000)	
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R ²	0.432	0.449	0.449	0.356	0.390	0.391
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp $\times$ Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Length-Decile FE			X			X

Notes. Differences in the victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered (Columns 4 to 6) indexes, controlling for article length. Columns 1 and 4 reproduce the main specification; Columns 2 and 5 add a control for article length; Columns 3 and 6 include length-decile fixed effects. All columns include newspaper-year, reporter's region, and crime fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the newspaper-year level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

A.5 Additional Results on Exposure to Crime Narratives and Help-Seeking

Table A.26: Balance Test on Female-Reporter Exposure Measure

Variable	Average		Difference in Means	
	High Exposure (1)	Low Exposure (2)	Without FE (3)	With Year FE (4)
Perp. is Partner	0.615 (0.487)	0.646 (0.479)	-0.032 (0.028)	-0.030 (0.029)
Perp. is Relative	0.185 (0.389)	0.181 (0.385)	0.005 (0.021)	0.008 (0.022)
Victim Italian	0.800 (0.400)	0.783 (0.413)	0.017 (0.024)	0.029 (0.026)
Perp. Italian	0.851 (0.356)	0.840 (0.367)	0.011 (0.022)	0.009 (0.023)
Homicides (prov-week)	0.102 (0.560)	0.082 (0.310)	0.019 (0.018)	0.010 (0.017)

Notes. Balance test of crime characteristics across events with high and low exposure to female reporters, split at the median of the treatment distribution. Columns 1 and 2 report the group means. Columns 3 and 4 report the difference in means without and with year fixed effects. *Homicides (prov-week)* is the local homicide count. Standard errors in parentheses: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.27: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Helpline Calls—OLS

	Number of Calls						
	Linear OLS				Log.	S.D.	Poisson
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Female Rep. Exposure	0.317* (0.173)	0.305* (0.168)	0.121** (0.055)	0.119** (0.055)	0.006 (0.010)	0.035** (0.016)	0.058** (0.025)
Murder (Prov-Week)		3.178*** (1.185)	0.258** (0.103)		0.024 (0.018)	0.075** (0.030)	0.051** (0.020)
Murder (Reg-Week)				0.074** (0.032)			
Observations	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443
R ²	0.000	0.016	0.690	0.690	0.538	0.690	
Mean Dep. Var.	1.724	1.724	1.724	1.724	1.724	1.724	1.724
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE			X	X	X	X	X
Month FE			X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on calls. Columns 1 to 4 report the OLS estimate using the number of calls as outcomes. Column 1 reports the simple OLS estimate; Column 2 controls for a murder happening in the same week; Column 3 and 5 to 7 add province and month fixed effects; Column 4 controls for a murder happening in the same region and week. Column 5 uses the logarithm of calls as an outcome, Column 6 uses the normalized number of calls, and Column 7 uses a Poisson regression. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.28: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Narratives

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Narratives			Perpetrator-Centered Narratives		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Rep. Exposure	0.091*** (0.018)	0.066*** (0.017)	0.066*** (0.017)	0.010 (0.015)	-0.038** (0.015)	-0.038** (0.015)
Region Gender Norms			-0.273 (0.307)			0.302 (0.344)
Observations	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443
R ²	0.000	0.057	0.057	0.000	0.013	0.013
Mean Dep. Var.	0.140	0.140	0.140	0.095	0.095	0.095
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE		X	X		X	X
Month FE		X	X		X	X

Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on victim-centered (Columns 1 to 3) and perpetrator-centered narratives (Columns 4 to 6). Columns 2-3 and 5-6 include province and month fixed effects. Columns 3 and 6 control for the proxy for gender norms. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.29: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Helpline Calls—Different Narratives

	Number of Calls (Poisson)					
	Articles with No VC Narratives			Articles with VC Narratives		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art} × Post	0.080 (0.259)	0.194 (0.303)	0.194 (0.300)	0.512* (0.282)	0.462* (0.251)	0.463* (0.251)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art}	−0.307 (0.226)	−0.315 (0.205)	−0.314 (0.204)	0.568* (0.312)	−0.074 (0.263)	−0.074 (0.261)
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980
R ²	0.536	0.564	0.564	0.538	0.564	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.143	0.143	0.143	0.065	0.065	0.065
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE		X	X		X	X
Gender Norms Control			X			X

Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on calls estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. Columns 1 to 3 capture the effect of exposure to female reporters who do not use victim-centered narratives, while Columns 4 to 6 the effect of exposure to female reporters who use victim-centered narratives. All columns include province and weeks-from-murder fixed effects, while Columns 2 and 5 also add month fixed effects, and Columns 3 and 6 control for the proxy for gender norms. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

Table A.30: Effect of Victim-Centered Components on Helpline Calls

	Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Pre-Violence ^{5Art}	-0.216** (0.106)			-0.276*** (0.093)
Pre-Violence ^{5Art} × Post	0.288** (0.115)			0.275** (0.111)
Femicide Label ^{5Art}		0.217*** (0.069)		0.246*** (0.076)
Femicide Label ^{5Art} × Post		-0.052 (0.143)		-0.129 (0.127)
Help Info ^{5Art}			0.164 (0.137)	0.083 (0.158)
Help Info ^{5Art} × Post			0.254 (0.221)	0.255 (0.189)
Observations	6939	6939	6939	6939
R ²	0.563	0.563	0.563	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.186	0.188	0.038	–
Province FE	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of exposure to each component of the victim-centered index on the number of calls (Poisson), in an eight-week window around the murder. The components are naming the past violence underlying the crime, labeling the crime a femicide, and providing information on support resources; each is interacted with the post-murder indicator as in Equation 5. Columns 1 to 3 enter each component separately; Column 4 includes all three jointly. All columns include province, window-from-murder, and month fixed effects, and control for the proxy for gender norms. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.31: Placebo: Male-Victim Murders Preceding a Femicide

	At Least 1 Call			Number of Calls (Poisson)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art} × Post	−0.204 (0.182)	0.057 (0.126)	0.167 (0.107)	0.638 (0.544)	−0.116 (0.336)	0.107 (0.288)
Observations	239	459	702	239	457	700
R ²	0.494	0.381	0.377	0.580	0.553	0.572
Mean Dep. Var.	0.866	0.871	0.859	9.498	8.947	8.076
Mean Treatment	0.262	0.288	0.285	0.262	0.289	0.285
Male murder before femicide	≤1 wk	≤2 wks	≤3 wks	≤1 wk	≤2 wks	≤3 wks
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

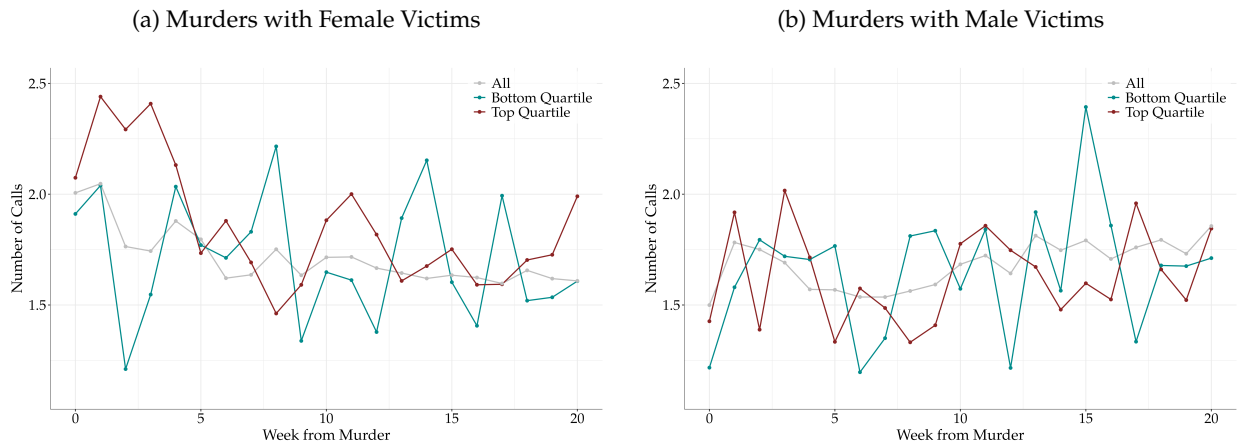
Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on calls estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. Events considered are murders with male victims occurring in the weeks before a murder with a female victim. Columns 1 to 3 report the results for the probability of having at least one call. Columns 4 to 6 report the results from a Poisson regression using the number of calls. Columns vary the maximum time between the male murder and the following femicide, from one to three weeks. All columns include province, window-from-murder, and month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

Table A.32: Triple-Difference: Femicide-Specific Effect on Helpline Calls

	Number of Calls (Poisson)				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Fem. Exposure × Post	0.057 (0.080)	−0.077 (0.100)	−0.022 (0.096)	−0.050 (0.112)	−0.039 (0.118)
Fem. Exposure × Post × Female Victim	0.239 (0.186)	0.372 (0.237)	0.321* (0.181)	0.351** (0.170)	0.337* (0.195)
Observations	14911	13766	13377	13062	12809
R ²	0.574	0.548	0.541	0.533	0.531
Mean Dep. Var.	3.601	3.226	3.125	3.025	2.991
Mean Treatment	0.246	0.244	0.242	0.241	0.241
Male-victim murders dropped	None	±2 wks	±3 wks	±4 wks	±5 wks
Male-victim events	1401	1161	1080	1010	959
Province, Month FE	X	X	X	X	X
Rel. time × Victim gender FE	X	X	X	X	X

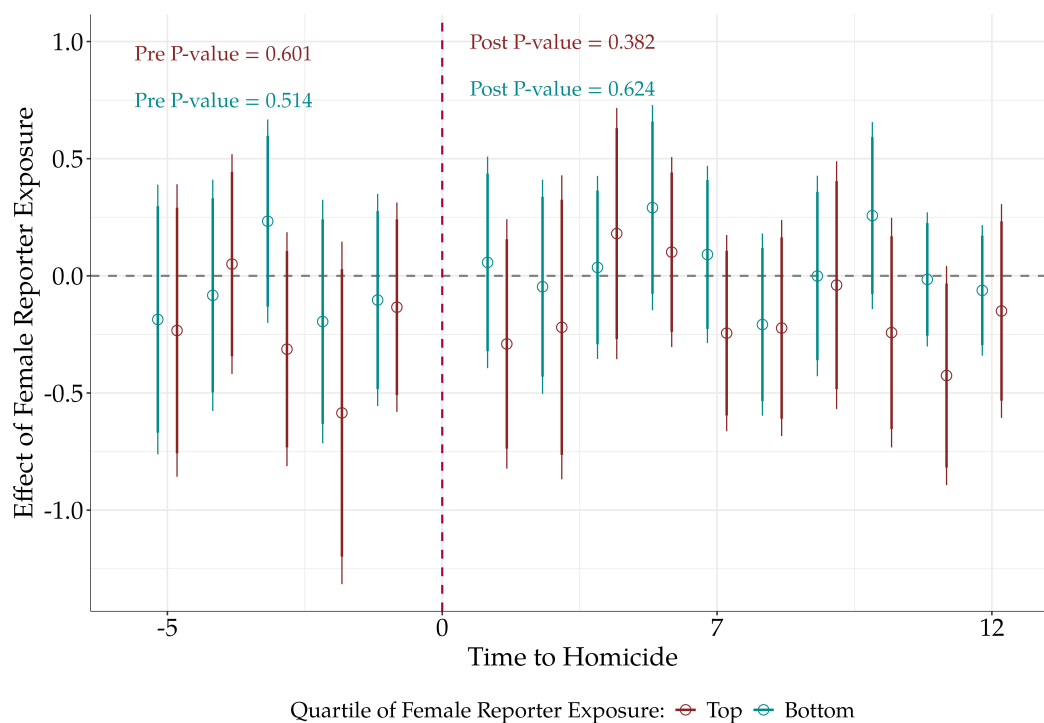
Notes. Triple-difference estimates of the effect of female-reporter exposure on the number of calls (Poisson), pooling murders with female and male victims. Columns progressively drop male-victim murders occurring within ±2 to ±5 weeks of a femicide to avoid contamination from overlapping windows. All columns include province, month, and relative-time × victim-gender fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

Figure A.4: Calls to Helpline in the Weeks after Murder by Exposure to Female Reporters



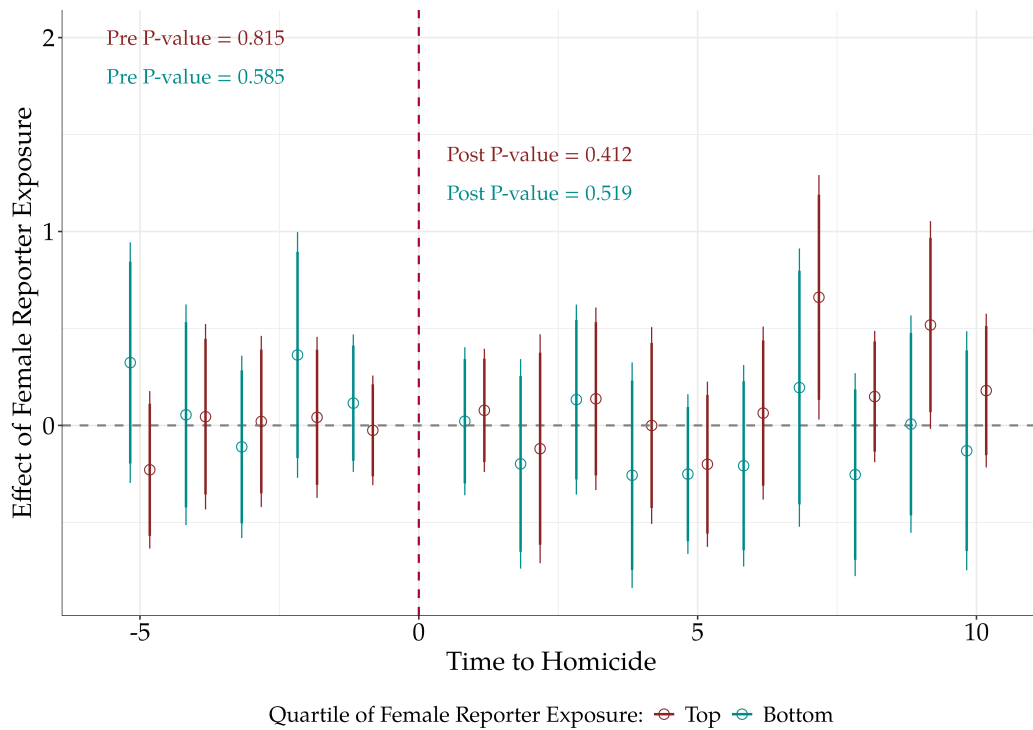
Notes. Time series of the number of calls, after taking out province fixed effects, in the province of the murder in the 20 weeks after the murder happens. The time series are plotted considering all province-week observations and separately for observations with the female reporters' exposure measure in the bottom and top quartile of its distribution. Panel (a) shows the trend of calls to the helpline in provinces where a murder with female victims occurs and after such murder, while Panel (b) plots the same for murders with male victims.

Figure A.5: Event Study: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Number of Articles



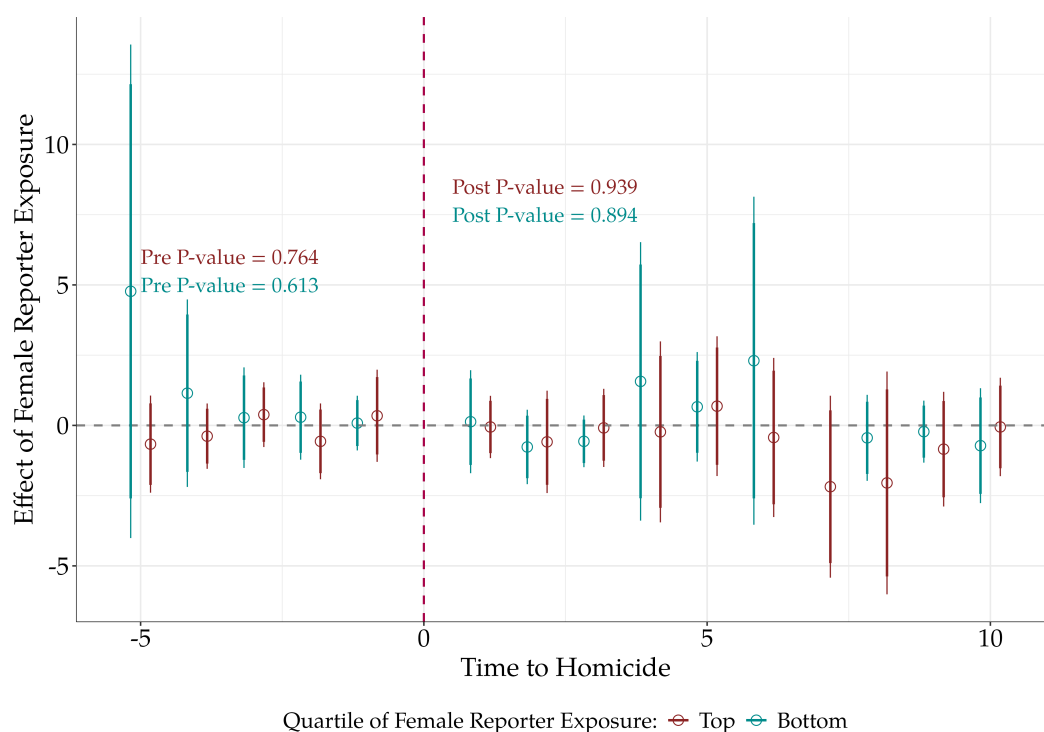
Notes. Number of articles before and after a murder happens in the same province for increasing exposure to female reporters in the first five articles covering the crime. The figure plots the coefficient from regression (6) using as an outcome the number of articles weighted by the newspapers market share. The regression includes province and week effects. It shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals constructed by clustering errors at the province level. Overlaid text reports the p-value from an F-test for the joint significance of the pre- (top left) and post-murder (top right) indicators.

Figure A.6: Event Study: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls—Male Victims



Notes. Calls to the helpline number before and after a murder happens in the same province for increasing exposure to female reporters in the first five articles on crimes. The figure plots the coefficient from regression (6) separately for murders with male victims. The regression includes province and week fixed effects. It shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals constructed from clustering errors at the province level. Overlaid text reports the p-value from an F-test for the joint significance of the pre- (top left) and post-murder (top right) indicators.

Figure A.7: Event Study: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls—Neighboring Provinces



Notes. Calls to the helpline number before and after a murder with a female victim occurs in a neighboring province for increasing exposure to female reporters in the first five articles covering crimes. The figure plots the coefficient from regression (6) where each province is treated if a murder occurs in a neighboring province. The regression includes province and week fixed effects. It shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals constructed by clustering errors at the province level. Overlaid text reports the p-value from an F-test for the joint significance of the pre- (top left) and post-murder (top right) indicators.

A.6 Robustness Checks on Exposure to Crime Narratives and Help-Seeking

Table A.33: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls: Alternative Treatments

Articles	Poisson Model					Zero-Infl. Poisson
	Main (1)	1 Art. (2)	2 Art. (3)	3 Art. (4)	4 Art. (5)	5 Art. (6)
Fem. Exposure ^{XArt} × Post	0.302* (0.181)	0.019 (0.156)	0.125 (0.169)	0.213 (0.197)	0.261 (0.194)	0.299*** (0.084)
Fem. Exposure ^{XArt}	-0.270 (0.167)	-0.111 (0.147)	-0.132 (0.150)	-0.217 (0.173)	-0.280* (0.166)	-0.270*** (0.072)
Observations	6980	6969	6980	6980	6980	6980
R ²	0.564	0.562	0.563	0.564	0.564	0.503
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.166	0.188	0.198	0.204	0.208
Gender Norms Control	X	X	X	X	X	X
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on calls estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. Column 1 reports the results from the main specification. Columns 2 to 5 show results using different treatments. In particular, the treatment in those columns is computed using the first 1, 2, 3, and 4 articles, respectively. Column 6 reports the results from a zero-inflated Poisson model. All specifications include province, week-from-murder, and month fixed effects, and control for the proxy for gender norms. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01.

Table A.34: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls (Extensive Margin): Alternative Treatments

	At Least One Call				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Fem. Exposure ^{XArt} × Post	0.116* (0.067)	0.068 (0.053)	0.079 (0.055)	0.106* (0.061)	0.103* (0.062)
Fem. Exposure ^{XArt}	-0.083 (0.057)	-0.027 (0.043)	-0.048 (0.043)	-0.064 (0.048)	-0.085* (0.049)
Observations	6980	6969	6980	6980	6980
R ²	0.282	0.282	0.282	0.282	0.282
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.166	0.188	0.198	0.204
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on the probability of at least one call estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. Column 1 reports the results from the main specification. Columns 2 to 5 show results using different treatments. In particular, the treatment in those columns is computed using the first 1, 2, 3, and 4 articles, respectively. All specifications include province, week-from-murder, and month fixed effects, and control for the proxy for gender norms. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

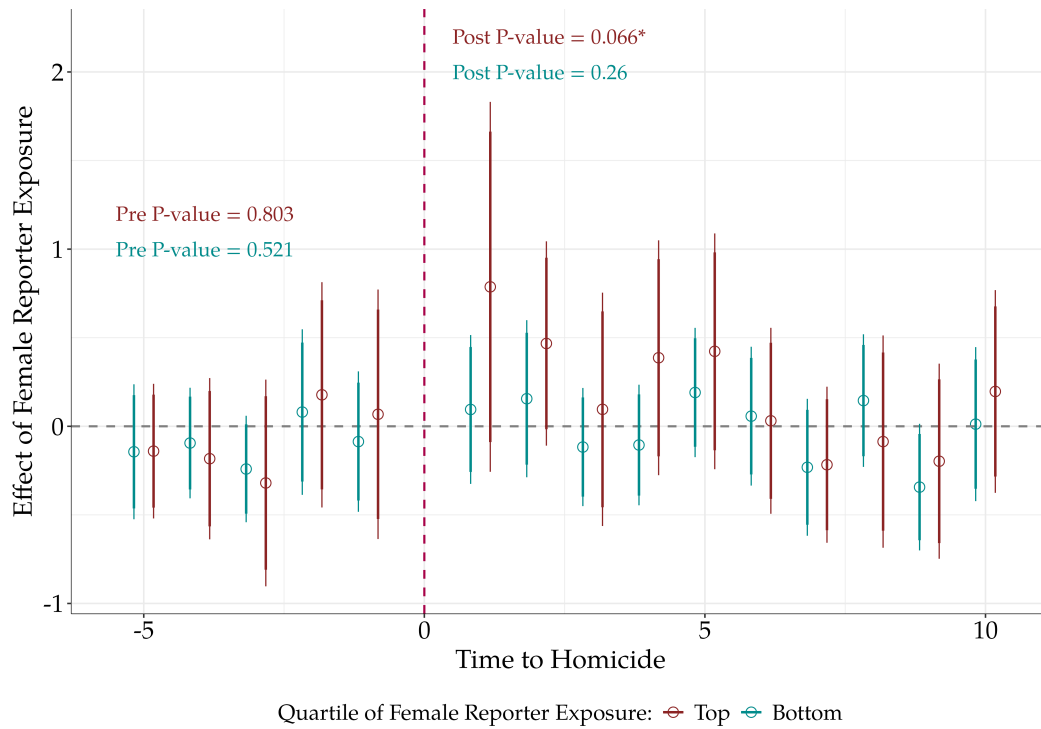
Table A.35: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls: Alternative Specifications

	At Least 1 Call				Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art} × Post	0.120* (0.067)	0.116* (0.067)	0.115* (0.067)	0.114* (0.067)	0.291 (0.207)	0.308* (0.185)	0.305* (0.181)	0.299 (0.185)
Fem. Exposure ^{5Art}	-0.083 (0.055)	-0.084 (0.056)	-0.083 (0.056)	-0.088 (0.057)	-0.288 (0.191)	-0.269* (0.163)	-0.272 (0.167)	-0.270 (0.177)
Murders in Province-Year		-0.000 (0.003)				0.005 (0.008)		
Crime Female Rep.			-0.007 (0.006)				-0.011 (0.012)	
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6924	6980	6980	6980	6924
R ²	0.284	0.282	0.283	0.279	0.568	0.564	0.564	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Gender Norms×Year FE	X				X			
Gender Norms Control		X	X	X		X	X	X
Other Crime Rates				X				X

Notes. Effect of exposure to female reporters on calls estimated in a difference-in-differences design in an eight-week window around the murder. Columns 1 to 4 report the linear probability estimate of there being at least one call (extensive margin). Columns 5 to 8 report results using the number of calls as outcomes and a Poisson model. All columns include province, month, and window-from-murder fixed effects. Columns 1 and 5 also include gender norms times year fixed effects; columns 2 and 6 control for the total number of murders in each province-year, and columns 3 and 7 control for the number of female reporters writing on murders with male victims that individuals are exposed to in each province-year. Finally, columns 4 and 8 control for other crime rates. The R^2 in Columns 5 to 8 corresponds to the pseudo R^2 calculated for the Poisson regression. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses):

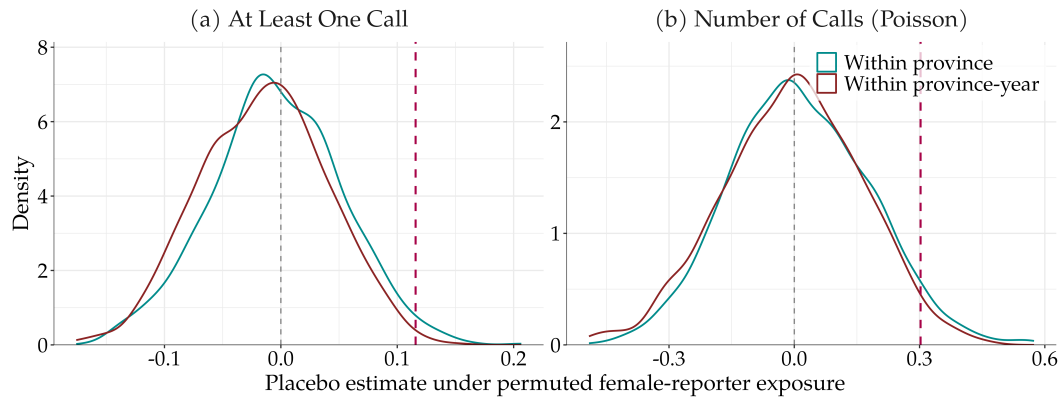
* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure A.8: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls—No Overlap



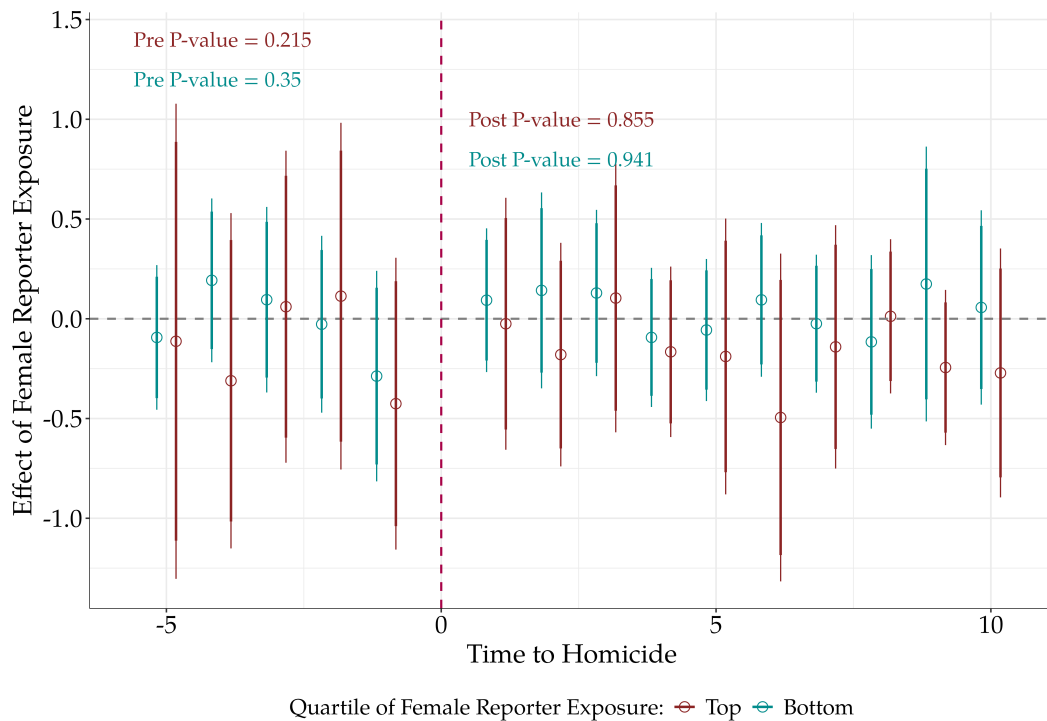
Notes. Calls to the helpline number before and after a murder happens in the same province for increasing exposure to female reporters in the first five articles covering the crime. The figure plots the coefficient from regression (6) excluding crimes that occur within 10 weeks of another crime. The regressions include province and week-fixed effects and exclude crimes occurring within 10 weeks of the previous one in the same province. The plots show 95% and 90% confidence intervals constructed by clustering errors at the province level. The overlaid text reports the p-value from an F-test for the joint significance of the pre- (top left) and post-murder (top right) indicators.

Figure A.9: Randomization Inference: Reshuffling Female-Reporter Shares



Notes. Distribution of the estimated effect of female-reporter exposure on calls when the weekly female-reporter shares are reshuffled across weeks within each province and within each province-year, and the treatment is rebuilt. The dashed red vertical line marks the estimate on the true data.

Figure A.10: Event Study: Effect of Female-Reporter Exposure on Calls—Placebo



Notes. Calls to the helpline number before and after a placebo murder happens in the same province for increasing exposure to female reporters in the first five articles covering crimes. The figure plots the coefficient from regression (6) for placebo murders. The regression includes province and week fixed effects. It shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals constructed by clustering errors at the province level. Overlaid text reports the p-value from an F-test for the joint significance of the pre- (top left) and post-murder (top right) indicators.

A.7 Additional Tables and Figures

Table A.36: Most Read Newspapers per Province

Newspaper	Newspaper Diffusion	Characteristics Ideology
<i>Corriere della Sera</i>	260357	Progressive
<i>Repubblica</i>	136321	Progressive
<i>Avvenire</i>	100802	Conservative
<i>La Stampa</i>	97800	Progressive
<i>Il Messaggero</i>	70021	Conservative
<i>Il Resto del Carlino</i>	67155	Conservative
<i>Il Fatto Quotidiano</i>	50515	Progressive
<i>Il Gazzettino</i>	47987	Conservative
<i>La Nazione</i>	44224	Conservative
<i>Il Giornale</i>	32461	Conservative
<i>Messaggero Veneto</i>	30045	–
<i>Il Secolo XIX</i>	26366	–
<i>Il Tirreno</i>	24349	–
<i>Il Mattino</i>	24328	–
<i>Gazzetta di Parma</i>	23575	–
<i>L'Arena</i>	23092	Conservative
<i>La Nuova Sardegna</i>	22356	Progressive
<i>Il Giornale di Vicenza</i>	21360	Progressive
<i>Il Giorno</i>	20605	Conservative
<i>Il Piccolo</i>	15514	–
<i>Il Manifesto</i>	13356	Progressive
<i>Quotidiano di Sicilia</i>	11206	–
<i>Gazzetta del Sud</i>	11145	–
<i>Corriere Adriatico</i>	9507	Progressive
<i>Nuovo Quotidiano di Puglia</i>	8465	–
<i>La Provincia Pavese</i>	7962	Progressive
<i>La Tribuna di Treviso</i>	7722	Progressive
<i>La Gazzetta del Mezzogiorno</i>	7610	Progressive
<i>Gazzetta di Reggio</i>	6063	Progressive
<i>Nuova Gazzetta di Modena</i>	5803	Progressive
<i>La Nuova Venezia</i>	5687	Progressive
<i>La Nuova Ferrara</i>	4621	Progressive

Notes. List of Italian newspapers in the sample (most read national newspapers and two most read newspapers per province). *Diffusion* indicates the number of newspaper copies sold in 2022 all over Italy.

Table A.37: Summary Statistics: Murders with Female Victims

Variable	Mean	SD	N
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Victim Italian	0.77	0.42	1969
Perpetrator Italian	0.83	0.37	1860
Perpetrator Partner	0.66	0.47	1861
Perpetrator Relative	0.21	0.41	1861
Relationship Missing	0.06	0.25	1989
North	0.49	0.50	1989
South	0.30	0.46	1989
Center	0.21	0.41	1989

Notes. Summary statistics of murders with female victims. *North*, *Center*, and *South* indicate whether the region where the crime happened is in the North, Center, or South of Italy.

Table A.38: Summary Statistics: Reporters

Variable	Total	Mean		Difference in Means	
		Female Reporters	Male Reporters	Without FE	With FE
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Region Gender Norms	0.301 (0.068)	0.301 (0.068)	0.3 (0.068)	0 (0.001)	-0.002 (0.007)
Year of Birth	1971.627 (10.06)	1973.964 (8.807)	1969.943 (10.559)	4.021*** (0.154)	3.675*** (0.546)
Start Year	1999.815 (10.111)	2001.814 (9.045)	1998.374 (10.583)	3.441*** (0.155)	3.009*** (0.761)
North	0.468 (0.499)	0.454 (0.498)	0.478 (0.5)	-0.023*** (0.008)	0.016 (0.064)
South	0.22 (0.414)	0.21 (0.407)	0.227 (0.419)	-0.017*** (0.006)	-0.021 (0.035)
Liberal	0.62 (0.485)	0.586 (0.493)	0.644 (0.479)	-0.057*** (0.007)	-0.051* (0.029)
Conservative	0.266 (0.442)	0.297 (0.457)	0.243 (0.429)	0.054*** (0.007)	0.053* (0.03)

Notes. Summary statistics of reporters for the whole sample and separately for female and male reporters. The last two columns show the difference in mean between female and male reporters, with and without newspaper times year fixed effects. *Region Gender Norms* indicates the share of households for each region in which only the man is working. *North* and *South* indicate the region of residence of the reporter.

Table A.39: Female Reporters by Newspaper

Newspaper	Female Reporters		
	Share of Articles	Number	Share
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Repubblica	0.44	176	0.40
CDS	0.39	150	0.41
La Stampa	0.29	123	0.36
Il Mattino	0.45	119	0.45
Il Messaggero	0.53	104	0.45
Il Gazzettino	0.47	96	0.46
La Nazione	0.41	95	0.44
Il Resto del Carlino	0.48	91	0.43
Giornale	0.47	48	0.35
Corriere Adriatico	0.41	35	0.41
La Nuova Sardegna	0.36	29	0.41
Nuovo Quotidiano di Puglia	0.38	28	0.46
Fatto Quotidiano	0.39	27	0.38
Il Secolo XIX	0.35	26	0.39
Avvenire	0.26	25	0.32
Messaggero Veneto	0.56	22	0.45
Il Giorno	0.40	18	0.50
Il Tirreno	0.52	16	0.50
Il Piccolo	0.26	12	0.38
L'Arena	0.50	12	0.34
La Nuova Venezia	0.34	11	0.41
La Provincia Pavese	0.42	9	0.43
Il Giornale di Vicenza	0.22	9	0.30
Gazzetta di Parma	0.50	7	0.50
Il Manifesto	0.48	4	0.33
La Tribuna di Treviso	0.67	4	0.67
La Gazzetta di Reggio	0.73	4	0.57
La Nuova Ferrara	0.28	3	0.30
Gazzetta del Sud	0.41	3	0.30
La Gazzetta di Modena	0.41	2	0.29
Quotidiano di Sicilia	0.19	1	0.33

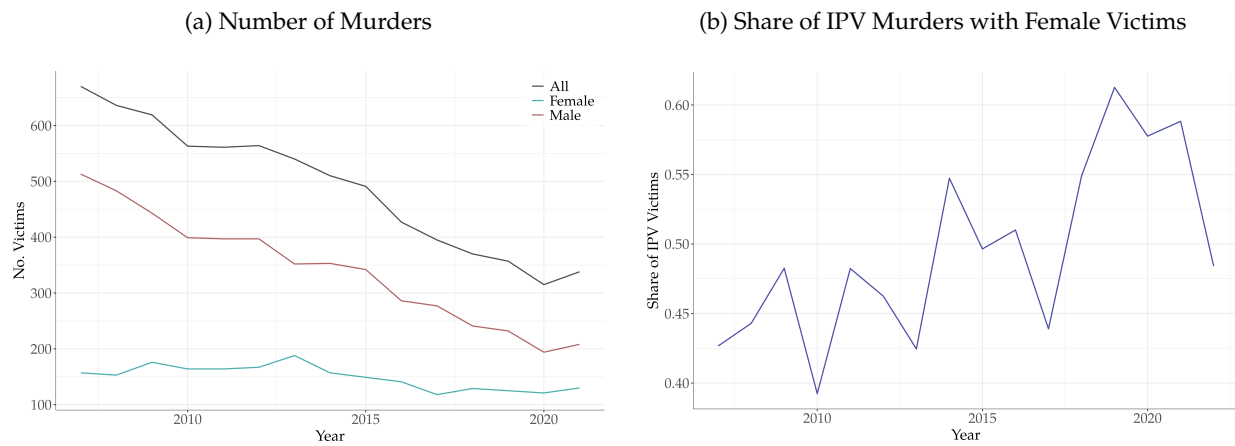
Notes. Female reporters by newspaper. Column 1 reports the share of articles written by female reporters in each newspaper. Columns 2 and 3 report the number and share of female reporters in each newspaper, respectively.

Table A.40: Correlation Between Proxy for Gender Norms and Gender Norms

	Stereotypical Behavior	Support for Traditional Gender Norms	Stereotypes about Sex. Violence
Share of HH with no Woman Working	0.766	0.785	0.710

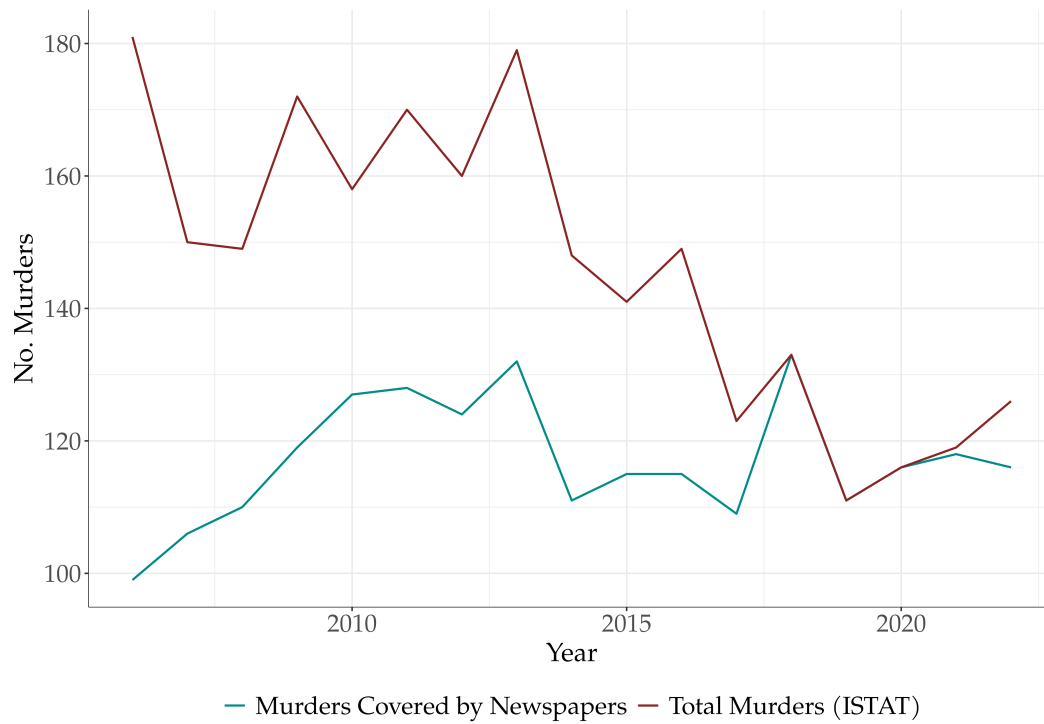
Notes. Pearson correlation between the proxy for gender norms in 2018, namely the share of households with couples where only the man is working, and survey-based measures of stereotypical behavior—e.g., for women, it is less important to have a career—, support for traditional gender norms—e.g., men should provide economically for their family—, and acceptability of intimate partner violence—e.g., it is acceptable to slap a woman if she has been cheating.

Figure A.11: Murders over Time



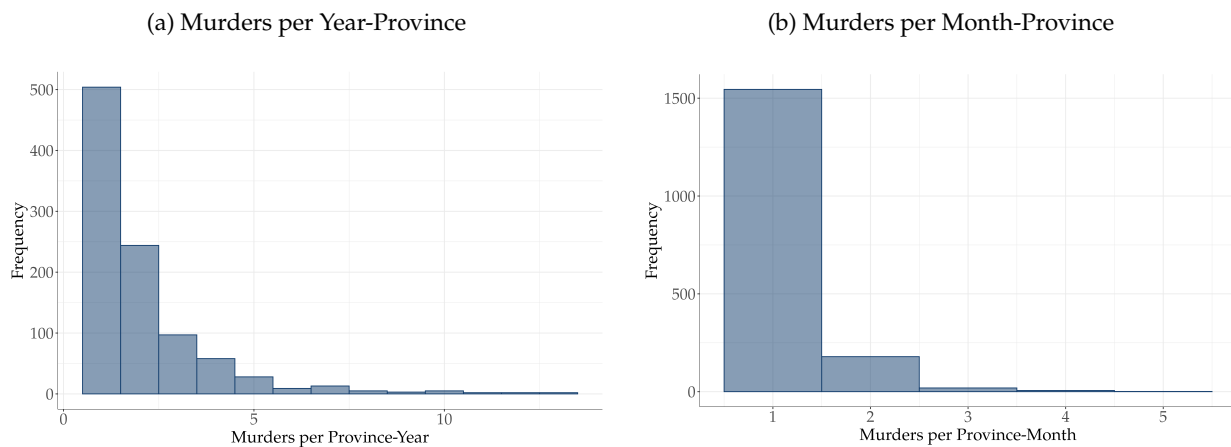
Notes. Time series of victims of homicide in Italy from 2006 to 2022. Panel (a) plots the number of victims of voluntary homicides in Italy, both overall and separately by gender, while Panel (b) plots the share of female victims murdered by their ex- or current intimate partner.

Figure A.12: Number of Murders with Female Victims



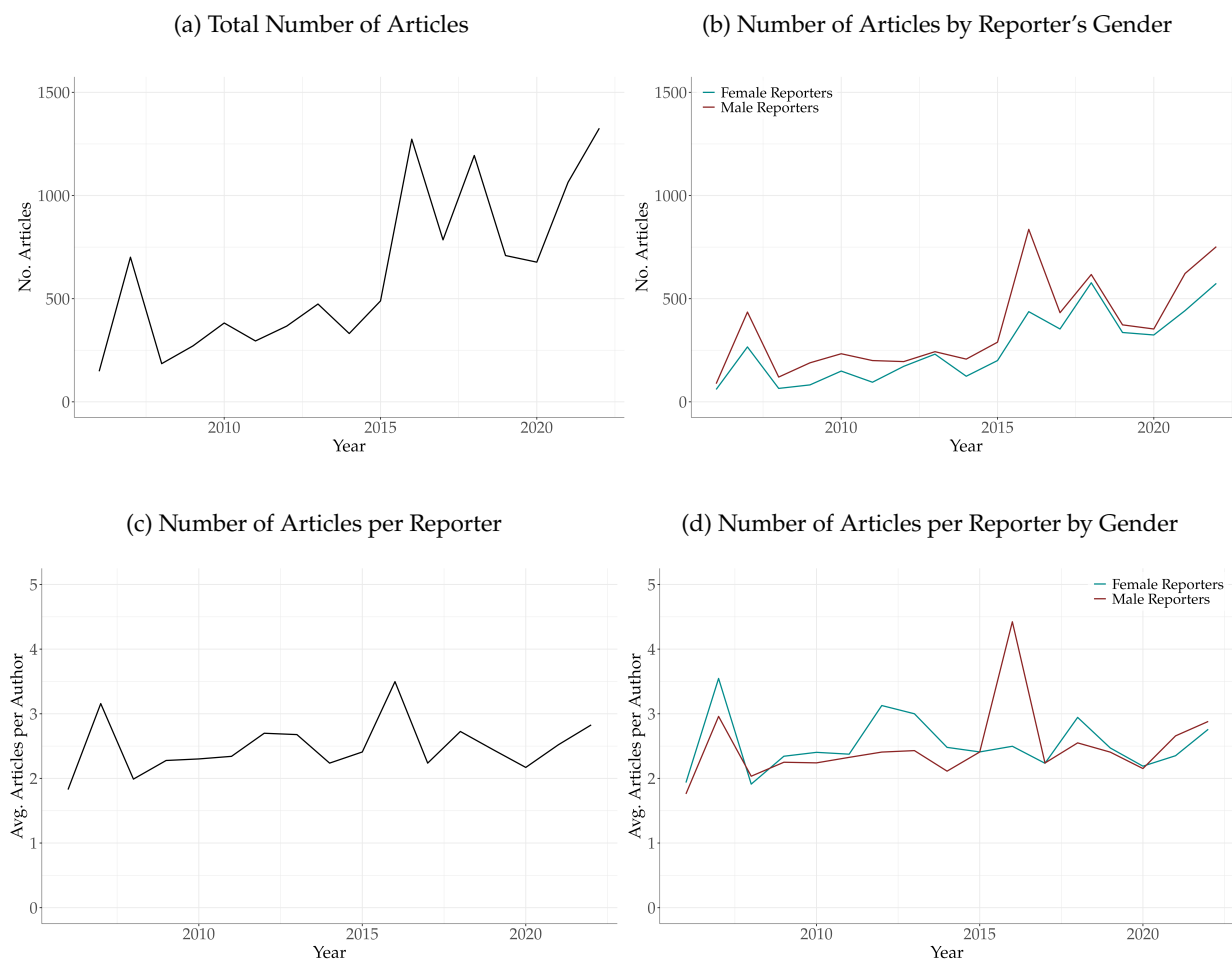
Notes. Number of murders with female victims plotted separately for the national average, calculated using data from the Italian National Statistical Office, and the events in the newly compiled dataset.

Figure A.13: Distribution of Murders



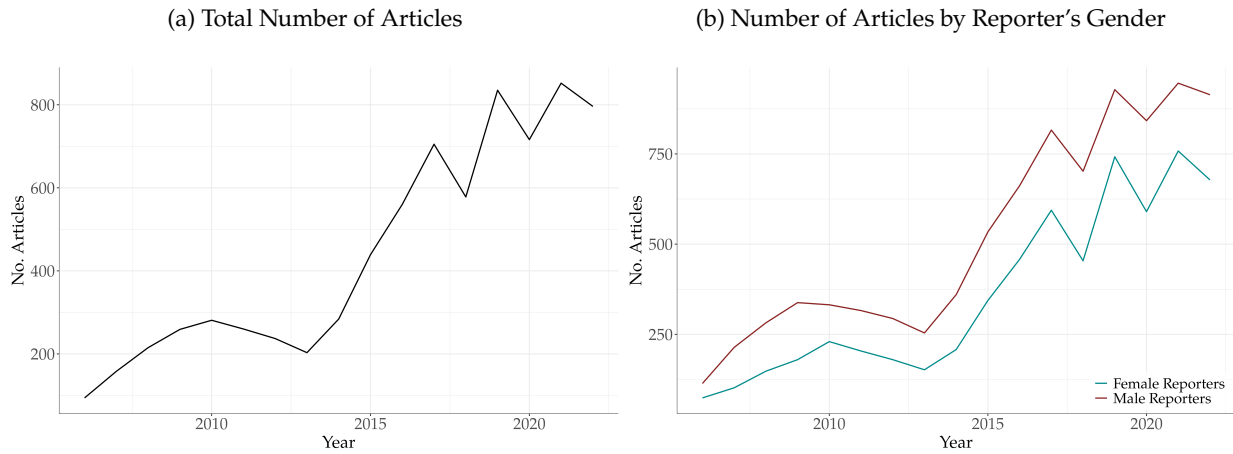
Notes. Histogram of number of murders with female victims in each province and year (Panel a) and in each province and month (Panel b).

Figure A.14: Time Series of Articles on Murders with Female Victims



Notes. Number of articles on murders with female victims plotted by year. Panels (a) and (c) report the total number of articles by year and the average number of articles per reporter over time, respectively. Panels (b) and (d) report the total number of articles and the average number of articles per reporter over time, separately for female and male reporters.

Figure A.15: Number of Articles with Male Victims over Time



Notes. Total number of articles on murders with male victims plotted by year. Panel (a) shows the total number of articles by year, while Panel (b) shows the total number of articles separately for female and male reporters.

Figure A.16: Share of Articles for each Newspapers

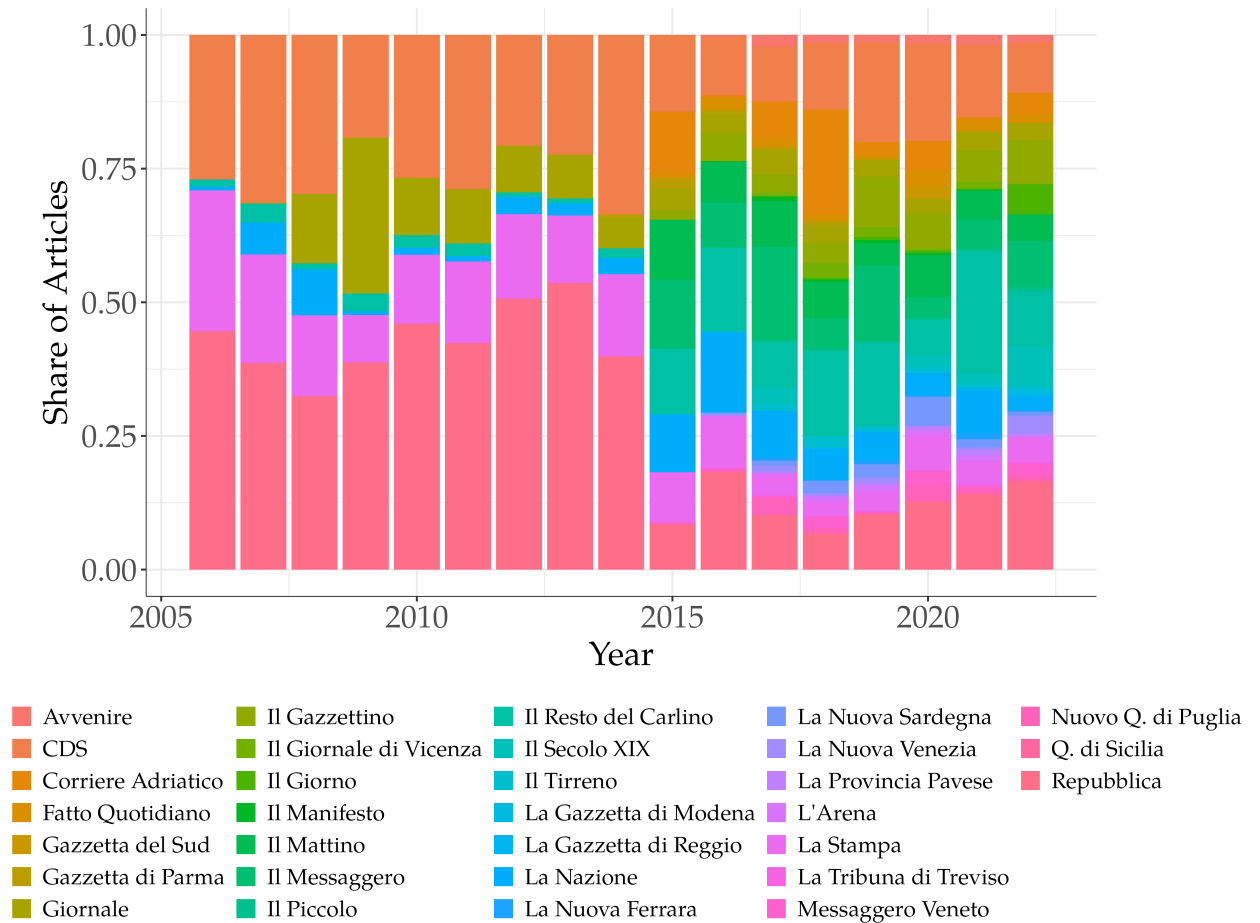
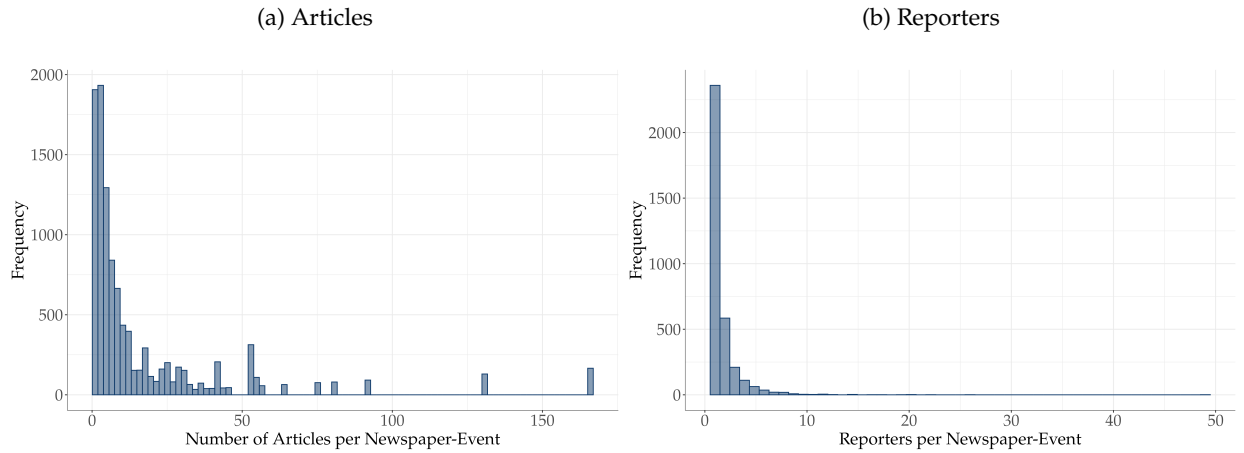
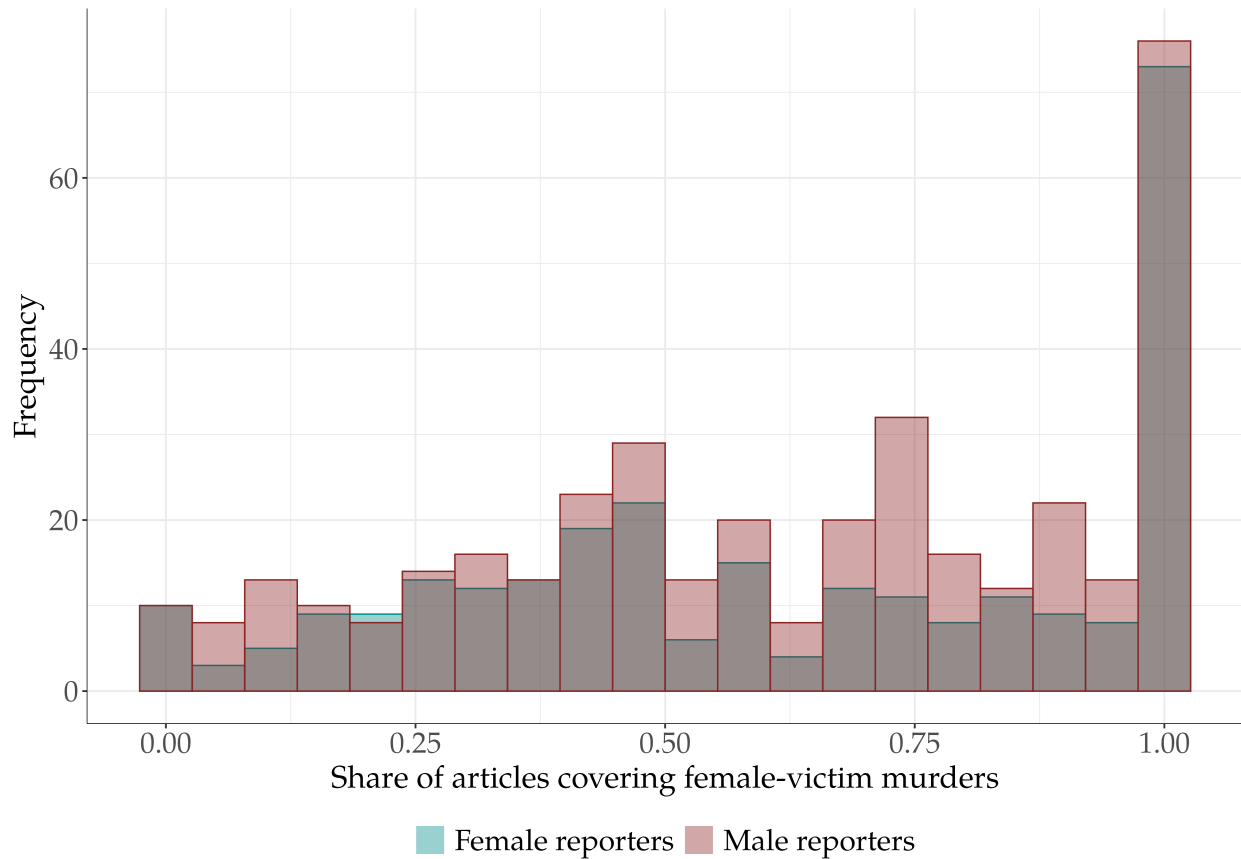


Figure A.17: Distribution of Articles and Reporters per Newspaper-Event



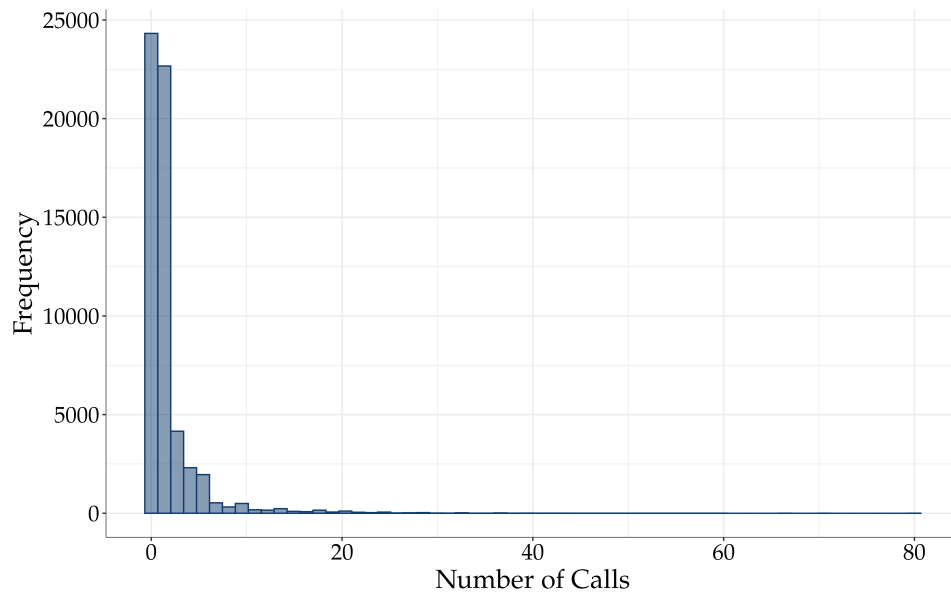
Notes. Frequency of number of articles (Panel a) and reporters (Panel b) for each newspaper and crime in the sample of articles on murders with female victims.

Figure A.18: Distribution of Share of Articles on Crimes with Female Victims



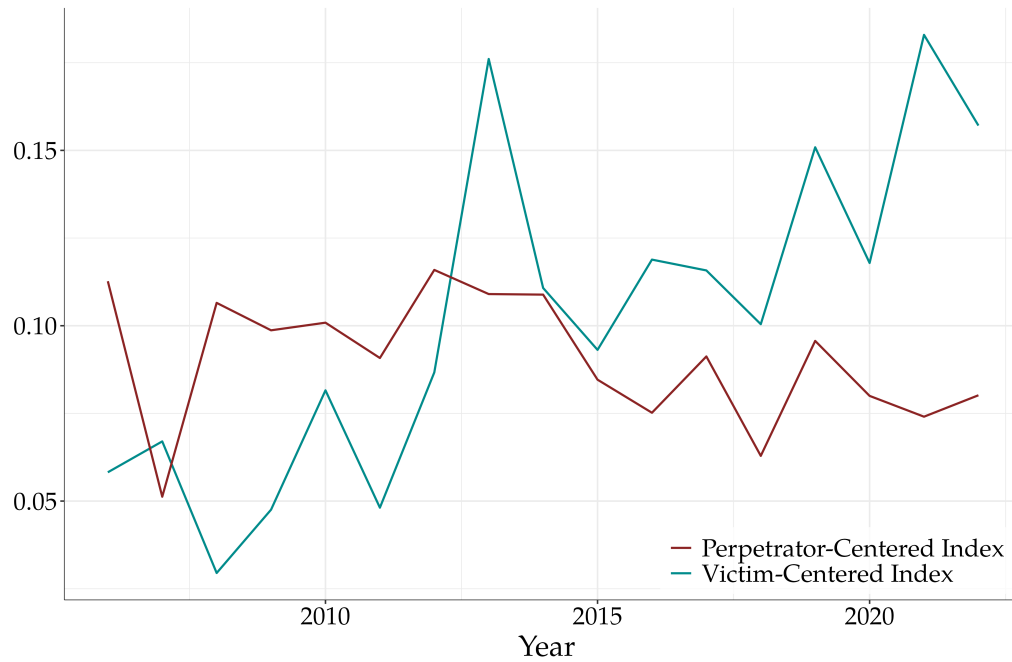
Notes. Distribution across reporters of the share of articles about murders with female victims, over the total number of articles in the sample, that each reporter writes about, separately by reporters' gender. The figure considers only reporters who authored more than 5 articles.

Figure A.19: Distribution of Helpline Calls



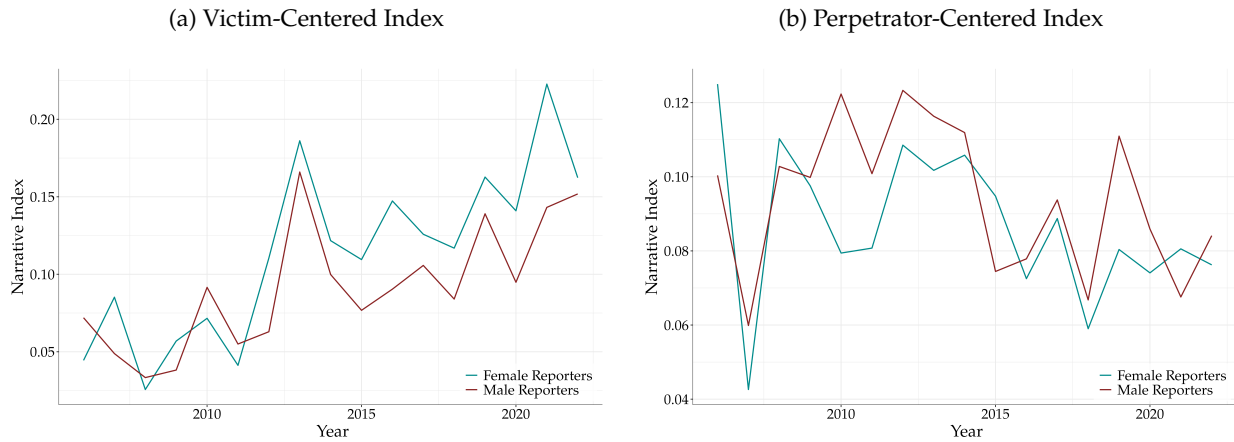
Notes. Histogram of the number of calls to the 1522 helpline number in each week and province, from 2013 on.

Figure A.20: Narrative Indexes over Time



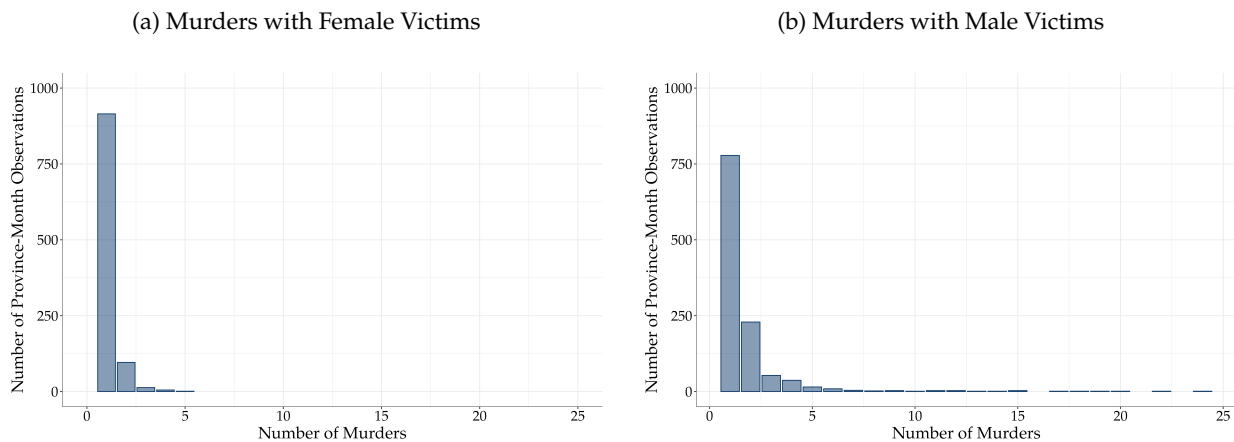
Notes. Average victim-centered and perpetrator-centered indexes, plotted by year.

Figure A.21: Trend in Reporting Practices by Gender



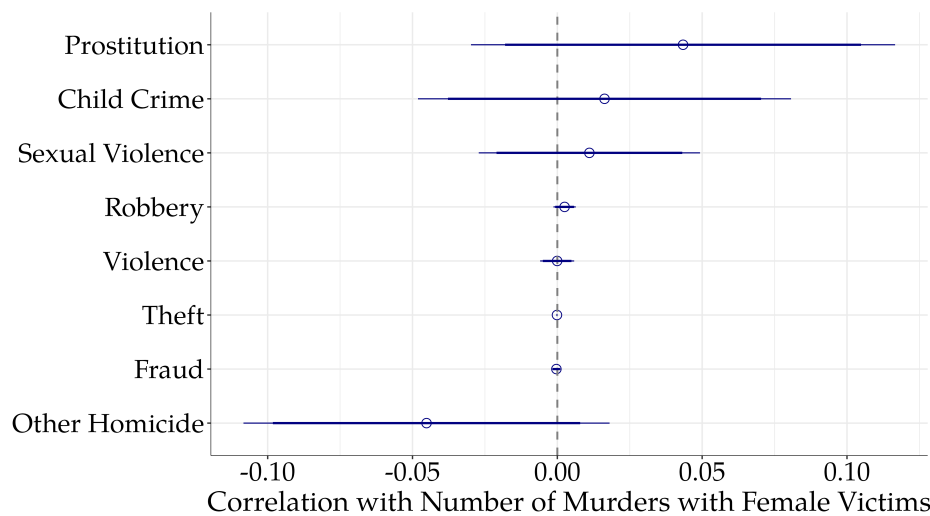
Notes. Victim-centered and perpetrator-centered indexes plotted by year separately for male and female reporters. Panel (a) shows the victim-centered index, while Panel (b) shows the perpetrator-centered index.

Figure A.22: Number of Murders in each Province and Month



Notes. Number of murders in each province and month, for province-month observations that have at least one murder. Panel (a) plots the province-months observations for murders with female victims, while Panel (b) plots murders with male victims.

Figure A.23: Correlations Between Murders with Female Victims and Crime Rates



Notes. Correlation between the number of murders with female victims and other crime rates in each province and year. All regressions include province and year fixed effects and the figure shows 95% and 90% confidence intervals.

B Additional Experimental Results

B.1 Additional Results on Narrative Effects

Table B.1: Effect of Narratives on Empathy towards the Victim

	Full		Females	Males	Sample		Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	Has Daughter	No Daughter	(7)	(8)
Intercept	77.286*** (0.878)	67.654*** (1.933)	71.995*** (2.754)	66.464*** (3.062)	76.096*** (9.254)	67.401*** (2.039)	70.898*** (3.021)	76.285*** (5.224)
PC Narr.	3.833*** (1.133)	3.548*** (1.142)	3.767** (1.671)	3.400* (1.996)	4.198 (3.928)	3.639*** (1.198)	3.920** (1.542)	-1.678 (4.760)
EVC Narr.	2.522* (1.431)	2.273* (1.372)	1.274 (1.963)	3.120 (1.954)	-0.169 (3.534)	2.378* (1.428)	2.403 (1.990)	-1.125 (4.410)
TVC Narr.	1.111 (1.693)	0.705 (1.628)	1.274 (2.099)	0.193 (2.753)	3.768 (4.637)	0.461 (1.829)	1.703 (2.274)	-5.175 (3.830)
Observations	1508	1508	722	786	141	1367	692	160
R ²	0.005	0.062	0.057	0.045	0.183	0.050	0.054	0.074
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different narratives on the empathy towards the victim measured on a scale from 0 (*not feeling close*) to 100 (*feeling very close*). Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.2: Effect of Narratives on Empathy towards the Perpetrator

	Sample							
	Full		Females	Males	Has Daughter	No Daughter	Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Intercept	11.068*** (0.974)	13.455*** (1.705)	10.294*** (1.963)	13.294*** (2.488)	13.784** (5.594)	13.268*** (1.824)	11.930*** (2.835)	14.221*** (3.467)
PC Narr.	-1.506 (1.206)	-1.170 (1.152)	-1.824 (1.443)	-0.219 (1.640)	-4.915 (4.996)	-0.914 (1.176)	-1.242 (1.539)	3.276 (3.849)
EVC Narr.	-3.225** (1.265)	-3.098** (1.236)	-1.499 (1.670)	-4.648*** (1.656)	-8.073* (4.360)	-2.637** (1.285)	-3.703* (2.114)	-4.281 (2.777)
TVC Narr.	-2.871** (1.192)	-2.649** (1.142)	-0.860 (1.479)	-4.201** (1.745)	-4.941 (4.567)	-2.500** (1.201)	-1.552 (1.885)	-0.083 (3.839)
Observations	1508	1508	722	786	141	1367	692	160
R ²	0.006	0.035	0.020	0.033	0.094	0.035	0.030	0.060
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different narratives on the empathy towards the perpetrator measured on a scale from 0 (*not feeling close*) to 100 (*feeling very close*). Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.3: Effect of Narratives on Perceived Prevalence of VAW

	Sample							
	Full		Females	Males	Has Daughter	No Daughter	Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Intercept	0.028 (0.056)	0.105 (0.119)	0.734*** (0.175)	0.080 (0.152)	0.136 (0.676)	0.103 (0.129)	0.449*** (0.144)	−0.330 (0.220)
EVC Narr.	−0.072 (0.066)	−0.037 (0.063)	0.043 (0.109)	−0.123* (0.069)	0.455** (0.208)	−0.081 (0.073)	−0.086 (0.090)	−0.042 (0.163)
TVC Narr.	−0.143** (0.065)	−0.113* (0.061)	−0.223** (0.087)	−0.045 (0.078)	0.308 (0.196)	−0.151** (0.064)	−0.162* (0.091)	−0.162 (0.150)
Observations	1137	1137	550	587	108	1029	529	122
R ²	0.004	0.211	0.112	0.128	0.249	0.203	0.186	0.280
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different victim-centered compared to perpetrator-centered narratives on perceived prevalence of VAW-related crimes among 10000 women in the respondents' province. Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.4: Effect of Narratives on Perceived Minus Real Prevalence of Police Reporting

	Sample							
	Full		Females	Males	Has Daughter	No Daughter	Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Intercept	0.064 (0.052)	0.230* (0.137)	0.839*** (0.136)	0.077 (0.172)	0.338 (0.497)	0.236* (0.136)	0.300** (0.138)	0.163 (0.272)
EVC Narr.	0.032 (0.060)	0.044 (0.055)	0.104 (0.097)	−0.022 (0.065)	0.419* (0.234)	0.014 (0.068)	0.007 (0.079)	−0.187 (0.200)
TVC Narr.	−0.077 (0.071)	−0.054 (0.064)	−0.131 (0.098)	0.002 (0.101)	0.166 (0.198)	−0.073 (0.069)	−0.049 (0.095)	−0.293 (0.209)
Observations	1138	1138	551	587	108	1030	529	122
R ²	0.002	0.065	0.047	0.027	0.175	0.062	0.060	0.119
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different victim-centered compared to perpetrator-centered narratives on the difference between perceived and real prevalence of police reporting of VAW-related crimes among 10000 women in the respondents' province. Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.5: Effect of Narratives on Perceived Minus Real Prevalence of Help-Seeking

	Sample							
	Full		Females	Males	Has Daughter	No Daughter	Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Intercept	0.015 (0.053)	−0.008 (0.121)	0.463*** (0.139)	−0.059 (0.145)	0.199 (0.435)	−0.022 (0.116)	0.083 (0.151)	−0.362 (0.227)
EVC Narr.	0.090* (0.051)	0.101** (0.048)	0.161** (0.079)	0.016 (0.067)	0.490** (0.205)	0.060 (0.053)	0.064 (0.086)	0.064 (0.139)
TVC Narr.	−0.007 (0.050)	0.011 (0.052)	−0.024 (0.088)	0.018 (0.074)	0.109 (0.169)	−0.002 (0.055)	0.022 (0.074)	0.069 (0.161)
Observations	1138	1138	551	587	108	1030	529	122
R ²	0.002	0.068	0.041	0.021	0.176	0.070	0.055	0.079
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different victim-centered compared to perpetrator-centered narratives on the difference between perceived and real prevalence of calls to the VAW helpline among 10000 women in the respondents' province. Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.6: Effect of Narratives on Declared Retention

	Full		Females	Males	Sample Has Daughter	No Daughter	Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Intercept	0.632*** (0.020)	0.679*** (0.043)	0.771*** (0.066)	0.641*** (0.048)	0.666*** (0.201)	0.690*** (0.050)	0.740*** (0.073)	1.088*** (0.146)
PC Narr.	-0.069** (0.028)	-0.063** (0.029)	-0.104** (0.044)	-0.024 (0.040)	-0.086 (0.121)	-0.061** (0.029)	-0.082** (0.037)	-0.207* (0.120)
EVC Narr.	-0.014 (0.034)	-0.009 (0.036)	-0.020 (0.052)	0.002 (0.046)	0.266** (0.128)	-0.035 (0.035)	-0.028 (0.062)	-0.079 (0.097)
TVC Narr.	0.019 (0.035)	0.023 (0.036)	0.008 (0.054)	0.041 (0.045)	0.104 (0.118)	0.018 (0.039)	0.012 (0.058)	-0.185** (0.088)
Observations	1508	1508	722	786	141	1367	692	160
R ²	0.004	0.021	0.033	0.034	0.158	0.018	0.014	0.152
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

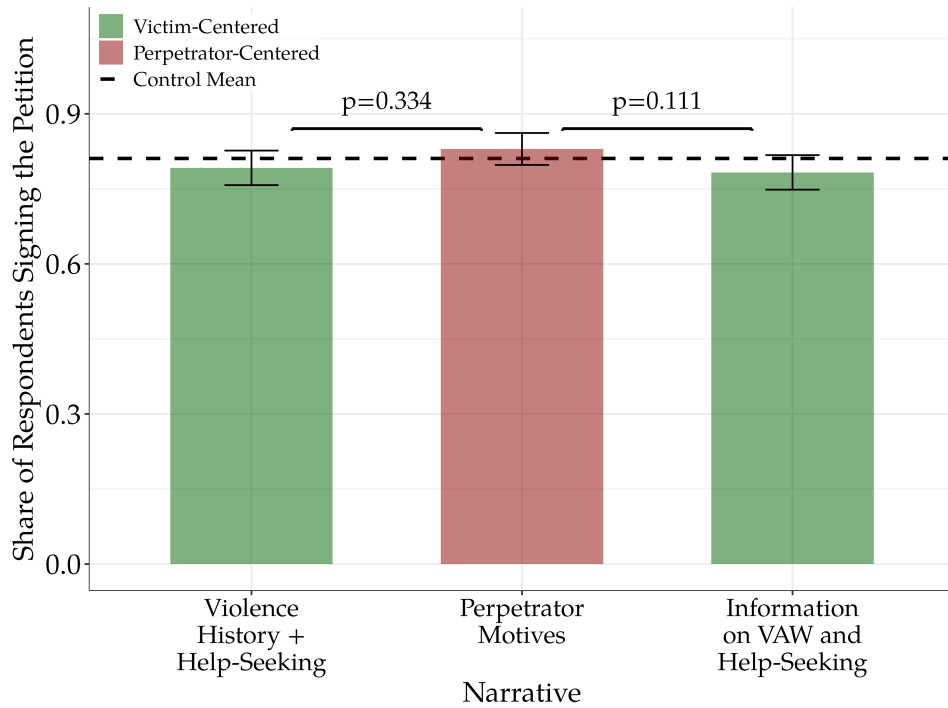
Notes. Effect of different narratives on the probability of using the newspaper in the future for crime information. Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.7: Effect of Narratives on Click-Through Engagement

	Full		Females	Males	Sample Has Daughter	No Daughter	Left-Wing	Right-Wing
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Intercept	0.541*** (0.022)	0.394*** (0.046)	0.414*** (0.057)	0.353*** (0.064)	0.242 (0.205)	0.384*** (0.051)	0.479*** (0.068)	0.389*** (0.120)
PC Narr.	0.023 (0.036)	0.012 (0.032)	0.012 (0.049)	0.020 (0.050)	-0.213 (0.133)	0.037 (0.036)	0.011 (0.043)	-0.207* (0.121)
EVC Narr.	-0.031 (0.033)	-0.038 (0.033)	0.004 (0.049)	-0.081 (0.052)	-0.126 (0.119)	-0.028 (0.034)	-0.082* (0.050)	-0.240** (0.110)
TVC Narr.	-0.034 (0.031)	-0.046 (0.030)	0.010 (0.045)	-0.100** (0.040)	-0.061 (0.111)	-0.046 (0.034)	-0.061 (0.051)	-0.161 (0.117)
Observations	1508	1508	722	786	141	1367	692	160
R ²	0.002	0.056	0.064	0.062	0.156	0.060	0.031	0.071
Controls		X	X	X	X	X	X	X

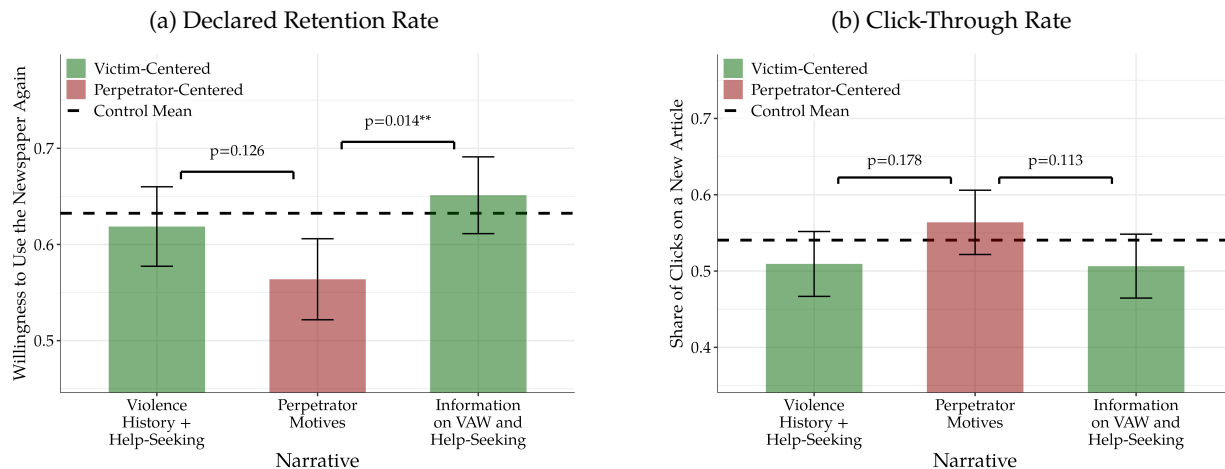
Notes. Effect of different narratives on the probability of clicking on a new article. Columns 1 and 2 report the results for the full sample, Columns 3 and 4 separately for female and male respondents, Columns 5 and 6 separately for respondents with at least one daughter or with no daughters, and Columns 7 and 8 separately for left and right-wing respondents. Columns 2 to 8 control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure B.1: Share of Respondents Signing the Petition



Notes. Share of respondents who sign the petition, separately by treatment. The dashed line marks the control mean. The figure reports 90% confidence intervals. Stars above each VC bar give the p-value of that treatment versus PC, from a regression on all treatments (excluding the control) with covariates; stars for each treatment versus the control come from a t-test: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure B.2: Effect of Narratives on News Engagement: Full Sample



Notes. Engagement metrics by treatment, estimated on the full sample. Panel (a) reports the declared retention rate, measured as the willingness to use the newspaper again in the future. Panel (b) reports the click-through rate, measured by monitoring respondents' clicks on another article linked at the bottom of the main one. The dashed line marks the control mean. The figure reports 90% confidence intervals. Brackets report p-values for pairwise comparisons between narratives. The corresponding estimates split by respondent gender are reported in Figure 8.

B.2 Robustness Checks on Experimental Evidence on Narrative Effects

Table B.8: Robustness: Effect of Narratives on Empathy towards the Victim

	Sample			Treatment		
	Main	Screened	Video Screened	No EVC 1	No EVC 2	No EVC 3
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Intercept	67.654*** (1.933)	67.888*** (1.953)	66.692*** (1.947)	67.790*** (2.037)	66.915*** (2.165)	68.027*** (1.965)
PC Narr.	3.548*** (1.142)	3.137*** (1.143)	4.118*** (1.212)	3.575*** (1.142)	3.566*** (1.130)	3.544*** (1.140)
EVC Narr.	2.273* (1.372)	2.372* (1.347)	2.790* (1.438)	2.381 (1.547)	2.448 (1.650)	2.107 (1.381)
TVC Narr.	0.705 (1.628)	0.686 (1.650)	1.124 (1.664)	0.726 (1.614)	0.729 (1.611)	0.711 (1.625)
Observations	1508	1443	1447	1380	1315	1454
R ²	0.062	0.066	0.066	0.062	0.067	0.063
Controls	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different narratives on the empathy towards the victim measured on a scale from 0 (*not feeling close*) to 100 (*feeling very close*). Column 1 reports the results for the main specification, Columns 2 and 3 exclude respondents who failed at one attention check, and the AI screening, respectively; Columns 4, 5, and 6 exclude each of the variations for EVC treatment. All Columns control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.9: Robustness: Effect of Narratives on Empathy towards the Perpetrator

	Sample			Treatment		
	Main (1)	Screened (2)	Video Screened (3)	No EVC 1 (4)	No EVC 2 (5)	No EVC 3 (6)
Intercept	13.455*** (1.705)	12.618*** (1.790)	13.846*** (1.685)	12.818*** (1.775)	12.869*** (1.888)	13.272*** (1.741)
PC Narr.	-1.170 (1.152)	-0.720 (1.153)	-1.122 (1.185)	-1.222 (1.149)	-1.170 (1.165)	-1.158 (1.153)
EVC Narr.	-3.098** (1.236)	-2.993** (1.238)	-2.858** (1.312)	-3.107** (1.447)	-3.110** (1.371)	-3.067** (1.259)
TVC Narr.	-2.649** (1.142)	-2.022* (1.080)	-2.881** (1.180)	-2.696** (1.131)	-2.687** (1.149)	-2.659** (1.142)
Observations	1508	1443	1447	1380	1315	1454
R ²	0.035	0.033	0.038	0.032	0.037	0.035
Controls	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different narratives on the empathy towards the perpetrator measured on a scale from 0 (*not feeling close*) to 100 (*feeling very close*). Column 1 reports the results for the main specification, Columns 2 and 3 exclude respondents who failed at one attention check, and the AI screening, respectively; Columns 4, 5, and 6 exclude each of the variations for EVC treatment. All Columns control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.10: Robustness: Effect of Narratives on Perceived Prevalence of VAW

	Sample			Treatment		
	Main (1)	Screened (2)	Video Screened (3)	No EVC 1 (4)	No EVC 2 (5)	No EVC 3 (6)
Intercept	0.105 (0.119)	0.118 (0.113)	0.101 (0.123)	0.108 (0.114)	0.181 (0.130)	0.109 (0.121)
EVC Narr.	-0.037 (0.063)	-0.031 (0.061)	-0.026 (0.058)	-0.007 (0.081)	-0.084 (0.067)	-0.032 (0.062)
TVC Narr.	-0.113* (0.061)	-0.112* (0.062)	-0.096* (0.058)	-0.112* (0.060)	-0.110* (0.062)	-0.114* (0.061)
Observations	1137	1088	1093	1009	944	1083
R ²	0.211	0.212	0.209	0.210	0.204	0.206
Controls	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different victim-centered compared to perpetrator-centered narratives on perceived prevalence of VAW-related crimes among 10000 women in the respondents' province. Column 1 reports the results for the main specification, Columns 2 and 3 exclude respondents who failed at one attention check, and the AI screening, respectively; Columns 4, 5, and 6 exclude each of the variations for EVC treatment. All Columns control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.11: Robustness: Effect of Narratives on Perceived Minus Real Prevalence of Police Reporting

	Sample			Treatment		
	Main (1)	Screened (2)	Video Screened (3)	No EVC 1 (4)	No EVC 2 (5)	No EVC 3 (6)
Intercept	0.230* (0.137)	0.233* (0.125)	0.246* (0.133)	0.256** (0.125)	0.240 (0.154)	0.231 (0.147)
EVC Narr.	0.044 (0.055)	0.035 (0.059)	0.046 (0.049)	0.025 (0.079)	0.031 (0.063)	0.071 (0.057)
TVC Narr.	-0.054 (0.064)	-0.047 (0.068)	-0.061 (0.065)	-0.053 (0.064)	-0.051 (0.065)	-0.054 (0.065)
Observations	1138	1089	1094	1010	945	1084
R ²	0.065	0.062	0.067	0.070	0.059	0.065
Controls	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different victim-centered compared to perpetrator-centered narratives on the difference between perceived and real prevalence of police reporting of VAW-related crimes among 10000 women in the respondents' province. Column 1 reports the results for the main specification, Columns 2 and 3 exclude respondents who failed at one attention check, and the AI screening, respectively; Columns 4, 5, and 6 exclude each of the variations for EVC treatment. All Columns control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

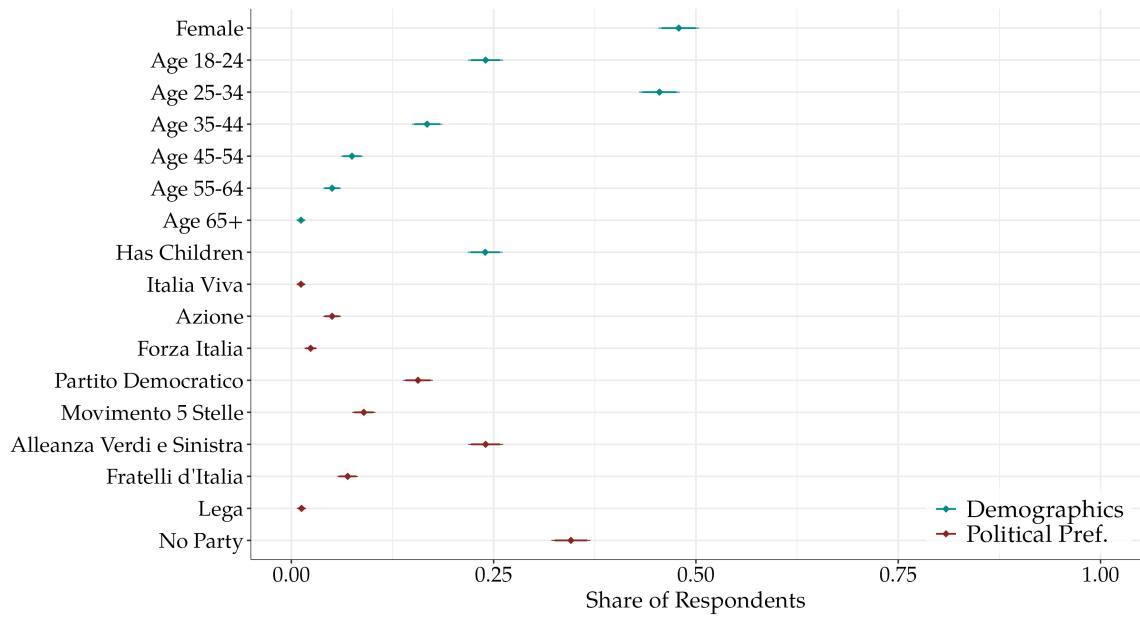
Table B.12: Robustness: Effect of Narratives on Perceived - Real Prevalence of Help-Seeking

	Sample			Treatment		
	Main (1)	Screened (2)	Video Screened (3)	No EVC 1 (4)	No EVC 2 (5)	No EVC 3 (6)
Intercept	-0.008 (0.121)	-0.009 (0.116)	0.007 (0.115)	0.020 (0.124)	-0.001 (0.135)	-0.002 (0.128)
EVC Narr.	0.101** (0.048)	0.110** (0.051)	0.097** (0.047)	0.042 (0.060)	0.138** (0.066)	0.126** (0.050)
TVC Narr.	0.011 (0.052)	0.025 (0.057)	0.002 (0.057)	0.012 (0.051)	0.011 (0.052)	0.010 (0.052)
Observations	1138	1089	1094	1010	945	1084
R ²	0.068	0.068	0.069	0.069	0.063	0.071
Controls	X	X	X	X	X	X

Notes. Effect of different victim-centered compared to perpetrator-centered narratives on the difference between perceived and real prevalence of calls to the VAW helpline among 10000 women in the respondents' province. Column 1 reports the results for the main specification, Columns 2 and 3 exclude respondents who failed at one attention check, and the AI screening, respectively; Columns 4, 5, and 6 exclude each of the variations for EVC treatment. All Columns control for the respondent's gender, whether they have a daughter, political affiliation, and an aggregated proxy for gender norms, unless the covariate is used to determine the subsample. Standard errors are clustered at the province level (in parentheses): * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

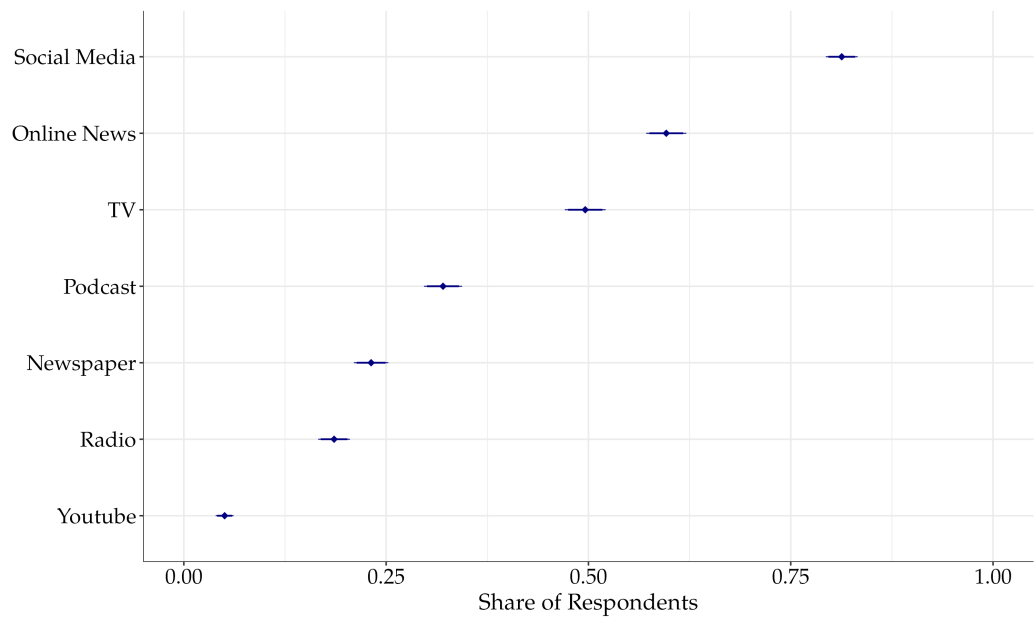
B.3 Additional Information on Experimental Sample

Figure B.3: Respondents' Socio-Demographic Characteristics



Notes. Respondents' socio-demographics characteristics. The figure reports confidence intervals at the 90% and 95% level.

Figure B.4: Respondents' Use of News Sources



Notes. Respondents' use of news sources. The figure reports confidence intervals at the 90% and 95% level.

Figure B.5: Geographical Distribution of Respondents

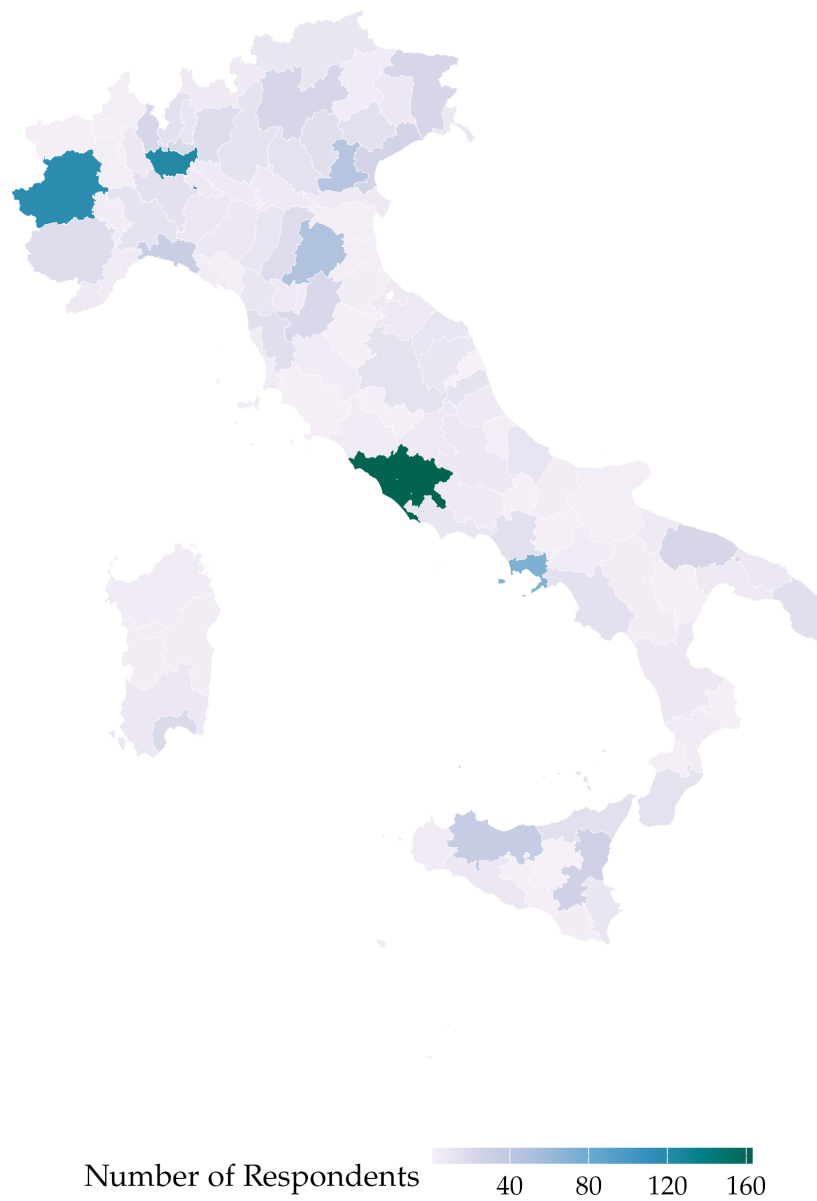
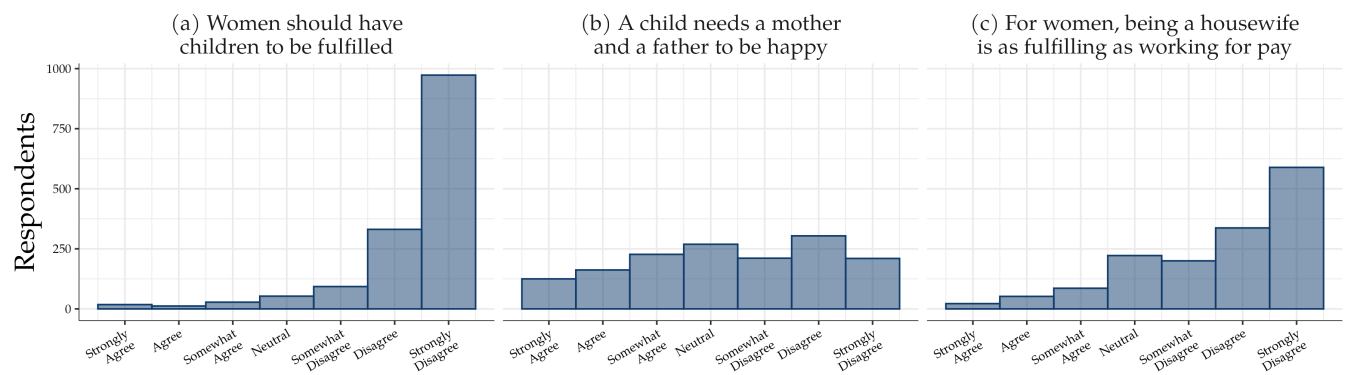


Figure B.6: Respondents Gender and Family Norms



Notes. Distribution of respondents across different levels of agreement with statements proxying gender and family norms. The questions come from the World Values Survey.

Table B.13: Balance Table: Respondents' Characteristics across Treatments

Variable	Treatment			
	Control	Perpetrator-Centered	Victim-Centered Episodic	Victim-Centered Thematic
Female	0.462 (0.026)	0.495 (0.026)	0.485 (0.026)	0.473 (0.025)
Age 18-24	0.241 (0.022)	0.250 (0.022)	0.219 (0.021)	0.251 (0.022)
Age 25-34	0.451 (0.026)	0.465 (0.026)	0.483 (0.026)	0.421 (0.025)
Age 35-44	0.170 (0.020)	0.152 (0.019)	0.176 (0.020)	0.173 (0.019)
Age 45-54	0.092 (0.015)	0.069 (0.013)	0.056 (0.012)	0.083 (0.014)
Age 55-64	0.041 (0.010)	0.048 (0.011)	0.045 (0.011)	0.067 (0.013)
Age 65+	0.005 (0.004)	0.016 (0.006)	0.021 (0.007)	0.005 (0.004)
Has Children	0.241 (0.031)	0.229 (0.030)	0.222 (0.031)	0.266 (0.033)
Italia Viva	0.014 (0.006)	0.005 (0.004)	0.016 (0.006)	0.013 (0.006)
Azione	0.043 (0.011)	0.066 (0.013)	0.048 (0.011)	0.044 (0.010)
Forza Italia	0.019 (0.007)	0.027 (0.008)	0.024 (0.008)	0.026 (0.008)
Partito Democratico	0.165 (0.019)	0.117 (0.017)	0.165 (0.019)	0.178 (0.019)
Movimento 5 Stelle	0.116 (0.017)	0.085 (0.014)	0.067 (0.013)	0.090 (0.015)
Alleanza Verdi e Sinistra	0.219 (0.022)	0.263 (0.023)	0.243 (0.022)	0.235 (0.022)
Fratelli d'Italia	0.076 (0.014)	0.059 (0.012)	0.072 (0.013)	0.072 (0.013)
Lega	0.008 (0.005)	0.013 (0.006)	0.013 (0.006)	0.016 (0.006)
No Party	0.341 (0.025)	0.364 (0.025)	0.352 (0.025)	0.326 (0.024)
News: TV	0.530 (0.026)	0.500 (0.026)	0.493 (0.026)	0.463 (0.025)
News: Radio	0.203 (0.021)	0.173 (0.020)	0.168 (0.019)	0.199 (0.020)
News: Newspaper	0.205 (0.021)	0.221 (0.021)	0.243 (0.022)	0.256 (0.022)
News: Social Media	0.811 (0.020)	0.830 (0.019)	0.805 (0.020)	0.806 (0.020)
News: Online News	0.616 (0.025)	0.598 (0.025)	0.555 (0.026)	0.615 (0.025)
News: Podcast	0.303 (0.024)	0.356 (0.025)	0.331 (0.024)	0.292 (0.023)
News: Youtube	0.049 (0.011)	0.040 (0.010)	0.051 (0.011)	0.062 (0.012)
Women should have children to be fulfilled	6.292 (0.062)	6.431 (0.054)	6.275 (0.069)	6.463 (0.050)
A child needs a mother and a father to be happy	4.292 (0.096)	4.489 (0.093)	4.333 (0.097)	4.274 (0.095)
For women, housewife is as fulfilling as paid work	5.505 (0.079)	5.614 (0.078)	5.523 (0.082)	5.680 (0.077)
Observations	370	376	375	387

C Keyword-Based Measure

C.1 Examples of Articles

In this section, I present examples of articles that score high on victim- and perpetrator-centered narratives. The articles have been modified to remove all information that could identify the people involved. I **highlight** the pieces of text that contribute to the corresponding index.

- **Victim-Centered Index = 1:** Milan – Murdered by Her Husband in the Bedroom with 23 Stab Wounds, **After Twenty Years of Violence and Threats**. This is how [VICTIM], [...], met her tragic end in her 30-square-meter apartment in Lorenteggio, a southern suburb of Milan. Her killer, [PERPETRATOR], [...] with minor prior offenses for resisting a public official and insulting an officer. After denying everything for hours, he finally confessed at 4 AM when the inconsistencies in his version of events became impossible to sustain. According to the head of Milan's homicide squad, who conducted the investigation alongside the prosecutor, the man displayed a "cold and calculated" demeanor in his attempt to cover up the murder. Investigators reconstructed the events leading up to the crime: the couple had returned on Saturday from a month-long vacation in Pantelleria and had a violent argument on Sunday morning. **It was just one of many fights between them, as neighbors later recounted.** During the altercation—[PERPETRATOR] later confessed—[VICTIM] allegedly threatened him with an iron. In response, he savagely attacked her with a kitchen knife. After the murder, he staged an elaborate deception to mislead the investigation. He left the house and wandered the neighborhood for three hours—shopping for groceries, buying pastries, chatting with acquaintances, and stopping at a bar to play slot machines. In the meantime, he managed to dispose of the murder weapon and his bloodstained clothes in a storm drain two kilometers away, where they were unlikely to be found. Around 3 PM, [PERPETRATOR] returned home and called emergency services and the police, claiming he had found the door open and his wife lying in a pool of blood. **His story was eerily similar to what had happened in 1995 when [VICTIM] had been stabbed and her husband had called for help, claiming he had found the door open and his wife bleeding. Back then, she did not report him, and from that moment on, their life together was marked by endless arguments, shouting, and threats.** The entire neighborhood was aware—neighbors could hear the screams coming from the ground-floor apartment. Yet no one ever intervened to protect her. **Just two months ago, on November 5, the police had been called to break up another violent dispute.** According to Milan's police chief, this case is **"emblematic of a toxic family dynamic, where violent relationships remain hidden."** It is the story of a woman abandoned to her fate, without support to escape a life of terror. **"There are now legal measures in place. Victims of stalking must turn to anti-violence centers and alert the police, who have the authority to issue warnings to violent men."** But few women do. **"In the past year alone, I have personally met with 38 men who were reported for violence by their wives and partners."** The system works. Yet in Milan, we receive hundreds of calls reporting violence against women, and many of them

Table C.1: Full List of Keywords per Dictionary

Topic	Words
Fit of Rage	<i>'raptus', 'rabbia', 'delitto d'impeto', 'impeto omicida', 'gesto d'impeto', 'gesto di impeto', 'omicidio di impeto', 'impeto di rabbia', 'impeto di gelosia', 'impeto di odio', 'impeto di follia', 'impeto di violenza', 'in un impeto', 'impeto nervoso', 'violenza cieca', 'violenta e irrazionale', 'impeto di gelosia', 'impulso', 'furia', 'perde la testa', 'ira' (whole word), 'collera', 'furore', 'furibondo', 'infuriato', 'fuori di sé', 'fuori di senno', 'fuori di se', 'delirio', 'follia', 'pazzia', 'collera', 'irrefrenabile', 'foga omicida', 'foga di uccidere', 'furente', 'irascibile', 'sfogare la frustrazione', 'sfogato la frustrazione', 'sfogare la propria frustrazione', 'sfogato la propria frustrazione', 'preda della frustrazione'</i>
Jealousy	<i>'gelosia', 'ossessione', 'rivale in amore', 'geloso', 'morbosa', 'morboso', 'delitto passionale'</i>
Economic Difficulties	<i>'difficoltà finanziarie', 'difficile situazione lavorativa', 'crisi lavorativa', 'disoccupato', 'precario', 'licenziato', 'debiti', 'debito', 'perso il lavoro', 'indebitato', 'difficoltà economiche', 'problemi finanziari', 'instabilità economica', 'questioni economiche', 'ristrettezze economiche', 'preoccupazioni economiche', 'difficile situazione economica', 'difficile condizione economica', 'difficoltà finanziaria', 'precarietà economica'</i>
Mental Health Problems	<i>'salute mentale', 'disturbi psicologici', 'dipendenza', 'tossicodipendenza', 'alcolismo', 'abuso di sostanze', 'abuso di alcol', 'abuso di alcool', 'abuso di alcolici', 'abuso di droghe', 'depressi*', 'ossessivo compulsivo', 'disturbo di personalità', 'disturbi di personalità', 'narcisi*', 'disturbo psicologico', 'uso di sostanze', 'disturbi mentali', 'psicopatologici', 'perizia psichiatrica', 'dissociativi', 'psicopatologiche', 'malattia mentale', 'malato mentale'</i>
Infidelity	<i>'relazione segreta', 'infedeltà', 'scappatella', 'flirt*', 'tradimento', 'tradito', 'adultera', 'adulterina', 'adulterio', 'extraconiugale'</i>
End of Relationship	<i>'stato lasciato', 'voleva lasciare', 'divorzi*', 'terminare la relazione', 'terminato la relazione', 'porre termine alla relazione', 'porre fine alla relazione', 'fine relazione', 'chiudere relazione', 'chiuso relazione', 'crisi coniugale', 'annullamento del matrimonio', 'crisi di coppia', 'coppia in crisi', 'crisi matrimoniale', 'crisi relazionale'</i>
Past Violence	<i>'violentata', 'violenti litigi', 'liti violente', 'violente liti', 'litigate violente', 'violente litigate', 'litigi violenti', 'violenza sessuale', 'violenza domestica', 'violenze domestiche', 'continue violenze', 'minacciata', 'perseguitata', 'perseguitate', 'aggressione sessuale', 'aggressioni sessuali', 'maltratta*', 'molesta*', 'abus*', 'stuprare', 'stupratore', 'stuprata', 'molestie', 'stalk*', 'sevizia*', 'palpegg*', 'molestia', 'stupro', 'mani addosso', 'picchiava', 'picchiata'</i>
Information on VAW Resources	<i>'antiviolenza', 'anti-violenza', 'anti-violenza', 'anti stalking', 'antistalking', 'anti-stalking', 'casa rifugio', 'case rifugio', 'telefono rosa', '1522'</i>
Femicide	<i>'femminicidi*'</i>

do not come forward until it is too late.” For this reason, he stressed, “the most important thing is to raise awareness among women: they must ask for help.” [VICTIM]’s murder is the second femicide in Milan in just a few days. On Friday, another woman, [VICTIM] was found dead in her home. Her killer was an occasional acquaintance, [PERPETRATOR], who murdered her with a bottle in a drug-fueled rage.

- *Victim-Centered Index* = 0.667: The father of the woman killed in Milan recounts that the aggressor had already tried to strangle her last August and that he had beaten her “until he broke her eardrum,” forcing her to be hospitalized. For this reason, on August 29th, the victim had filed a complaint (never withdrawn). On May 28, 2006, the woman was stabbed three times in the condominium [...] 134 Victims of femicide in Italy in 2013 alone. This is the highest figure in the last ten years. The percentage of family abuse or violence and by ex-partners actually reported is only 11%. Thousands of stalking complaints filed from August 1, 2013, to July 31, 2014. Since 2009, they have exceeded 51 thousand.
- *Victim-Centered Index* = 0.667: The husband confesses, already accused of rape [...] [PERPETRATOR] returned from Germany to commit the crime, where he had found work. They saw him drink sambuca at the bar and then head towards the town’s exit. A few minutes later, gunshots were heard coming from the area of the Todis supermarket. Screams. And a rush of people. The first to notice the two corpses were some supermarket employees. On the asphalt, in a pool of blood, among scattered shopping bags, were two women: mother and daughter of Albanian ethnicity, but of Kosovar origin [...] The carabinieri only needed to speak with some witnesses to direct the investigation towards the woman’s husband, [PERPETRATOR] [...] long at odds with his wife, who had recently been reported for sexual violence and was undergoing separation proceedings. A family situation irreparably compromised after the woman accused her husband of molesting their eldest daughter. The Avezzano court had imposed a restraining order on the man to stay away from his wife and daughters. It took the carabinieri two hours to track down and arrest the Kosovar, intercepted at a roadblock while trying to leave the town in a Fiat Punto, where a gun was found. A double femicide. [...] According to the first information gathered by the carabinieri, led by the provincial commander, the crime matured in a family context steeped in violence and abuse by the man. The farm laborer’s hand was armed, who only occasionally did odd jobs in the countryside and who had recently moved to Germany, with the intention of “punishing” the wife who had reported him. The Kosovar had returned a few days ago to complete the separation procedure. His wife [...] had instead stayed to live with their children in the nearby fraction. A terrible story, with few shadows left now. [PERPETRATOR] confessed during the night to the public prosecutor. He admitted to firing the shots. Although it is still unclear what prompted him to also aim the gun at his daughter. Everything, in any case, suggests a premeditated murder. The man waited at the bar, drinking sambuca. Then, seeing the two women leave the supermarket, he headed towards them, brandishing a weapon. He

fired repeatedly, without saying a word. In the insane belief of washing some kind of honor.

- *Perpetrator-Centered Index* = 0.5: He disposed of the evidence, throwing the knife into a storm drain and hiding his clothes behind some plants two kilometers from home. He created an alibi, wandering around the neighborhood from 11 AM to 3 PM on Sunday—doing the groceries, buying pastries, playing slot machines, and greeting as many acquaintances as possible. He vehemently denied being the murderer of his wife, [VICTIM] who had been brutally killed in their bedroom with 23 stab wounds. Then, at 4 AM, he broke down: “I was the one who killed her. I’m sorry, and I regret what I’ve done,” reads the arrest order. Jealousy, resentment, and violence—this was the constant pattern in [VICTIM] and [PERPETRATOR]’s life. [...] In the concierge lodge of the building where they had continued to live, their fights were incessant. In November, the police had intervened twice to defuse the situation, but the help of doctors from the local mental health center had produced no results. [PERPETRATOR] known for his hot temper and with prior offenses for resisting and insulting a public official, would beat [VICTIM] with a broomstick, accusing her of spending too much time on Facebook. In 1995, he had stabbed her in the back and then staged the same charade for the police as he did two days ago: “I came home, found the door open, and [VICTIM] was lying on the floor.” This time, however, one stab wound wasn’t enough. He attacked her with uncontrollable rage, “then showed remarkable composure in executing an effective cover-up plan,” said the homicide squad chief. [VICTIM] and [PERPETRATOR] had returned on Saturday from a month-long vacation in Pantelleria, and everything at home seemed calm. In his statement, [PERPETRATOR] claimed: “We woke up in a good mood, we even made love. We had breakfast, then [VICTIM] started insulting me.” [PERPETRATOR] remembered exactly what his wife had said—but not how he had reacted. And the 23 stab wounds on [VICTIM]’s body? “I didn’t even realize it. I remember I had just grabbed a knife in the kitchen because I wanted to peel an orange. The argument continued, and suddenly I found myself in the bedroom with the knife in my hand. After yet another insult, I lost my temper and started stabbing her repeatedly—I don’t know how many times.” Noticing he had a wound on his hand and his clothes were covered in blood, he stuffed everything into a supermarket bag and got rid of it. Then he focused on his alibi: “I went twice to the pastry shop to buy babà, withdrew 50 euros from an ATM, played the slot machines, and won 70 euros.” He even went grocery shopping—buying salad for his wife, who had already been dead for hours.
- *Perpetrator-Centered Index* = 0.667: The man feared that the child was not his. A positive pregnancy test triggered suspicion. “You betrayed me.” Bellagio (Como)—The idea that his partner had a lover obsessed him. Saturday night, faced with a positive pregnancy test, jealousy shook him and blinded him. It drove him mad. The thought that his partner might be expecting a child from another man transformed a calm [...] into a murderer. The murderer of his woman, strangled with an electric cable, and perhaps also of his child.

Autopsy will determine whether [VICTIM]—divorced and already mother of two children and grandmother of two grandchildren— was indeed expecting a child. That evening there was a crescendo of accusations, culminating in the truck driver’s mad act, who, in a fit of rage, grabbed an electric cable and tightened it around his partner’s neck. He strangled her from behind, not looking into her eyes as she died. The carabinieri from the Bellagio barracks immediately reached the house where the two lived together: in reality, [PERPETRATOR] only spent weekends there, as work in inner Switzerland (canton of Thurgau) occupied him on other days of the week. Questioned by the prosecutor, the truck driver admitted his responsibilities and said he killed out of jealousy revealing the news of the pregnancy test and the suspicion of betrayal. Tomorrow, the autopsy will probably be performed. A preliminary analysis confirmed death by suffocation caused by the cable tightened around the neck. A bruise on the woman’s face, dating back to a few days earlier, was also noted.

- *Perpetrator-Centered Index* = 0.667: They were separating. The victim was found by her children. The investigation had found that marriage had long been in crisis, she suffered abuse but had never reported it. The testimony. The little ones called an aunt screaming: “Hurry, Mom won’t move.” Smoking one cigarette after another, [PERPETRATOR] seems calm, alternating between silences and statements. Investigators are surprised by his attitude since only a few hours have passed since the tragedy that destroyed his family. [PERPETRATOR][...] was arrested last night for voluntary manslaughter and taken to prison. Also yesterday, in the evening near Albano, another boy witnessed the injuring of his mother, struck in the head with a statuette by her husband, then stopped by the carabinieri. Another marriage in crisis, like that of the teacher with the marshal, according to the woman’s family members, questioned by the police. “They argued often, for a while it seemed they had reconciled. They had started the separation process. She was a beautiful woman, and he was very jealous,” say the neighbors. Perhaps yesterday the woman gave the marshal an ultimatum to leave the house. But this time, [PERPETRATOR] in a fit of rage according to investigators, pounced on her, bludgeoning her with the hammer taken from the garage. Then he left and drove to the police station to turn himself in.

C.2 Validation

C.2.1 LLM Validation

Prompt Topic Classification: “You are an assistant for annotating documents. Your task is to read a newspaper article about a murder and identify and annotate when the article mentions one of the following topics. Please note: if words related to these topics appear in contexts that do not concern the crime itself, or if they are mentioned negatively — for example, to deny that the crime is linked to these topics — they must not be annotated as present. Please strictly follow what is stated in the article and do not make assumptions or inferences that are not supported by explicit mentions. The topics are:

- **Fit of rage:** if the motive for the crime is attributed to loss of control, a sudden outburst, madness, anger, etc.
- **Jealousy:** if the motive for the crime is attributed to jealousy, possessiveness, or a crime of passion
- **Economic Difficulties:** if the motive for the crime is attributed to financial problems, money, or debts
- **Infidelity:** if the motive for the crime is attributed to cheating, infidelity, adultery
- **Mental health problems:** if the motive for the crime is attributed to mental disorders, psychological imbalance, or psychiatric illnesses
- **End of the relationship:** if the motive for the crime is attributed to a breakup, end of the relationship, separation
- **Past violence:** if the article mentions that the crime provides information about the violent past of the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator, this can include sexual violence, but also stalking, beatings, or violent arguments
- **Information on resources to counter violence against women:** if the article mentions resources available to victims of violence against women, such as helplines, assistance centers, NGOs

If a topic is present according to the criteria above, return True; otherwise, return False.”

Table C.2: Confusion matrices for all categories

LLM	Fit of Rage		Jealousy		Econ. Diff.		Infidelity	
	T	F	T	F	T	F	T	F
Dict. T	141	53	92	17	43	19	19	4
Dict. F	185	617	73	814	120	814	45	928
LLM	Mental Health		End of Rel.		Past Violence		VAW Resources	
	T	F	T	F	T	F	T	F
Dict. T	67	11	18	2	121	41	26	1
Dict. F	116	802	240	736	92	742	59	910

Notes. Confusion matrices for all the dictionaries, comparing dictionaries and LLM-based classifications. Rows represent the dictionary-based classification predictions and columns represent the LLM-based classification predictions, where T means True (category detected) and F means False (category not detected).

Examples of False Positive articles: In the following, I report some *false positive* articles, i.e., articles that are annotated as 0 by the dictionary-based approach and as 1 by the LLM. I highlight the parts that prompted the LLM to tag the articles as part of the positive class. The articles have been modified to remove all information that could identify the people involved.

- **Fit of Rage** The alarm to 113 came at 10:45. On the sleepy morning in [...] desperate screams were heard. Two police cars arrived with four officers on board. They climbed over the protective wall using a ladder provided by a neighbor and headed toward the basement tavern where everything seems to have happened: “Open the door, open the door” the officers shouted several times when they realized that the killer was still inside the villa. From inside, no answer, no sound. Even the screams had stopped. But while the firefighters were working to break down the door to the basement level, [PERPETRATOR] suddenly came out from another entrance. He was wearing black combat boots, military trousers, a green T-shirt, a leather belt, and a gardener’s mask. In his hands, he held a large kitchen knife, still bloody, and he ran toward his car. He was nearly two meters tall, frightening. The firefighters moved aside, while the police fired several shots. The man, given emergency assistance by the 118 medical team, arrived already dead at the hospital. Behind him he had left the decapitated body of [VICTIM]. He was probably still attacking her. It is hard to say with certainty what exactly happened. Pending the investigation, the villa was seized by the prosecutors. The order was carried out by the police. [...]. The residents of the villa arrived at [...] last night shortly before 9 p.m., returning quickly from vacation in an SUV. The house had been lent to [PROSECUTOR] by his colleague in exchange for doing some small maintenance jobs. But the killer’s real passion was knives, the same ones that had alarmed [VICTIM] and that ultimately cost her her life on a quiet Sunday morning in August.
- **Fit of Rage:** Three shots with his service pistol: two to kill his wife, one to take his own life. A terrible family tragedy unfolded yesterday afternoon in [...], in front of their two children, aged six and seven. It was the children who called the neighbors and raised the alarm. Everything happened in a matter of minutes, shortly after 4 p.m., following an argument (“increasingly frequent in recent weeks,” neighbors told investigators) within the walls of their home. [PERPETRATOR], pulled out his service pistol and fired at his wife [VICTIM]. She tried to defend herself: the first bullet hit her hand, the second, the fatal one, severed her femoral artery. She bled to death in the hallway of their home, by the time he was already dead. Moments after shooting her, he put the pistol to his temple and shot himself in the living room. The gunshots were also heard by neighbors in the surrounding apartment buildings. The two children ran screaming to some of the neighbors, who then helped investigators reconstruct the family situation. [...] “They no longer got along, they wanted to separate,” a neighbor recounted. “This afternoon our children were doing homework together at our house, and she was there too. Then they went back home, and in just a few minutes, everything went to hell.”

- **Past Violence:** Thirty-one days. That is how long [PERPETRATOR] remained locked inside a cell—from the early hours of Sunday until yesterday, shortly before 2 p.m., when [PERPETRATOR], accompanied by his lawyers, walked out through the main gate of the detention facility. He was released at the request of the very same public prosecutor, who had had him jailed on charges of murdering his elderly mother [VICTIM]. “There are no longer grounds for keeping him in custody,” and so [PERPETRATOR] left the facility to return to his home, where, for the time being, he must remain under house arrest—at least until the Court of Cassation rules on the appeal filed by his lawyers. Outside the prison, [PERPETRATOR] made no statements. With a long beard and a worn, exhausted face, he walked straight ahead. “This ruling,” the lawyers explained, “confirms what we have been arguing for days: that there are no grounds for pre-trial detention.” They also confirmed that they had already filed an appeal with the Supreme Court against the Appeals Court’s decision to extend custody by sixty days. The prosecutor’s request for his release came after a new inspection, on Tuesday the 17th, of the second-floor apartment at [...]. Officers from the mobile squad and forensic experts from Rome searched again for possible biological traces. During the inspection, a computer [PERPETRATOR] had given to his sister and some documents were seized. It is the same apartment where, according to the prosecutor, the murder of [VICTIM] took place at the climax of a quarrel with her son [PERPETRATOR]. According to the accusation, a violent argument escalated to the point where the son allegedly struck his mother, causing her to fall and die. He has always denied this. He denies having touched her and denies being responsible for her death. He admits the argument and says that when he found her on the floor, motionless, he panicked and thought of staging a robbery. But why such a fierce quarrel? Money, it seems—after yet another request for money from his mother, according to the prosecution. It is a case whose true contours still need to be established. Crucial to this will be what emerges from the forensic medical examination of the cause of death, as early indications suggest that it may not have been a violent death.

C.2.2 Indexes

Table C.3: Pairs of Articles about the Same Crime

High Victim-Centered Index	High Perpetrator-Centered Index
Three femicides occurred in a short span of time in Italy, with one in Tuscany and two in Lombardy. In Tuscany, [PERPETRATOR] called the emergency services to confess he killed his 46-year-old girlfriend near Monterotondo Marittimo. [...] In Lombardy, a married couple of Albanian origin was discovered dead in an apparent murder-suicide in Calino. Additionally, in Vigevano, a 59-year-old man killed his 39-year-old girlfriend before surrendering to the police the next day. These incidents come amidst a growing concern over gender-based violence in Italy, illustrated by other recent cases [...]	A man identified as Nicola Stefanini, 48, killed his partner, [PERPETRATOR], 46 [...] Stefanini immediately called emergency services to confess the crime and was found by the police next to the victim's body [...] The couple had a turbulent relationship marked by arguments and Stefanini's irascible character. The motive behind the murder remains unclear, and Stefanini has been arrested for voluntary homicide. The incident is part of a series of femicides in Italy, with other cases reported in Brescia and Vigevano involving intimate partner violence leading to tragic outcomes. [...] In a separate incident in Cazzago San Martino, Calino (Brescia), a couple of Albanian origin were found dead in an apparent murder-suicide. The husband allegedly strangled his wife before taking his own life, leaving behind a letter explaining his actions driven by jealousy.[...]
There was another tragic femicide of [VICTIM] in Iglesias, Italy, at the hands of her husband, [PERPETRATOR], who did not accept her request for separation. Despite having previously reported him to the authorities, [VICTIM] was fatally stabbed during a confrontation after picking up her children from her husband. The incident highlights the persistent issue of gender-based violence and femicide in Italy, as evidenced by a recent ruling against the Italian state by the European Court of Human Rights for not adequately responding to a similar case in the past. The lack of support for victims of domestic violence, including the absence of anti-violence centers in Sardinia, further exacerbates the situation and calls for more resources and awareness to combat this ongoing problem.	In Iglesias, Italy, a 46-year-old man named [PERPETRATOR] killed his 32-year-old wife, [VICTIM], after an argument that ended on the staircase of their two-story house in the city outskirts. The couple, who were parents to three children, were in the midst of a tense separation which was due to be finalized with a divorce in a few days. The trigger for the violence is believed to have been the impending separation, causing [PERPETRATOR] to fatally stab and throw his wife down the stairs where she was later found by emergency services covered in blood. [...]

Notes. Pairs of articles about the same crime. The articles in the left column have a victim-centered index higher than 0.6, while those in the right column have a perpetrator-centered index higher than 0.6. Highlighted are the parts captured by the highest-scoring index.

D A Model of Identity-Motivated Journalists

I model the decision of journalist j about narrative $s_j \in \{s^{AN}, s^{BN}\}$ they will use in their articles,⁵⁸ accounting for readers i 's utility from reading articles with narratives s_j . Journalists and readers can belong to groups B or A — $j, i \in \{A, B\}$ —with size ρ and $1 - \rho$, respectively.

Readers decide whether to consume news with narrative s_j by maximizing the following utility function

$$U_i(s_j) = -|s_j - \hat{s}_i| + \phi_i(s_j) \quad (7)$$

When making their news consumption choice, they consider the direct cost of reading an article with a narrative that is different from their preferred one, $\hat{s}_i$. This direct effect can be thought of as the benefit they get from consuming news they find engaging or align with their values. The preferred narrative $\hat{s}_i$ can equal either s^{AN} or s^{BN} and is stochastic, with a probability distribution that can differ across reader groups. Formally:

$$P(\hat{s}_i = s^{AN} \mid i = A) = \alpha_A \quad \text{and} \quad P(\hat{s}_i = s^{AN} \mid i = B) = \alpha_B, \quad \alpha_A, \alpha_B \in (0, 1) \quad (8)$$

where I assume that $\alpha_A > 0.5 > \alpha_B$.

Moreover, they also consider the indirect cost or benefit of reading an article with narrative s_j , $\phi_i(s_j)$. This indirect effect on their utility can be thought of as *material* or psychological effect of consuming news with a specific narrative, which depends on their identity as in Akerlof and Kranton (2000). For instance, in articles about violence against women, where gender is a salient identity dimension, if a woman who is in a violent relationship reads an article that is more victim-centred or reports information on resources, she might be more willing to seek help (Daponte et al., 1999; Bettinger et al., 2012) or become less accepting of VAW (Banerjee et al., 2019), and this might ultimately benefit her. On the contrary, if she reads an article that is more perpetrator-centred, she might be less likely to seek help, which will ultimately harm her. Similarly, men may benefit from perpetrator-centred writing as it diminishes men's responsibility in perpetrating VAW (Smith and Frieze, 2003). The structure of this additional component depends on the group to which the readers belong. In particular, I assume that if $i = B$, then they benefit from $s_j = s^{BN}$ and incur a cost if $s_j = s^{AN}$, with the opposite being true if $i = A$. Formally,

$$\phi_B(s_j) = \begin{cases} \tau & \text{if } s_j = s^{BN} \\ -\tau & \text{if } s_j = s^{AN} \end{cases} \quad \phi_A(s_j) = \begin{cases} -\tau & \text{if } s_j = s^{BN} \\ \tau & \text{if } s_j = s^{AN} \end{cases} \quad (9)$$

where $\tau > 0$ is a constant parameter, such that $\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$. This latter assumption implies that the magnitude of the indirect effect is large enough to compensate for the loss from reading an article with a narrative different from the readers' preferred one.⁵⁹ Appendix Section D.1 derives

⁵⁸I assume without loss of generality that $s^{AN} > s^{BN}$.

⁵⁹See Appendix D.2 for the derivation of the threshold for τ .

all results under the alternative case $\tau < \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, showing that the main propositions also hold in this scenario.

I now turn to the journalists' maximization problem. Knowing readers' utility function, $U_i(s_j)$, they decide on the narratives to use by maximizing the following

$$W_j(s_j) = \iota_j \left[\rho P(U_B(s_j) \geq U_B(s_{-j})) + (1 - \rho) P(U_A(s_j) \geq U_A(s_{-j})) \right] + (1 - \iota_j) \mathbb{E}[U_{i=j}(s_j)] \quad (10)$$

As anticipated, journalists account for two main factors when choosing narratives. First, they want to maximize the *monetary returns* from writing in terms of engagement, namely, to maximize the share of readers that, if they implement $s_j = s_j^*$, prefer s_j^* to s_{-j} , as in models of probabilistic voting (Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987). Namely, this part captures the returns from writing an article using narratives that readers prefer to alternative ones. Second, journalists also altruistically care about the expected utility of readers from their in-group, $\mathbb{E}[U_{i=j}(s_j)]$ (Andreoni and Miller, 2002; Turner et al., 1979). For instance, female journalists may care about the well-being of their female readers who face issues with violent partners and, thus, have an interest in including information on resources to counter VAW in their articles. Finally, these two components enter journalists' utility functions with different weights determined by $\iota_j \in [0, 1]$, and these weights can differ across journalist groups.

Decision Rule for Narrative Choice. Journalists choose narrative s^{BN} over s^{AN} if their utility from s^{BN} is larger than their utility from s^{AN} — $W_j(s^{BN}) \geq W_j(s^{AN})$. Namely, they follow the decision rule

$$\iota_j \left[2 \left(\rho P(U_B(s^{BN}) \geq U_B(s^{AN})) + (1 - \rho) P(U_A(s^{BN}) \geq U_A(s^{AN})) \right) - 1 \right] + (1 - \iota_j) \left[\mathbb{E}[U_{i=j}(s^{BN})] - \mathbb{E}[U_{i=j}(s^{AN})] \right] \geq 0$$

This yields the two different decision rules for groups A and B:

$$DR_j(s^{BN}) = \begin{cases} \iota_A(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_A)[(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau] \geq 0 & \text{if } j = A \\ \iota_B(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_B)[(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau] \geq 0 & \text{if } j = B \end{cases} \quad (11)$$

Next, I move to the characterization of the narratives chosen by journalists. I start by characterizing the scenario where journalists from both groups face the same decision rule, namely, when

$$\iota_A(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_A)[(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau] = \iota_B(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_B)[(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau]$$

This equality leads to the following proposition.

Proposition 1. Assuming a positive and large enough indirect effect of narratives ($\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$), journalists

from both groups face the same decision rule if they only care about monetary returns ($\iota_A = \iota_B = 1$). Additionally, the optimal narrative is $s_B^* = s_A^* = s^{BN}$ if $\rho \geq 0.5$, and vice-versa.

Therefore, in the case of purely readership-maximizing journalists, we should observe the same narrative in articles written by journalists from different groups. On the contrary, if we observe journalists from different groups choosing different narratives, then at least one group of journalists is *identity-motivated*, namely, journalists from that group also care about maximizing the utility of their in-group— $\iota_A < 1$ or $\iota_B < 1$. Additionally, the narrative chosen depends on the type of readers of the newspaper.

As a next step, I characterize the equilibrium allocation of writing styles in which journalists pick the writing practice that has a positive indirect effect on their in-group— $\phi_{i=j}(s_j) = \tau$.

Proposition 2. Assume that at least one group of journalists is identity-motivated, $\iota_A < 1$ or $\iota_B < 1$. In this scenario, the optimal combination of narratives is $(s_A^*, s_B^*) = (s^{AN}, s^{BN})$ if and only if one of the following parameter combinations realizes:

- $\rho \leq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{2(1 - \alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{1 - 2\rho} \geq \frac{\iota_B}{1 - \iota_B}$
- $\rho \geq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{2\alpha_A(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{2\rho - 1} \geq \frac{\iota_A}{1 - \iota_A}$

Proof. See Appendix D.2. □

In other words, the conditions of Proposition 2 imply that journalists choose the narrative that benefits their in-group if their in-group represents the majority of the population of readers. Alternatively, they choose that narrative if either they increasingly care about maximizing the utility of their in-group— $\iota_{A,B}$ low enough—or if the probability of the in-group utility-maximizing narrative is also more likely to be their group's preferred one. Namely, a higher α_A strengthens the altruistic incentive for A journalists to use AN narratives, while a lower α_B strengthens the altruistic incentive for B journalists to use BN narratives. Reader preference heterogeneity and identity motives are therefore complements in sustaining the in-group-maximizing allocation.

D.1 Results under $\tau < \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$

This section derives the decision rules and propositions for the case $\tau < \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, in which the indirect welfare effect is not large enough to dominate taste. In this case some readers prefer a style that is welfare-reducing for their group, and the group-specific preference parameters α_A and α_B enter both the monetary-return and the altruistic components of the journalist's objective.

When $\tau < \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, a group-B reader with $\hat{s}_B = s^{AN}$ (probability α_B) prefers s^{AN} even though it harms them, because the taste gain outweighs the welfare loss. Hence,

$$P(U_B(s^{BN}) \geq U_B(s^{AN})) = 1 - \alpha_B,$$

$$P(U_A(s^{BN}) \geq U_A(s^{AN})) = 1 - \alpha_A.$$

Therefore, the decision rule becomes

$$DR_j(s^{BN}) = \begin{cases} \iota_A [2\rho(1 - \alpha_B) + 2(1 - \rho)(1 - \alpha_A) - 1] + (1 - \iota_A) [(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau] \geq 0 & \text{if } j = A \\ \iota_B [2\rho(1 - \alpha_B) + 2(1 - \rho)(1 - \alpha_A) - 1] + (1 - \iota_B) [(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau] \geq 0 & \text{if } j = B \end{cases} \quad (12)$$

As in the main decision rule 11, the monetary-return is the same for both journalist groups, mirroring the fact that they share the same readership data, but in this case, it depends both on the newspaper share of readers of each group and on their probability of the preferred narratives, α_A and α_B

$$M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho) \equiv 2\rho(1 - \alpha_B) + 2(1 - \rho)(1 - \alpha_A) - 1.$$

Proposition 1.2. Assuming $\tau < \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, journalists from both groups face the same decision rule if they only care about monetary returns ($\iota_A = \iota_B = 1$). The optimal narrative is $s_A^* = s_B^* = s^{BN}$ if

$$\rho(1 - \alpha_B) + (1 - \rho)(1 - \alpha_A) \geq \frac{1}{2},$$

i.e., $\rho \geq \frac{\frac{1}{2} - (1 - \alpha_A)}{\alpha_A - \alpha_B} = \frac{2\alpha_A - 1}{2(\alpha_A - \alpha_B)}$, and $s_A^* = s_B^* = s^{AN}$ otherwise.

In this scenario, the optimal allocation now depends also on the group-specific probability for readers' preferred narrative, α_A and α_B . In particular, a wider preference gap $\alpha_A - \alpha_B$ makes the threshold smaller, so a less male-skewed readership suffices for s^{BN} to be profit-maximizing. Importantly, since the threshold is the same for both journalist types within the same newsroom, within-newsroom divergence still requires identity motives.

Proposition 2.2. Assume that at least one group of journalists is identity-motivated, $\iota_A < 1$ or $\iota_B < 1$. The optimal combination of narratives is $(s_A^*, s_B^*) = (s^{AN}, s^{BN})$ if and only if one of the following parameter combinations realizes:

- $M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho) \leq 0$ and $\frac{(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau}{-M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho)} \geq \frac{\iota_B}{1 - \iota_B},$
- $M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho) \geq 0$ and $\frac{(2\alpha_A - 1)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau}{M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho)} \geq \frac{\iota_A}{1 - \iota_A}.$

Compared with Proposition 2, the conditions under low τ are more complex because α_A and α_B now appear in both the monetary-return term M and the altruistic terms. The qualitative message is however similar: when one narrative is more profitable than the other, the less profitable narrative

is chosen if its benefits from the altruistic part of the decision rule are high enough to offset the low profitability, or if the journalist increasingly cares about the utility of their group.

D.2 Additional Derivations

Derivation of Threshold for τ : To compute the threshold value for the parameter τ , I focus on the intermediate case in which the preferred narrative of readers does not coincide with the one that benefits their group. For instance, I assume that $\hat{s}_B = s^{AN}$. In this scenario, readers from group B prefer $s_j = s^{AN}$ if the following expression is satisfied:

$$\begin{aligned} U_B(s^{AN}) &\geq U_B(s^{BN}) \\ -|s^{AN} - \hat{s}_B| - \tau &\geq -|s^{BN} - \hat{s}_B| + \tau \\ -\tau &\geq s^{BN} - s^{AN} + \tau \\ \tau &\leq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2} \end{aligned}$$

Therefore, if readers' preferred narrative is the same as the one harming their group, then they would get a higher utility under this narrative with respect to the alternative that benefits them if and only if the magnitude of the benefit/cost is small enough to be compensated by the taste-based gain. On the contrary, if the magnitude of the benefit/cost is large— $\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$ —the utility-maximizing narrative is always the one with a positive indirect effect on readers.

Proof of Proposition 2: I start by focusing on the scenarios in which journalist A chooses s^{AN} as preferred practice, namely when

$$\iota_A(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_A) \left[(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau \right] \leq 0$$

Note that since $\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, $\left[(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau \right] \leq -2\alpha_A(s^{AN} - s^{BN})$, which is ≤ 0 .

Therefore, one condition for the LHS of the decision rule to be negative is $\rho \leq 0.5$. Alternatively, if $\rho > 0.5$ then it must be that

$$\iota_A(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_A) \left[(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau \right] \leq \iota_A(2\rho - 1) - (1 - \iota_A) 2\alpha_A(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) \leq 0$$

Given that $\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, it is sufficient to show that the second inequality holds, which is true if $\frac{\iota_A}{1 - \iota_A} \leq \frac{2\alpha_A(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{2\rho - 1}$.

Moving to the choice of journalists from group B , they choose s^{BN} as preferred practice if

$$\iota_B(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_B) \left[(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau \right] \geq 0$$

Since $\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$, $\left[(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau \right] \geq 2(1 - \alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN})$, which is always ≥ 0 . Therefore, one condition for $s_B^* = s^{BN}$ is $\rho \geq 0.5$. Alternatively, if $\rho \leq 0.5$ then it must be that

$$\iota_B(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_B) \left[(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau \right] \geq \iota_B(2\rho - 1) + (1 - \iota_B) 2(1 - \alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) \geq 0$$

which is true if $\frac{2(1 - \alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{1 - 2\rho} \geq \frac{\iota_B}{1 - \iota_B}$.

Finally, since the two conditions for $s_A^* = s^{AN}$ and $s_B^* = s^{BN}$ involving ρ are mutually exclusive, we have $(s_A^*, s_B^*) = (s^{AN}, s^{BN})$ with one of the following combinations of parameters:

- $\rho \leq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{2(1 - \alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{1 - 2\rho} \geq \frac{\iota_B}{1 - \iota_B}$
- $\rho \geq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{2\alpha_A(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{2\rho - 1} \geq \frac{\iota_A}{1 - \iota_A}$

□

Proof of Proposition 2.2: In the scenario where journalist A chooses s^{AN} the decision rule becomes

$$\iota_A M + (1 - \iota_A) \left[(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau \right] \leq 0.$$

Since $\tau < \frac{s^{AN} - s^{BN}}{2}$ and $\alpha_A > 0.5$, $(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) - 2\tau$ is always negative. Therefore, one condition for the LHS to be negative is $M \leq 0$, which is equivalent to $\rho \leq \frac{\frac{1}{2} - (1 - \alpha_A)}{\alpha_A - \alpha_B} = \frac{2\alpha_A - 1}{2(\alpha_A - \alpha_B)}$.

Alternatively, if $M \geq 0$, which arises when ρ is high enough to make narrative BN profit-maximizing, it must be that the following inequality is satisfied for journalist A to choose AN

$$\frac{(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau}{M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho)} \geq \frac{\iota_A}{1 - \iota_A}$$

Moving to the choice of journalist B , they choose s^{BN} as preferred practice if

$$\iota_B M + (1 - \iota_B) \left[(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau \right] \geq 0.$$

Since $\tau > 0$ and $\alpha_B < 0.5$, the altruistic term $(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau$ is always positive. Therefore, journalist B always chooses $s_j = s^{BN}$ if BN is profit-maximizing, namely $M > 0$.

When $M \leq 0$, meaning when narrative AN is profit-maximizing, then, the following condition

must be satisfied for journalist B to still prefer BN

$$\frac{(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau}{-M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho)} \geq \frac{\iota_B}{1 - \iota_B}$$

Finally, since the two conditions for $s_A^* = s^{AN}$ and $s_B^* = s^{BN}$ involving ρ are mutually exclusive, we have $(s_A^*, s_B^*) = (s^{AN}, s^{BN})$ with one of the following combinations of parameters:

- ≤ 0 and $\frac{(1 - 2\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau}{-M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho)} \geq \frac{\iota_B}{1 - \iota_B}$
- $\geq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{(1 - 2\alpha_A)(s^{AN} - s^{BN}) + 2\tau}{M(\alpha_A, \alpha_B, \rho)} \geq \frac{\iota_A}{1 - \iota_A}$

□

E Additional Information on Data and Experiment

E.1 Additional Information on Data Construction

To compile the dataset about murders with male victims, I leverage `gpt-4o-mini` through the OpenAI API. In particular, I loop through all the articles and extract information using the following system prompt:

“You are an honest classifier. You receive an Italian news excerpt in the user prompt. You should classify if the news is related to a murder involving real people or not. You should classify the news positively if it is explicitly about the murder of a real person taking place in Italy as the main topic. You should classify negatively if the text generally mentions murders, e.g., in political discussions, or if it mentions other crimes, e.g., attempted murder, killing of animals, or murders that occur in fictional contexts, e.g., movies. If it is a murder news, you should also extract the name of the perpetrator and the victim if it is mentioned and set the respective field to `None` otherwise. Moreover, you should classify whether the victim is a woman or a man when possible. You should classify it positively if the victim is female. You should classify it negatively if the victim is a man. If you don’t have this information, just return `None`. If the city or region where the murder occurred is explicitly mentioned, you should also extract it and set the respective field to `None` otherwise. If the murder date is explicitly mentioned, you should extract it or set the respective field to `None` otherwise. Suppose the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator is mentioned. In that case, you should extract it and fill the respective field with one of the following values: `partner`, `ex-partner` (if the perpetrator is the partner or ex-partner of the murder victim), `relative`, `ex-relative` (if the perpetrator is the relative or ex-relative of the murder victim), `acquaintance`. If this is not mentioned, set the field to `None`. Please return for each user prompt an output in the custom `Newsclassification` format, which is inherited from `Pydantic`.”

This allows me to classify the articles as being about a real murder happening in Italy, and it having a male victim. Additionally, if the article is classified as a real murder, I ask the model to extract the names of the victim and perpetrator, the city where the murder occurred, and the date. I also ask it to extract the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator, suggesting the values to input. Finally, I specify the format of the output, mentioning that it should follow a JSON schema as defined by `Pydantic`. This way, I ensure that the output of the model always has the same structure, with each field containing the corresponding information.

E.2 Experimental Design

E.2.1 Treatments

Figure E.1: Control: News Articles for Crime A

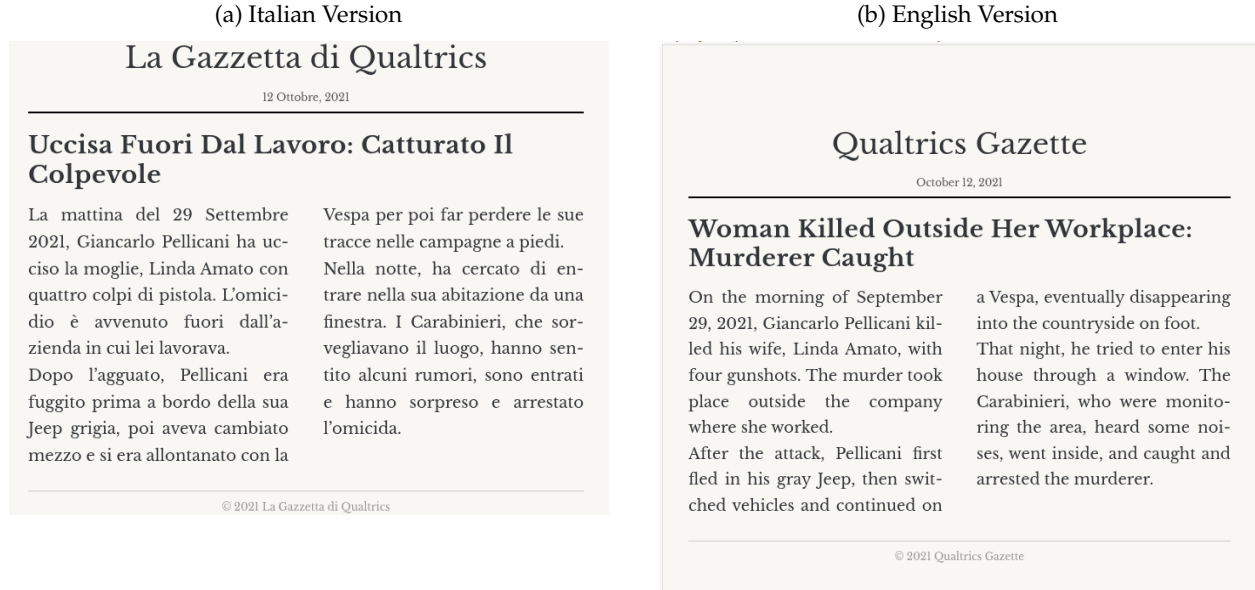


Figure E.2: Control: News Articles for Crime B

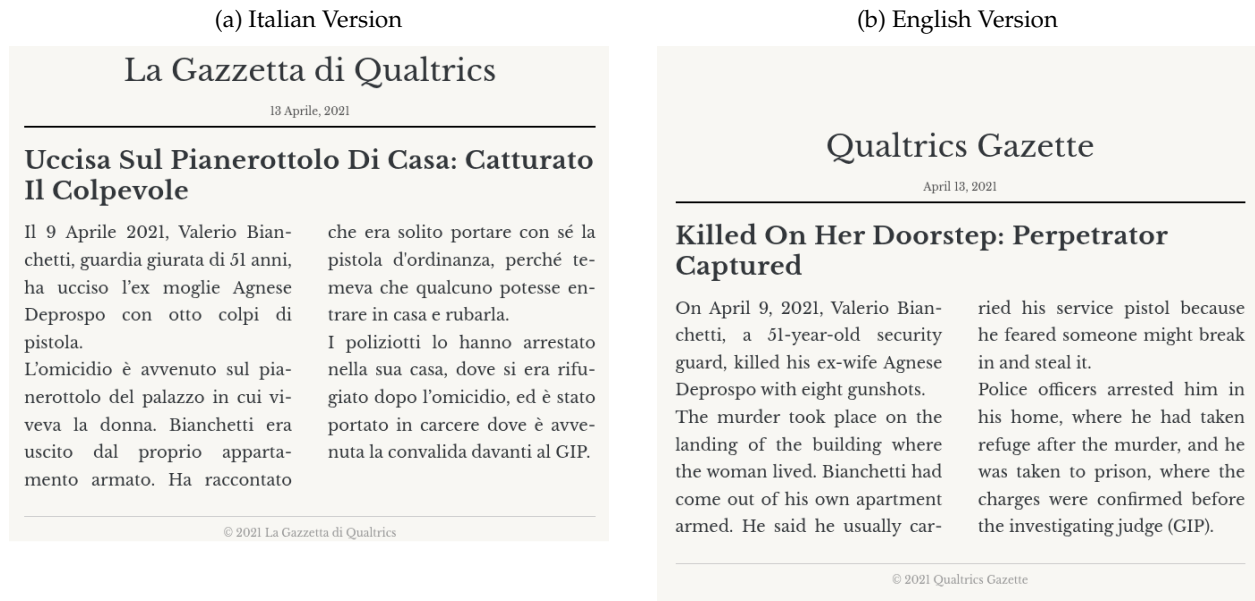


Figure E.3: Perpetrator-Centered: News Articles for Crime A

(a) Italian Version

La Gazzetta di Qualtrics
12 Ottobre, 2021

Uccisa Fuori Dal Lavoro: Catturato Il Colpevole

La mattina del 29 Settembre 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani, acciecat dalla rabbia, ha ucciso la moglie, Linda Amato con quattro colpi di pistola. L'omicidio è avvenuto fuori dall'azienda in cui lei lavorava.

Dopo l'agguato, Pellicani era fuggito prima a bordo della sua Jeep grigia, poi aveva cambiato mezzo e si era allontanato con la Vespa per poi far perdere le sue tracce nelle campagne a piedi. Nella notte, ha cercato di entrare nella sua abitazione da una

finestra. I Carabinieri, che sorvegliavano il luogo, hanno sentito alcuni rumori, sono entrati e hanno sorpreso e arrestato l'omicida.

Giancarlo Pellicani, negli ultimi tempi, era diventato particolarmente geloso, temendo le nuove frequentazioni della moglie potessero compromettere la loro relazione. Ha ammesso di aver premuto il grilletto perché non riusciva ad accettare di vederla allontanarsi.

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(b) English Version

Qualtrics Gazette
October 12, 2021

Woman Killed Outside Her Workplace: Murderer Caught

On the morning of September 29, 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani, blinded by rage, killed his wife, Linda Amato, with four gunshots. The murder took place outside the company where she worked.

After the attack, Pellicani first fled in his gray Jeep, then switched vehicles and continued on a Vespa, eventually disappearing into the countryside on foot.

That night, he tried to enter his house through a window. The Carabinieri, who were monitoring the area, heard some noises, went inside, and caught and arrested the murderer.

Giancarlo Pellicani had become particularly jealous, fearing that his wife's new acquaintances might jeopardize their relationship. He admitted to pulling the trigger because he couldn't bear to see her walk away.

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Figure E.4: Perpetrator-Centered: News Articles for Crime B

(a) Italian Version

La Gazzetta di Qualtrics
13 Aprile, 2021

Uccisa Sul Pianerottolo Di Casa: Catturato Il Colpevole

Il 9 Aprile 2021, Valerio Bianchetti, guardia giurata di 51 anni, ha ucciso l'ex moglie Agnese Deprosio con otto colpi di pistola, acciecat dalla gelosia.

L'omicidio è avvenuto sul pianerottolo del palazzo in cui viveva la donna. Bianchetti era uscito dal proprio appartamento armato. Ha raccontato che era solito portare con sé la pistola d'ordinanza, perché temeva che qualcuno potesse entrare in casa e rubarla.

I poliziotti lo hanno arrestato nella sua casa, dove si era rifugiato dopo l'omicidio, ed è stato portato in carcere dove è avvenuta la convalida davanti al GIP.

Nelle settimane precedenti, Valerio Bianchetti aveva iniziato a vedere l'ex moglie con un altro uomo e racconta in lacrime di essersi ingelosito in quanto sperava di convincerla a tornare sui propri passi. Sarebbero state la gelosia e l'idea di perderla a scatenare la furia omicida.

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(b) English Version

Qualtrics Gazette
April 13, 2021

Killed On Her Doorstep: Perpetrator Captured

On April 9, 2021, Valerio Bianchetti, a 51-year-old security guard, killed his ex-wife Agnese Deprosio with eight gunshots, blinded by rage.

The murder took place on the landing of the building where the woman lived. Bianchetti had come out of his own apartment armed. He said he usually carried his service pistol because he feared someone might break in and steal it.

Police officers arrested him in his home, where he had taken

refuge after the murder, and he was taken to prison, where the charges were confirmed before the investigating judge (GIP).

In the weeks prior, Valerio Bianchetti had begun seeing his ex-wife with another man, and tearfully recounted that he had become jealous because he had hoped to persuade her to come back to him. It was allegedly jealousy and the fear of losing her that triggered his murderous rage.

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Figure E.5: Episodic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime A—Version 1

(a) Italian Version

La Gazzetta di Qualtrics

12 Ottobre, 2021

Uccisa Fuori Dal Lavoro: Catturato Il Colpevole

La mattina del 29 Settembre 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani ha ucciso la moglie, Linda Amato con quattro colpi di pistola. L'omicidio è avvenuto fuori dall'azienda in cui lei lavorava. Dopo l'agguato, Pellicani era fuggito prima a bordo della sua Jeep grigia, poi aveva cambiato mezzo e si era allontanato con la Vespa per poi far perdere le sue tracce nelle campagne a piedi. Nella notte, ha cercato di entrare nella sua abitazione da una

finestra. I Carabinieri, che sorvegliavano il luogo, hanno sentito alcuni rumori, sono entrati e hanno sorpreso e arrestato l'omicida. Linda Amato era già andata dai carabinieri per raccontare che il marito le aveva messo le mani addosso ma non erano risultati gli elementi necessari per far scattare il Codice rosso. Temendo per la sua incolumità la donna si era quindi trasferita da un'amica.

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(b) English Version

Qualtrics Gazette

October 12, 2021

Woman Killed Outside Her Workplace: Murderer Caught

On the morning of September 29, 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani killed his wife, Linda Amato, with four gunshots. The murder took place outside the company where she worked. After the attack, Pellicani first fled in his gray Jeep, then switched vehicles and continued on a Vespa, eventually disappearing into the countryside on foot. That night, he tried to enter his house through a window. The

Carabinieri, who were monitoring the area, heard some noises, went inside, and caught and arrested the murderer. Linda Amato had already gone to the Carabinieri to report that her husband had laid hands on her, but there was not enough evidence to trigger the Codice Rosso. Fearing for her safety, the woman had therefore moved in with a friend.

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Figure E.6: Episodic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime A—Version 2

(a) Italian Version

La Gazzetta di Qualtrics

12 Ottobre, 2021

Uccisa Fuori Dal Lavoro: Catturato Il Colpevole

La mattina del 29 Settembre 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani ha ucciso la moglie, Linda Amato con quattro colpi di pistola. L'omicidio è avvenuto fuori dall'azienda in cui lei lavorava. Dopo l'agguato, Pellicani era fuggito prima a bordo della sua Jeep grigia, poi aveva cambiato mezzo e si era allontanato con la Vespa per poi far perdere le sue tracce nelle campagne a piedi. Nella notte, ha cercato di entrare nella sua abitazione da una

finestra. I Carabinieri, che sorvegliavano il luogo, hanno sentito alcuni rumori, sono entrati e hanno sorpreso e arrestato l'omicida. Linda Amato aveva confidato alle amiche che l'uomo la picchiava spesso. Era già andata dai carabinieri per raccontare che il marito le aveva messo le mani addosso e temendo per la sua incolumità, la donna si era quindi trasferita da un'amica.

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(b) English Version

Qualtrics Gazette

October 12, 2021

Woman Killed Outside Her Workplace: Murderer Caught

On the morning of September 29, 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani killed his wife, Linda Amato, with four gunshots. The murder took place outside the company where she worked. After the attack, Pellicani first fled in his gray Jeep, then switched vehicles and continued on a Vespa, eventually disappearing into the countryside on foot. That night, he tried to enter his house through a window. The

Carabinieri, who were monitoring the area, heard some noises, went inside, and caught and arrested the murderer. Friends reported that the woman had previously suffered abuse from her husband and that violent arguments between the two were frequent. Linda Amato had confided that she was afraid and feared for her safety if she remained in that house.

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Figure E.7: Episodic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime A—Version 3



Figure E.8: Episodic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime B—Version 1

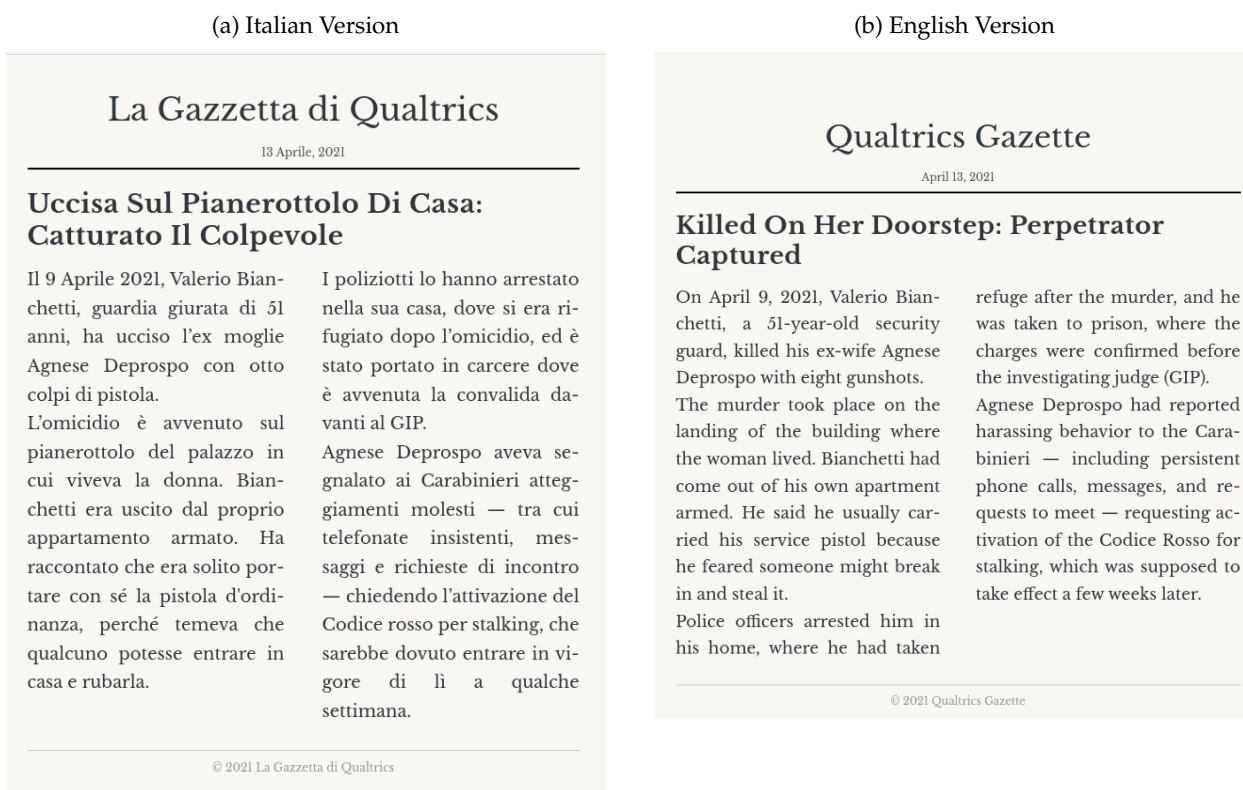


Figure E.9: Episodic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime B—Version 2

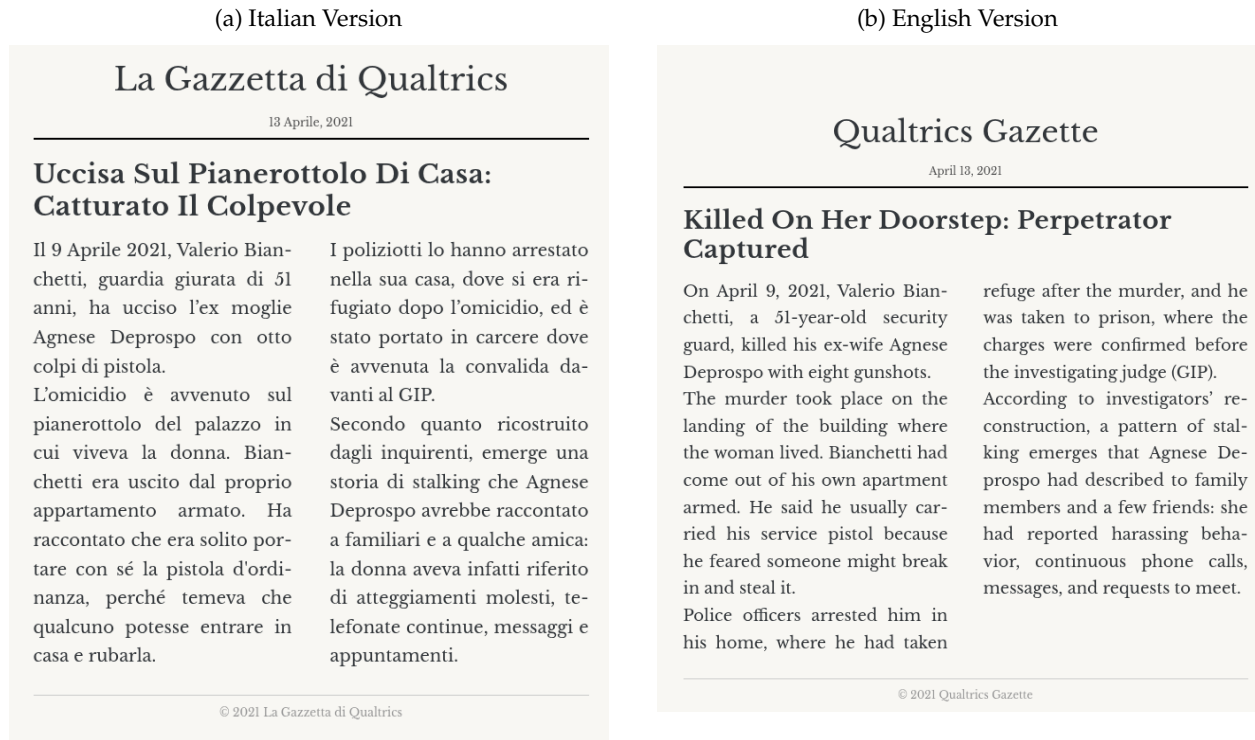


Figure E.10: Thematic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime A

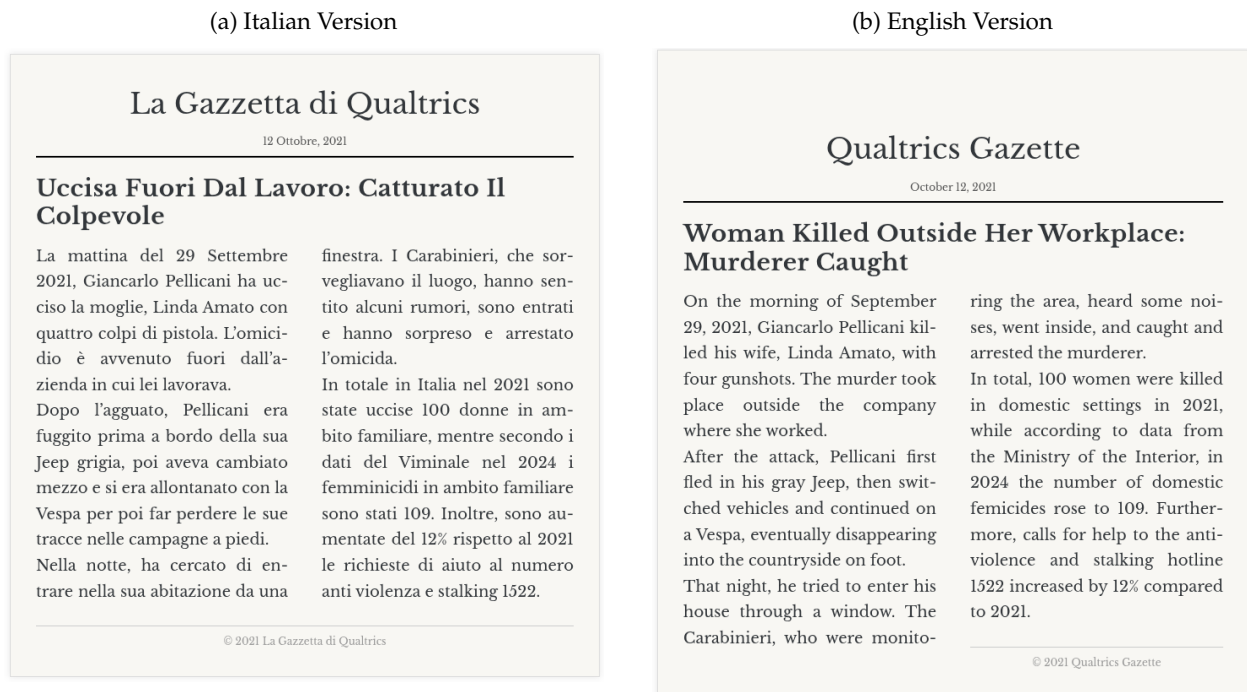


Figure E.11: Thematic Victim-Centered: News Articles for Crime B

(a) Italian Version

La Gazzetta di Qualtrics

13 Aprile, 2021

Uccisa Sul Pianerottolo Di Casa: Catturato Il Colpevole

Il 9 Aprile 2021, Valerio Bianchetti, guardia giurata di 51 anni, ha ucciso l'ex moglie Agnese Deproso con otto colpi di pistola. Il femminicidio è avvenuto sul pianerottolo del palazzo in cui viveva la donna. Bianchetti era uscito dal proprio appartamento armato. Ha raccontato che era solito portare con sé la pistola d'ordinanza, perché temeva che qualcuno potesse entrare in casa e rubarla.

I poliziotti lo hanno arrestato nella sua casa, dove si era rifugiato dopo l'omicidio, ed è stato portato in carcere dove è avvenuta la convalida davanti al GIP.

In totale in Italia nel 2021 sono state uccise 100 donne in ambito familiare, mentre secondo i dati del Viminale nel 2024 i femminicidi in ambito familiare sono stati 109. Inoltre, sono aumentate del 12% rispetto al 2021 le richieste di aiuto al numero anti violenza e stalking 1522.

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(b) English Version

Qualtrics Gazette

April 13, 2021

Killed On Her Doorstep: Perpetrator Captured

On April 9, 2021, Valerio Bianchetti, a 51-year-old security guard, killed his ex-wife Agnese Deproso with eight gunshots. The murder took place on the landing of the building where the woman lived. Bianchetti had come out of his own apartment armed. He said he usually carried his service pistol because he feared someone might break in and steal it. Police officers arrested him in his home, where he had taken refuge after the murder, and he was taken to prison, where the charges were confirmed before the investigating judge (GIP).

In total, 100 women were killed in domestic settings in 2021, while according to data from the Ministry of the Interior, in 2024 the number of domestic femicides rose to 109. Furthermore, calls for help to the anti-violence and stalking hotline 1522 increased by 12% compared to 2021.

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E.2.2 Survey Questions

Attitudes Toward Victim and Perpetrator

1. How do you feel about the victim? A score between 50 and 100 means that you feel emotionally close to her, while a score between 0 and 50 means that you do not feel emotionally close to her. Choose 50 if you do not have a particularly strong opinion either way. There is no right or wrong answer, as people may experience different emotions regarding these events. Remember, your answer to this question does not necessarily reflect your opinion about the sentence.

[Slider: 0—100]

2. How do you feel about the perpetrator? A score between 50 and 100 means that you feel emotionally close to him, while a score between 0 and 50 means that you do not feel emotionally close to him. Choose 50 if you do not have a particularly strong opinion either way. There is no right or wrong answer, as people may experience different emotions regarding these events. Remember, your answer to this question does not necessarily reflect your opinion about the sentence.

[Slider: 0—100]

Policy Support

3. In November 2023, the Parliament approved unanimously a law to counter violence against women, which included regulations regarding facilitating preventive measures such as admonition and restriction orders, education programs of police forces and the judiciary, educational programs in schools, and support for anti-violence centers. At the same time, the law does not include any additional resources dedicated to this matter. You will now have the possibility to sign a simulated petition asking for devoting some of the funds allocated to crime prevention to implement this law in the 2027 Budget Law. We will communicate to the Parliamentary commission on femicide and any form of gender-based violence the share of participants who signed this petition, namely, the number of participants who signed the petition over the total number of participants completing the survey in percentage.

[Button: I want to sign the petition]

Beliefs About Violence Against Women

4. Out of 10,000 women aged 18 to 80 in the province where you live, how many do you think have reported crimes involving any form of violence (beating, stalking, or sexual violence) in 2024?

[Slider: 0—10,000]

5. Out of 10,000 women aged 18 to 80 in the province where you live, how many contacted the anti-violence and stalking helpline to seek help in 2024?

[Slider: 0—10,000]

Note: In the questions above, participants have the chance to receive a EUR 5 bonus if their answers are close to the correct number. A random subsample of all study participants will be selected (1 in 25). For each of these participants, a computer will check whether their answers match the correct ones. If at least one of the two answers is within 5 percentage points above or below the exact value, that participant will receive the bonus.

6. Out of 10,000 women aged 18 to 80 in the province where you live, how many do you think have experienced any form of violence (beating, stalking, or sexual violence) in 2024? Please provide your best guess.

[Slider: 0—10,000]

Engagement with the Article

7. Now we will show you again the article you saw earlier, as it would appear on the newspaper's website. This means that if you click on the links below the article, you will automatically be redirected to the corresponding article (still within the questionnaire). You can continue interacting with the articles as much as you like, and at any point, proceed with the rest of the questionnaire by clicking the Next Page button.

[TREATMENT ARTICLE]

Other articles from the Gazette:

- *Focus on Violence Against Women: Inside the ISTAT Report* (Clickable)
- *Femicide: "Help, I've Been Stabbed" — The Last Words of Lorena, Killed by Her Husband in Brescia* (Clickable)
- *Asti, Murder of tobaccoist Emanuele Bianchi: 30-Year Sentences for the 5 Defendants Confirmed on Appeal* (Clickable)

8. Would you use the news outlet publishing the articles that you saw in this survey as a source of information for crime news?

- Yes
- No